Rostas

Coordinator Guide

Knox Church Waitara

November 2026

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Fair, automatic, kind rostering for churches and volunteer organisations.

What is Rostas?

Rostas is your organisation's volunteer roster assistant. It handles the time-consuming, people-sensitive work of building rosters, collecting availability, and finding replacements when someone can't make it — automatically, fairly, and kindly.

Once set up, Rostas runs most of the roster cycle on its own. Your job shifts from juggling spreadsheets and chasing people by text to simply reviewing what Rostas has prepared and pressing go.

How do I…?

The everyday jobs, each linked to its steps. Use the search box for anything else.

Getting started

- Get my volunteer list into Rostas
- Decide who sets roles and whether to ask for availability
- Set up every profile before the first build
- Build my first roster

On the Board, week to week

- Swap two volunteers
- Someone can't make it
- Choose who covers a gap yourself
- Ask someone from another roster to cover
- See all of one volunteer's dates
- Print the roster

Volunteers

- Add one new volunteer
- Import a list of volunteers
- Import volunteers from my phone's contacts
- Put a volunteer on another roster
- Put a group of volunteers on a roster at once
- Take a volunteer off a roster
- Delete several volunteers at once
- Change how often someone serves
- Make two people serve together (or never together)
- Send a volunteer their app link
- Give a volunteer a new link

Each roster cycle

- Start the next roster
- Ask volunteers when they're free
- Fill empty slots after a build
- Send the roster to volunteers
- Add an extra date (Christmas Eve, Good Friday)
- Skip a date
- Pause a roster for a while

Set-up and settings

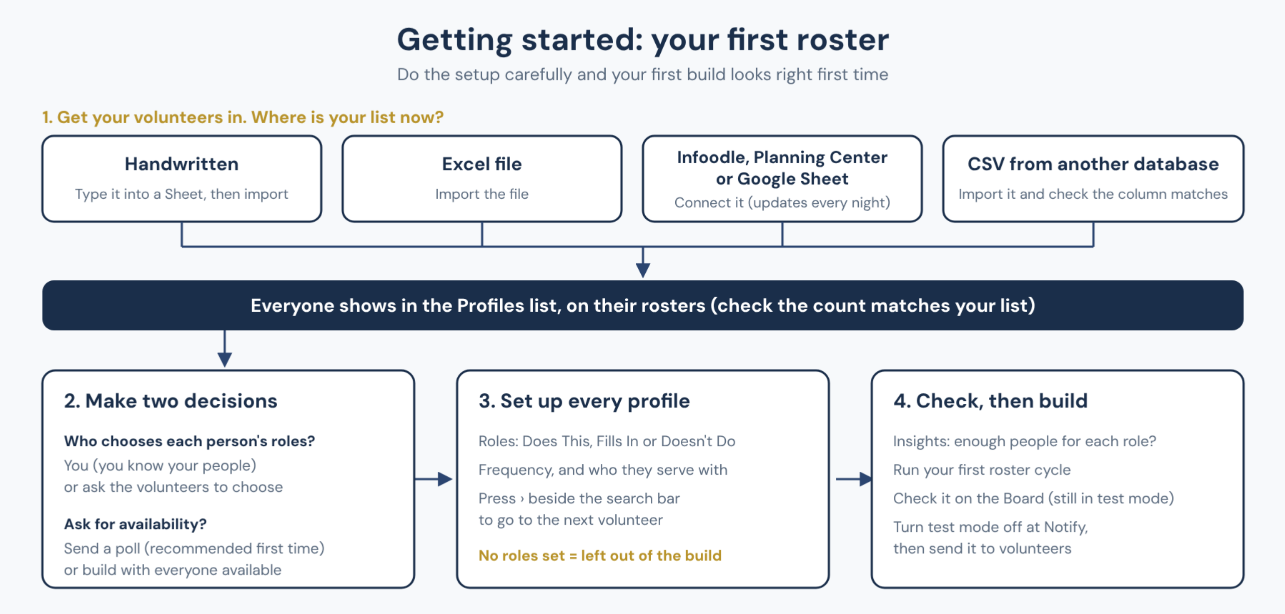
- Set up a new roster
- Add or change a role
- Buy more text credits

Something's not right

- A volunteer never got a text
- A volunteer replied to a text
- Red slots after a build
- Something else went wrong
- Look up a word (Glossary)

Getting started: your first roster

Your first roster is the one everyone judges Rostas by. When a first roster looks wrong (people in roles they don't do, or on dates they can't make), the cause is nearly always the setup work before the build, not the build itself. Do these four jobs carefully, in this order, and your first build should be fast and close to right first time.



Getting started: your first roster

Do the setup carefully and your first build looks right first time

1. Get your volunteers in. Where is your list now?

Handwritten
Type it into a Sheet, then import

Excel file
Import the file

Infoodle, Planning Center or Google Sheet
Connect it (updates every night)

CSV from another database
Import it and check the column matches

Everyone shows in the Profiles list, on their rosters (check the count matches your list)

2. Make two decisions
Who chooses each person's roles?
You (you know your people)
or ask the volunteers to choose
Ask for availability?
Send a poll (recommended first time)
or build with everyone available

3. Set up every profile
Roles: Does This, Fills In or Doesn't Do
Frequency, and who they serve with
Press › beside the search bar
to go to the next volunteer
No roles set = left out of the build

4. Check, then build
Insights: enough people for each role?
Run your first roster cycle
Check it on the Board (still in test mode)
Turn test mode off at Notify,
then send it to volunteers

The four jobs before your first build, in order.

> **Roles belong to a roster.** A volunteer's roles are set separately for each roster they serve on, so the roster and its roles need to exist first. If you haven't made your roster yet, do Set up a new roster before step 3 below.

1. Get your volunteers into Rostas

Only a name is required, but add mobile numbers and emails wherever you have them: they're how volunteers get their roster, availability requests and replacement asks. Pick the row that matches where your list lives now.

When you're done, open **Profiles** and check the number of people matches your list. If your file said which roster each person serves on, map that column during the import and they're put on their rosters for you. Otherwise click **Set roster types now** at the end of the import.

2. Make two decisions

Decide these before you open any profiles, because they decide how much of the profile work is yours.

3. Work through each profile, one by one

This is the step that makes the first roster look right. If you know your people, set each profile up yourself in one sitting:

1. Open **Profiles** and pick the roster with the pills at the top.
2. Click the first volunteer.

3. Check their mobile and email, and the **Active**, **Email** and **SMS** toggles (what each one does).
4. Set each of their roles to **Does This**, **Fills In** or **Doesn't Do** (Roles).
5. If they serve less often than every week, set their Frequency. If they should always (or never) serve with someone, set Relational rostering.
6. Press the › arrow at the top of the profile, beside the search bar, to go straight to the next volunteer. Repeat until you reach the end.

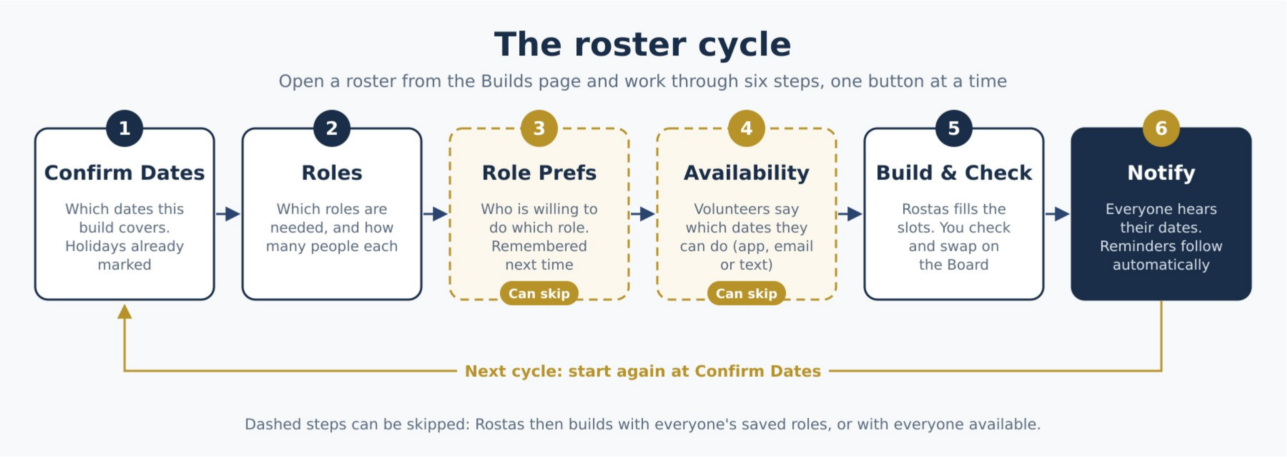
A volunteer with no roles is left out of the build. Rostas has nothing to place them in. Before you build, use the No roles set button on the Profiles page: it shows how many are left and steps through only those people.

4. Check, then build

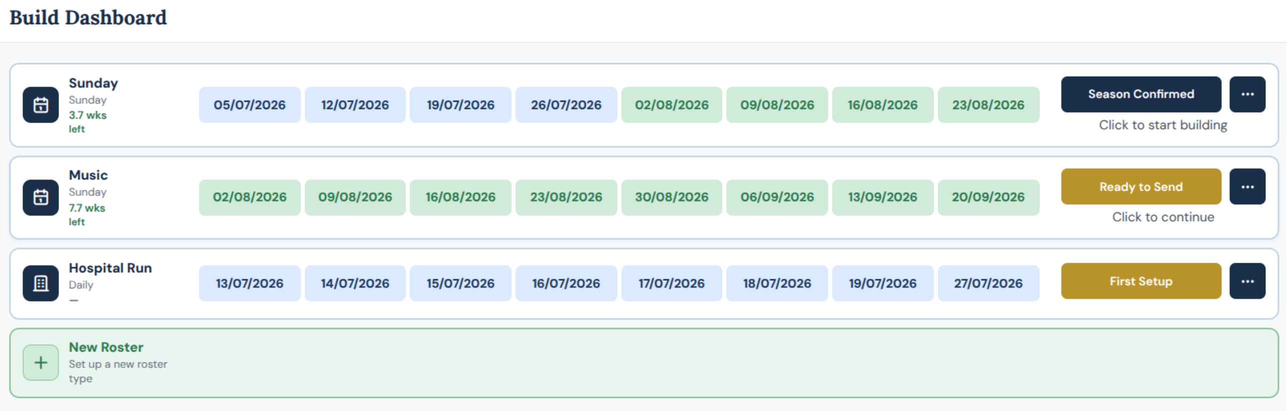
1. Open Insights for the roster. Any role with fewer **People** than it needs shows up here, before the build rather than after it.
2. Start your first roster cycle. Follow the two decisions you made in step 2 at Role Prefs and Availability.
3. Check the result on the Board before you send it. Your copy is still in test mode, so nothing reaches a volunteer until you turn test mode off at Step 6 — Notify.

How Rostas Works — The Big Picture

Rostas works in a rhythm that repeats every few weeks. The six-step roster cycle guides you through each stage in order:


The roster cycle
Open a roster from the Builds page and work through six steps, one button at a time
1
Confirm Dates
Which dates this build covers. Holidays already marked
2
Roles
Which roles are needed, and how many people each
3
Role Prefs
Who is willing to do which role. Remembered next time
Can skip
4
Availability
Volunteers say which dates they can do (app, email or text)
Can skip
5
Build & Check
Rostas fills the slots. You check and swap on the Board
6
Notify
Everyone hears their dates. Reminders follow automatically
Next cycle: start again at Confirm Dates
Dashed steps can be skipped: Rostas then builds with everyone's saved roles, or with everyone available.

The six-step roster cycle. Each step is one button on the roster's page; the dashed steps can be skipped.



Build Dashboard

Sunday Sunday 3.7 wks left	05/07/2026	12/07/2026	19/07/2026	26/07/2026	02/08/2026	09/08/2026	16/08/2026	23/08/2026	Season Confirmed Click to start building
Music Sunday 7.7 wks left	02/08/2026	09/08/2026	16/08/2026	23/08/2026	30/08/2026	06/09/2026	13/09/2026	20/09/2026	Ready to Send Click to continue
Hospital Run Daily —	13/07/2026	14/07/2026	15/07/2026	16/07/2026	17/07/2026	18/07/2026	19/07/2026	27/07/2026	First Setup

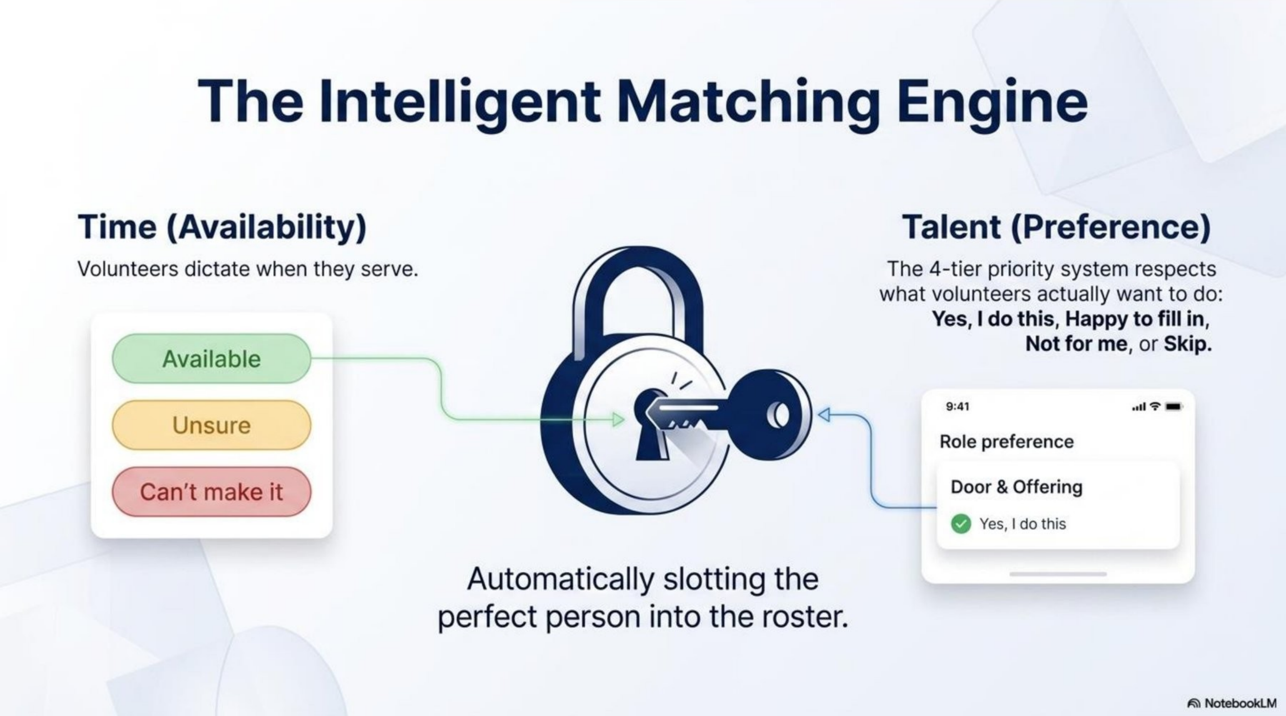
New Roster
Set up a new roster type

The Builds dashboard — your starting point for each roster cycle. Each roster type is a full-width row showing its current state, recent and upcoming dates, and a menu of actions. Click a row's state button to open its wizard.

Key Concepts

Availability — Simple for Volunteers

Before each build, Rostas can email your volunteers asking which upcoming dates they're available for. Volunteers receive a personalised link and see a simple calendar of dates. Everything starts as **Available** — volunteers only change the dates they can't make.



The Intelligent Matching Engine

Time (Availability)

Volunteers dictate when they serve.

Talent (Preference)

The 4-tier priority system respects what volunteers actually want to do: **Yes, I do this**, **Happy to fill in**, **Not for me**, or **Skip.**

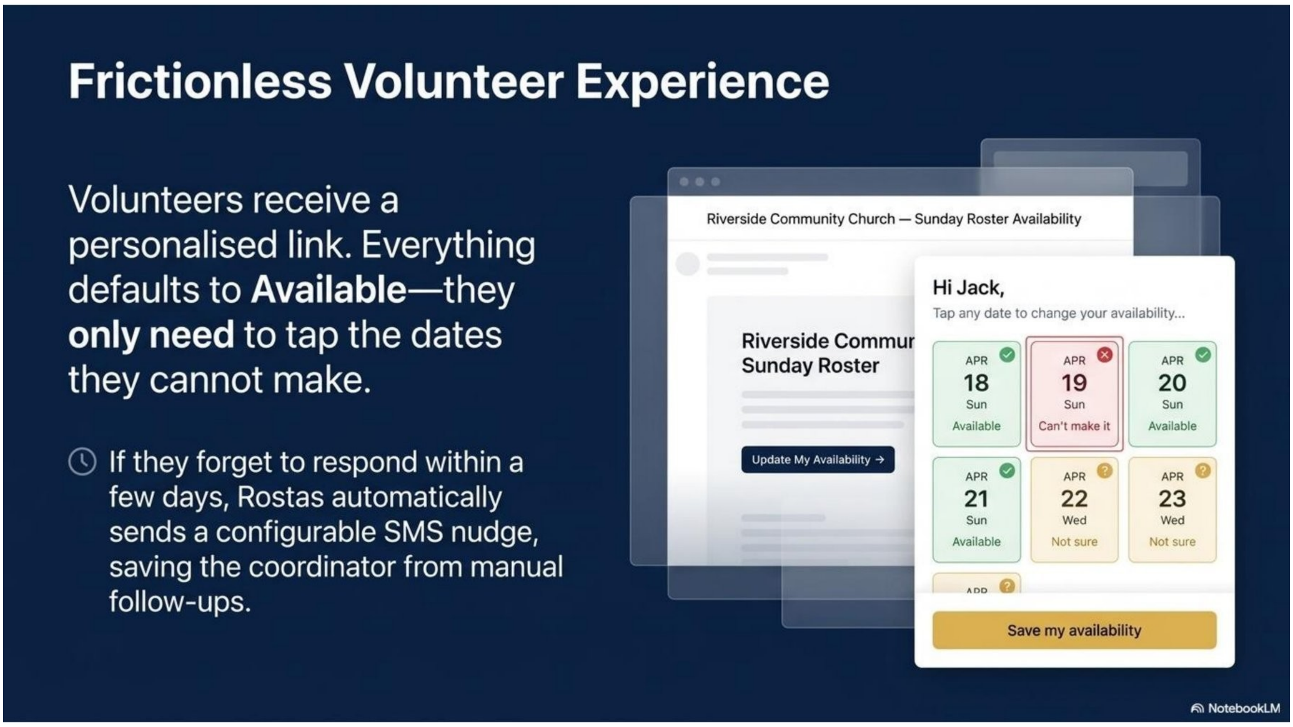
Automatically slotting the perfect person into the roster.

Volunteers tap their dates on a simple form. Everything defaults to Available — they only mark the dates they can't make.

> **If a volunteer doesn't respond**, click **Nudge** in the roster cycle. Rostas reminds them by app or email straight away, and texts anyone still silent two hours later. Nothing is texted unless you nudge. See Step 4 — Availability.

The Intelligent Matching Engine

The roster engine doesn't fill slots blindly. It uses a four-tier priority system that respects both when volunteers can serve and what they actually want to do:



Frictionless Volunteer Experience

Volunteers receive a personalised link. Everything defaults to **Available**—they **only need** to tap the dates they cannot make.

If they forget to respond within a few days, Rostas automatically sends a configurable SMS nudge, saving the coordinator from manual follow-ups.

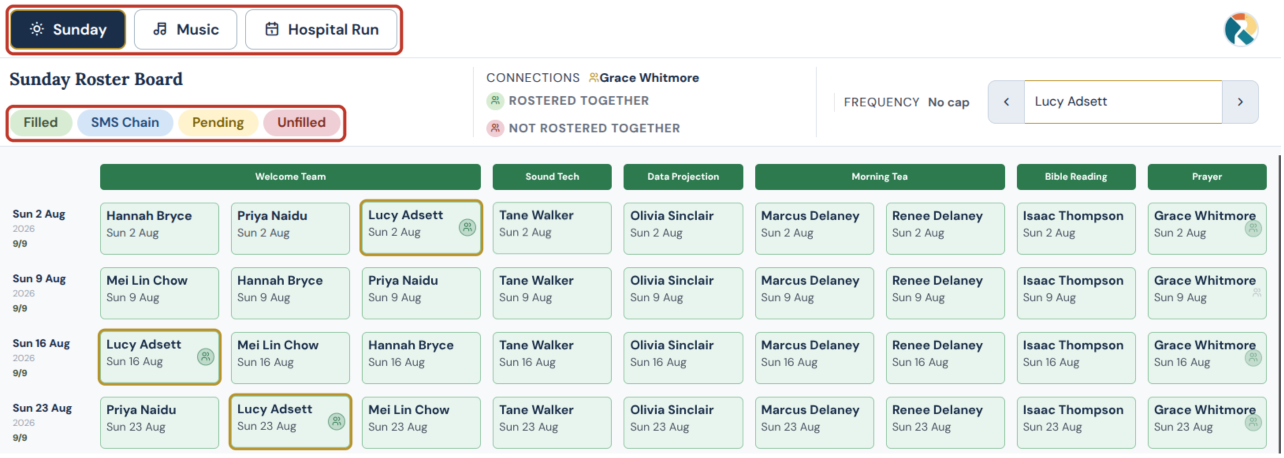
Riverside Community Church — Sunday Roster Availability
Riverside Commur
Sunday Roster
Update My Availability →
Hi Jack,
Tap any date to change your availability...
APR 18 Sun Available
APR 19 Sun Can't make it
APR 20 Sun Available
APR 21 Sun Available
APR 22 Wed Not sure
APR 23 Wed Not sure
APR
Save my availability
NotebookLM

The engine combines availability (when volunteers can serve) with role preferences (what they want to do) to find the best person for every slot.

Within each tier, Rostas picks the volunteer who has served least in recent weeks (counting all their roles), then whoever did this particular role longest ago — keeping things fair automatically over time without any manual tracking.

The Roster Board

The Board is your day-to-day view of the current roster. It shows every slot, every date, and every volunteer assignment at a glance. A traffic light colour system tells you instantly what's filled, what's pending, and what needs attention.



Sunday
Music
Hospital Run
Filled
SMS Chain
Pending
Unfilled
CONNECTIONS Grace Whitmore
ROSTERED TOGETHER
NOT ROSTERED TOGETHER
FREQUENCY No cap
‹
›

Sunday Roster Board

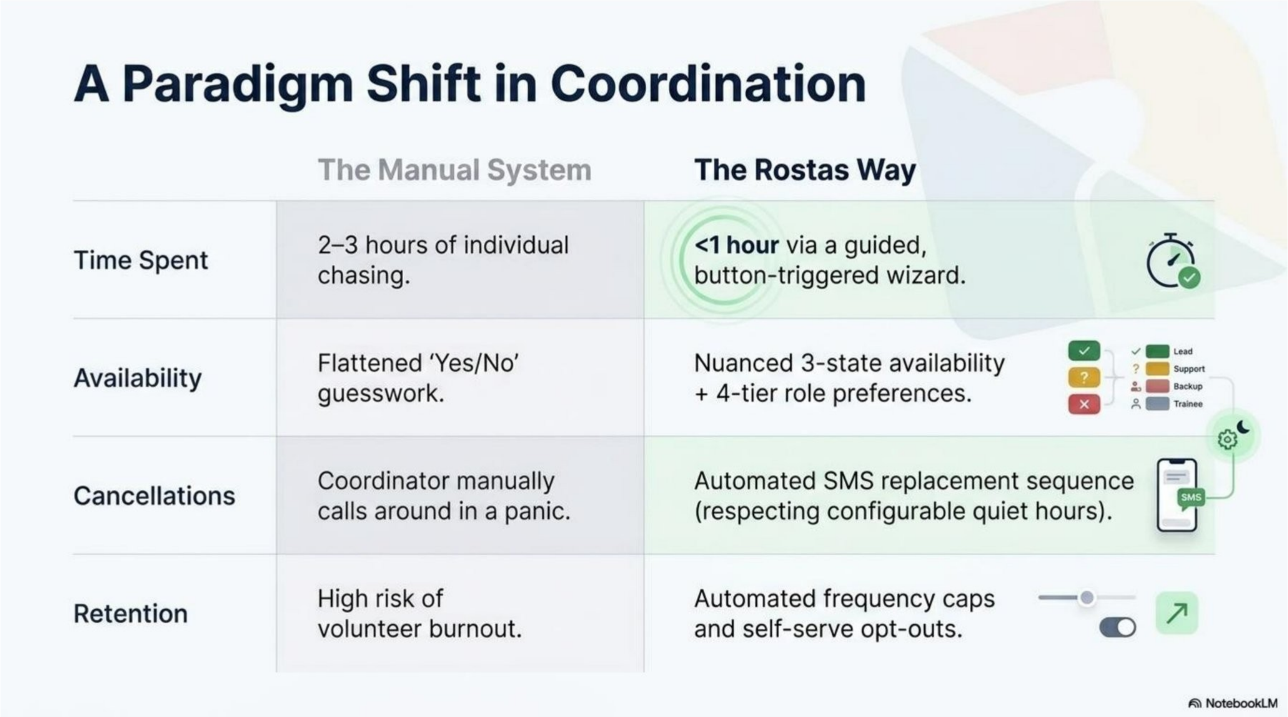
Lucy Adsett

	Welcome Team			Sound Tech	Data Projection	Morning Tea		Bible Reading	Prayer
Sun 2 Aug 2026 9/9	Hannah Bryce Sun 2 Aug	Priya Naidu Sun 2 Aug	Lucy Adsett Sun 2 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 2 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 2 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 2 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 2 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 2 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 2 Aug
Sun 9 Aug 2026 9/9	Mei Lin Chow Sun 9 Aug	Hannah Bryce Sun 9 Aug	Priya Naidu Sun 9 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 9 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 9 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 9 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 9 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 9 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 9 Aug
Sun 16 Aug 2026 9/9	Lucy Adsett Sun 16 Aug	Mei Lin Chow Sun 16 Aug	Hannah Bryce Sun 16 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 16 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 16 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 16 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 16 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 16 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 16 Aug
Sun 23 Aug 2026 9/9	Priya Naidu Sun 23 Aug	Lucy Adsett Sun 23 Aug	Mei Lin Chow Sun 23 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 23 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 23 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 23 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 23 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 23 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 23 Aug

The Roster Board — dates run down the left, roles across the top. Click any cell to select it and take action. Use the roster type tabs at the top to switch between rosters.

The Automated SMS Replacement Chain

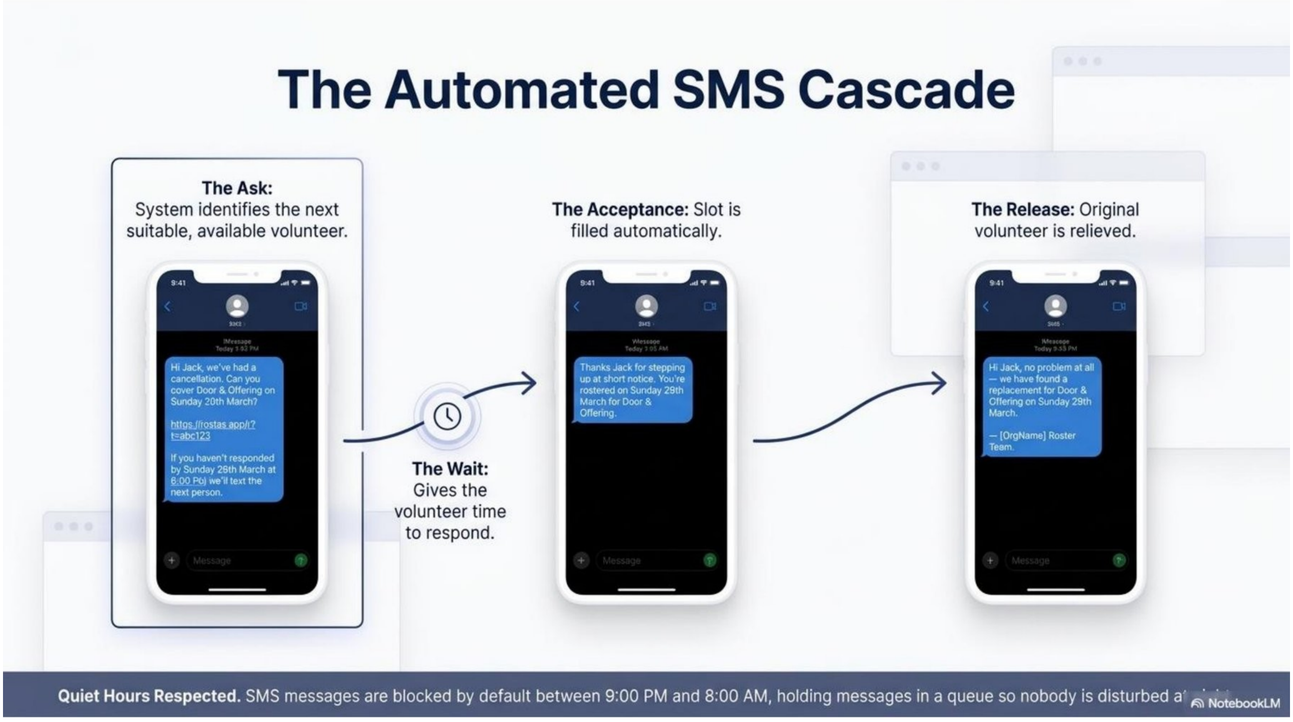
When a rostered volunteer can't make it, they tap **Can't make it** in their roster email, their reminder, or the app. Rostas immediately starts working through the backup list — no coordinator involvement needed.



A Paradigm Shift in Coordination

	The Manual System	The Rostas Way
Time Spent	2–3 hours of individual chasing.	**<1 hour** via a guided, button-triggered wizard.
Availability	Flattened 'Yes/No' guesswork.	Nuanced 3-state availability + 4-tier role preferences.
Cancellations	Coordinator manually calls around in a panic.	Automated SMS replacement sequence (respecting configurable quiet hours).
Retention	High risk of volunteer burnout.	Automated frequency caps and self-serve opt-outs.

Every notification includes a "Can't make it?" link. When tapped, the automated replacement engine starts — the coordinator's phone doesn't ring.



The Automated SMS Cascade

The Ask: System identifies the next suitable, available volunteer.

Hi Jack, we've had a cancellation. Can you cover Door & Offering on Sunday 20th March?

https://rostas.app/r?t=abc123

If you haven't responded by Sunday 26th March at 6:00 PM we'll text the next person.

The Wait: Gives the volunteer time to respond.

The Acceptance: Slot is filled automatically.

Thanks Jack for stepping up at short notice. You're rostered on Sunday 29th March for Door & Offering.

The Release: Original volunteer is relieved.

Hi Jack, no problem at all — we have found a replacement for Door & Offering on Sunday 29th March.

— [OrgName] Roster Team.

Quiet Hours Respected. SMS messages are blocked by default between 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM, holding messages in a queue so nobody is disturbed a

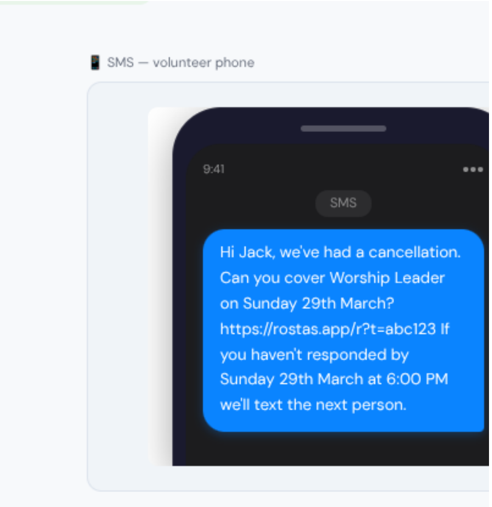
The SMS replacement chain: Rostas texts the next suitable volunteer, waits for a reply, and keeps going until the slot is filled. The original volunteer is automatically released once a replacement accepts.

> **Quiet hours are always respected.** Rostas never sends automated SMS during your quiet hours. If the replacement chain reaches a volunteer during that window, it pauses and resumes automatically once quiet hours end. You set the start and end times in Settings → Timing & behaviour (the default is 9pm–8am).

Every reply-seeking message — the automated chain above, Manual Replacement, and a Cross-Roster Ask — decides how to reach the volunteer the same way, in this order:

> You can see and edit the wording for every tier — including the app-push text and the SMS — in Settings: text wording is under **SMS**, app-notification wording under **App**, and email wording under **Email wording**.

The Tier 2 message contains a **personalised link** straight to the volunteer's accept / decline page. There's nothing to type and no separate entry page to visit — they just tap the link in the text.



Hi Jack, we've had a cancellation. Can you cover Worship Leader on Sunday 29th March? https://rostas.app/r?t=abc123 If you haven't responded by Sunday 29th March at 6:00 PM we'll text the next person.

What a replacement request looks like on a volunteer's phone — a short message with a direct link to accept or decline.

Looking After Your Volunteers

Rostas is designed with your volunteers in mind, not just your roster.

Who Does What

Rostas is designed so that most of the routine work happens automatically. Here's how responsibilities divide between you, your volunteers, and Rostas:

> **Rostas doesn't replace your judgement.** There will be times when you want to override what Rostas has built — swap two people, add someone manually, or put a slot on hold. The Board makes all of this easy. Rostas handles the routine so you can focus on the exceptions.

Where to Start

The guide is organised into seven parts and an appendix. Jump to the section that matches where you are right now:

Setting up your copy

Rostas runs in your own copy of the Rostas spreadsheet, in your Google account. Straight after you sign up, your welcome page links to a short video guide that shows every click. These are the same steps in writing, for anyone who prefers to read or needs them again later. It's easiest on a computer, not a phone.

1. Make your copy

Click **Make your copy of Rostas** on your welcome page (or in the video guide), then **Make a copy**. Your own copy of the spreadsheet opens in a new tab.

2. Let Rostas keep your copy up to date (optional)

In your new sheet, click **Share** (top right). Type **rostasapp@gmail.com**, choose **Editor**, and click **Send**. This lets Rostas send your copy fixes and new features, the same as every other church. Your copy then finishes setting each update up by itself, so once setup is done you never need to open the script editor.

> You can also share only when you need to. When we let you know that an important update is ready, share your sheet as above, wait until we confirm your copy is updated, then remove the access: click **Share**, open the menu beside **rostasapp@gmail.com** and choose **Remove access**.

3. Open the script editor

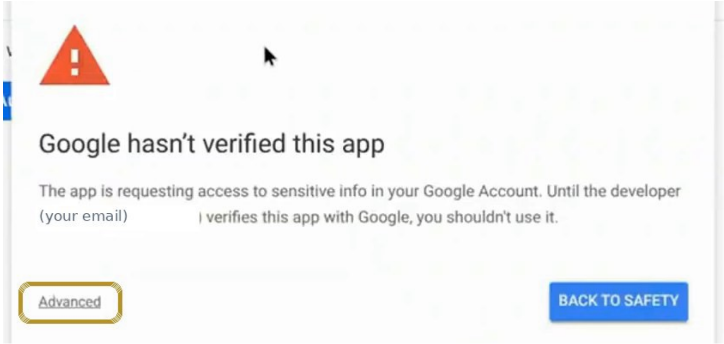
In your sheet, open the **Extensions** menu and choose **Apps Script**. It opens in another tab. You won't need to touch any code.

4. Deploy Rostas

At the top right, click **Deploy**, then **New deployment**. Click the cog beside “Select type” and choose **Web app**. Set “Execute as” to **Me** and “Who has access” to **Anyone**, then click **Deploy**.

5. Get past Google's warning

Click the blue **Authorise access** button and choose your Google account. Google then says it “hasn't verified this app”. It says this about every new copy of Rostas, because the copy you just made lives in your own Google account and Google hasn't reviewed it. Rostas is made by Rostas in Waitara, New Zealand. Click the small **Advanced** link at the bottom left.

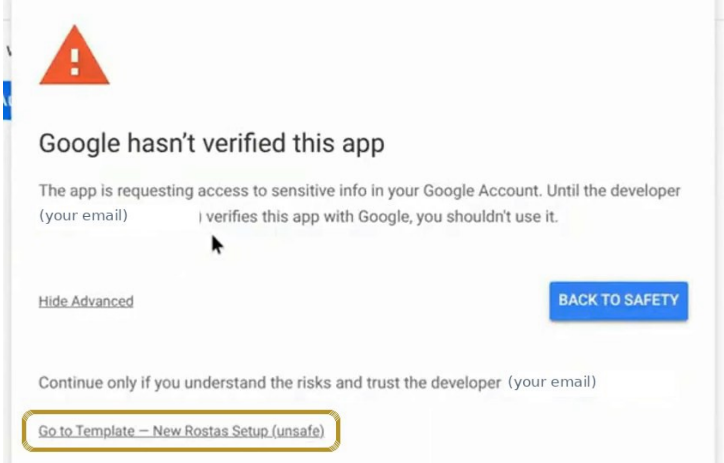


Google hasn't verified this app

The app is requesting access to sensitive info in your Google Account. Until the developer (your email) verifies this app with Google, you shouldn't use it.

Click Advanced, not Back to safety.

A new line appears underneath. Click **Go to… (unsafe)**.



Google hasn't verified this app

The app is requesting access to sensitive info in your Google Account. Until the developer (your email) verifies this app with Google, you shouldn't use it.

Continue only if you understand the risks and trust the developer (your email)

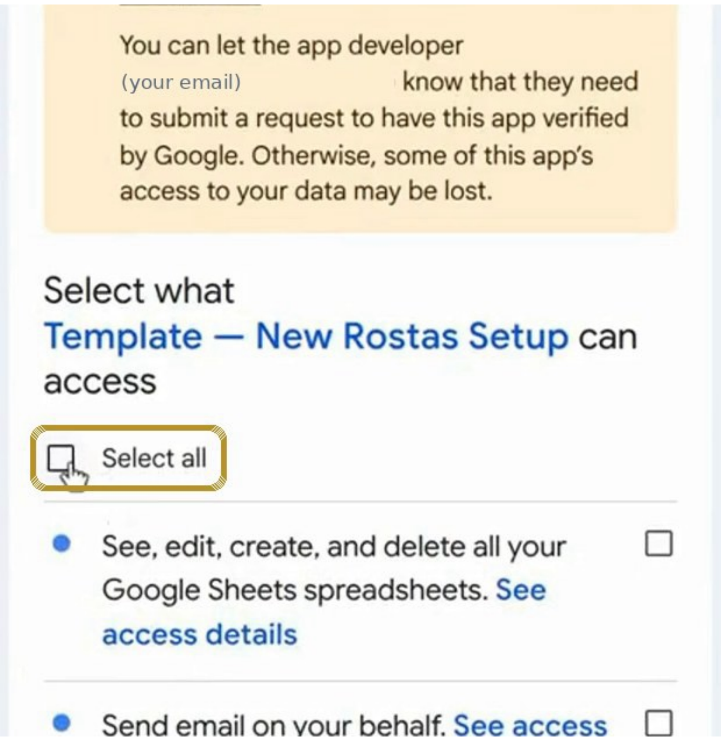
The link names your copy and ends in "(unsafe)".

If your church uses Google Workspace and you see "This app is blocked" instead, your Workspace administrator needs to allow it, or you can set Rostas up with an ordinary Gmail account.

6. Choose what to share with Rostas

A sign-in screen appears. Click **Continue**. The next screen lists what your copy of Rostas needs. Tick **Select all** at the top of the list, scroll to the bottom and click **Continue**. If you skip Select all, parts of Rostas will not work later.

"Send email on your behalf" is how Rostas sends roster reminders from your account. It can't read your email. Your rosters and volunteer list stay in your own Google Sheet (see the privacy policy).



You can let the app developer (your email) know that they need to submit a request to have this app verified by Google. Otherwise, some of this app's access to your data may be lost.

Select what Template — New Rostas Setup can access

☐ Select all

● See, edit, create, and delete all your Google Sheets spreadsheets. See access details ☐

● Send email on your behalf. See access ☐

Tick Select all before you continue.

7. Copy your Web app URL

The deployment window now shows a Deployment ID and, below it, a **Web app URL**. You need the Web app URL. Click the small **Copy** button beside it, not your browser's address bar. Save the link somewhere safe as well.

8. Open Rostas

Open a new browser tab, paste the link and press Enter. The Rostas Setup Wizard starts (see The Setup Wizard below). Bookmark this page now (Ctrl+D, or ⌘+D on a Mac), because you will open it often.

If Google says “Sorry, unable to open the file”, your browser is signed in to more than one Google account. Open the link in an Incognito window (Ctrl+Shift+N, or ⌘+Shift+N on a Mac) instead; you don't need to sign in. For everyday use, see Put Rostas on your desktop.

> **Lost the link?** Open your sheet, then **Extensions → Apps Script → Deploy → Manage deployments**, and copy the Web app URL again.

When you open Rostas for the first time, the setup wizard runs automatically. It takes about five minutes and covers the essentials — your organisation name, your contact details, and a quick SMS test to make sure everything is working before your first roster build.

The wizard runs once. After it's complete, Rostas opens directly to the Builds dashboard on every future visit.

> **Before you start:** have your Rostas licence key ready — it's in your Rostas welcome email. If someone else at your organisation has already set Rostas up, you don't need this wizard: ask them to forward you the coordinator link (see Your coordinator link).

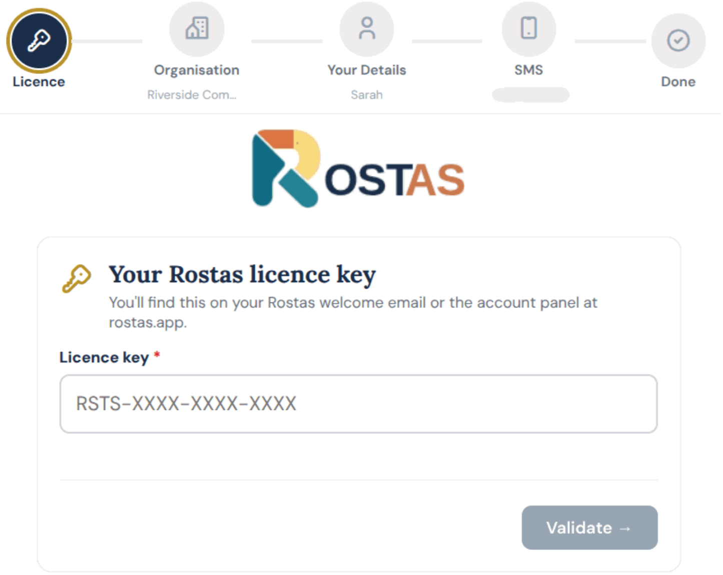
> **Signed in to more than one Google account?** If your browser is signed in to two Google accounts at once (for example your personal Gmail and the church account), the setup page won't open: you'll see **"Sorry, unable to open the file at this time"**. This is a Google limitation, not a fault in your copy. The simplest fix is to make a **Church** browser profile with only the church account in it, and do the setup there. It takes two minutes. See Put Rostas on your desktop. For a quick one-off, you can also open the setup link in a private window (Chrome: **Ctrl+Shift+N** on Windows, **⌘+Shift+N** on a Mac).

The Setup Wizard

The wizard has five steps — Licence, Organisation, Your Details, SMS and Done — shown across the top of the screen. You can see at a glance how far through you are and what's coming next.

Step 1 — Licence

Enter the licence key from your Rostas welcome email (it looks like **RSTS-XXXX-XXXX-XXXX**; you can also find it in your account at rostas.app) and click **Validate →**. Rostas checks it and moves you on to your organisation's details. If the key isn't accepted, check it for typos, then contact support@rostas.app.



Your Rostas licence key

You'll find this on your Rostas welcome email or the account panel at rostas.app.

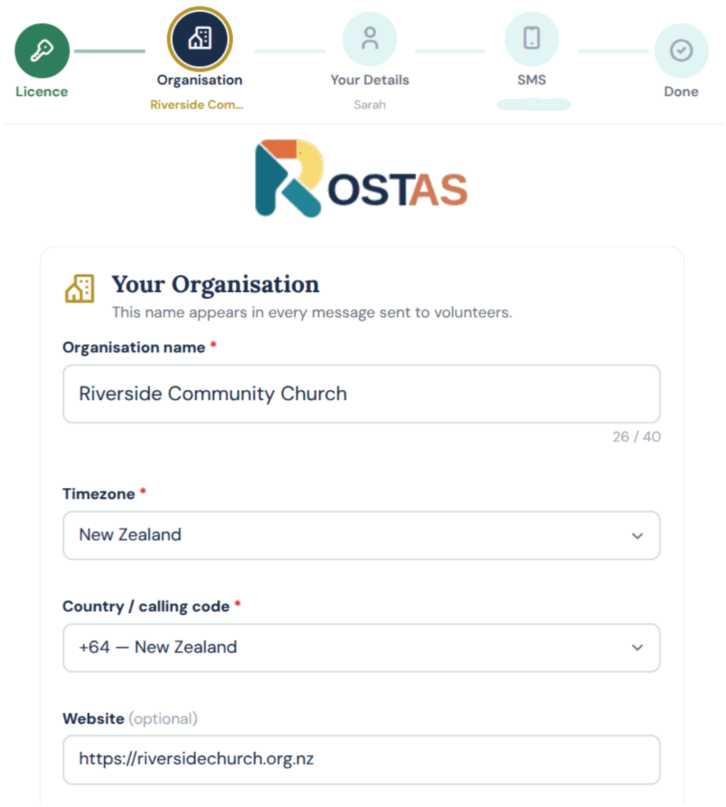
Licence key *

RSTS-XXXX-XXXX-XXXX

Step 1 — type or paste your licence key, then click Validate.

Step 2 — Your Organisation

The first step establishes your organisation's identity. The name you enter here appears in every message sent to volunteers — availability emails, roster notifications, and SMS reminders.



Your Organisation

This name appears in every message sent to volunteers.

Organisation name *: Riverside Community Church (26 / 40)

Timezone *: New Zealand

Country / calling code *: +64 — New Zealand

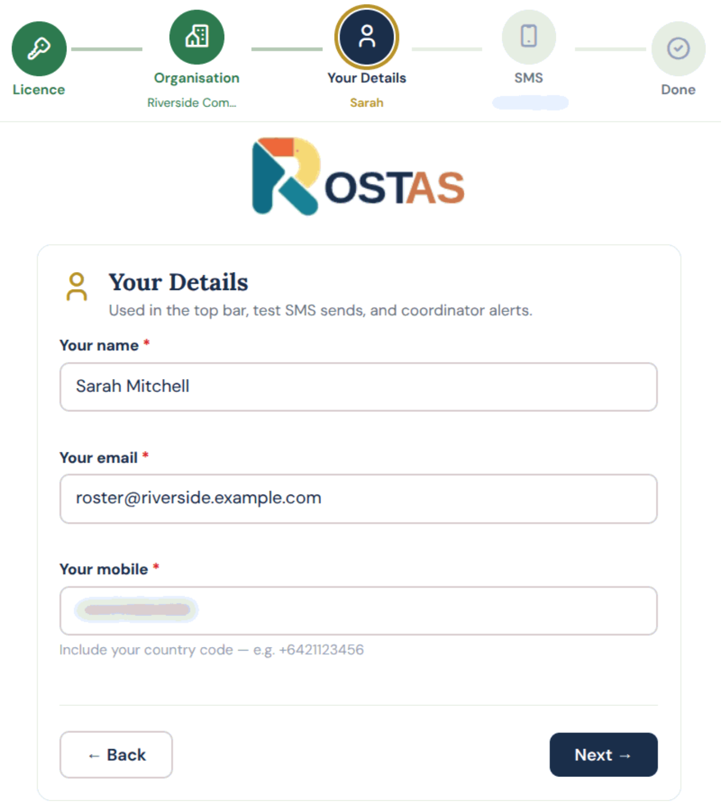
Website (optional): https://riversidechurch.org.nz

Step 2 — enter your organisation name, timezone, and country code. The name appears in every volunteer-facing message Rostas sends.

Click **Next →** when all required fields are filled. The button stays disabled until everything is valid.

Step 3 — Your Details

Step 3 captures the primary coordinator's contact details. These are used for the SMS test send, error alerts, and the bottom of the coordinator app sidebar.


Licence
Organisation
Riverside Com...
Your Details
Sarah
SMS
Done
ROSTAS

Your Details

Used in the top bar, test SMS sends, and coordinator alerts.

Your name *

Sarah Mitchell

Your email *

roster@riverside.example.com

Your mobile *

[redacted]

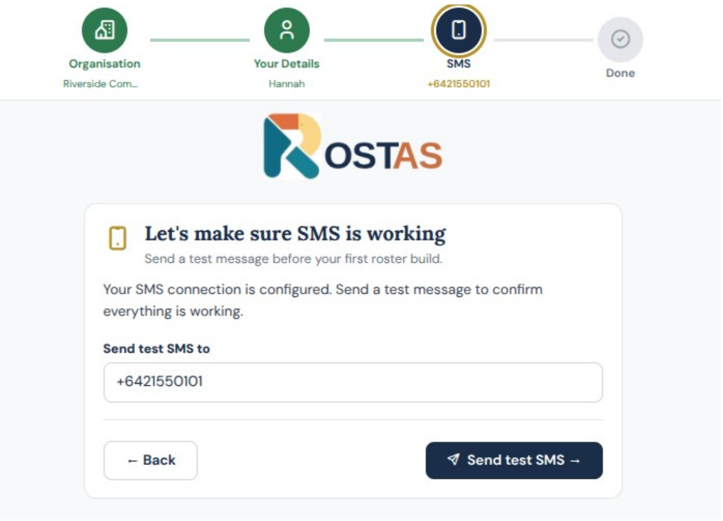
Include your country code — e.g. +6421123456

← Back
Next →

Step 3 — enter your name, email address, and mobile number. Your mobile must include the country code.

Step 4 — SMS Test

Before your first roster build, Rostas verifies that SMS is working. This step sends a real test message to your mobile so you can confirm everything is set up correctly.


Organisation
Riverside Com...
Your Details
Hannah
SMS
+6421550101
Done
ROSTAS

Let's make sure SMS is working

Send a test message before your first roster build.

Your SMS connection is configured. Send a test message to confirm everything is working.

Send test SMS to

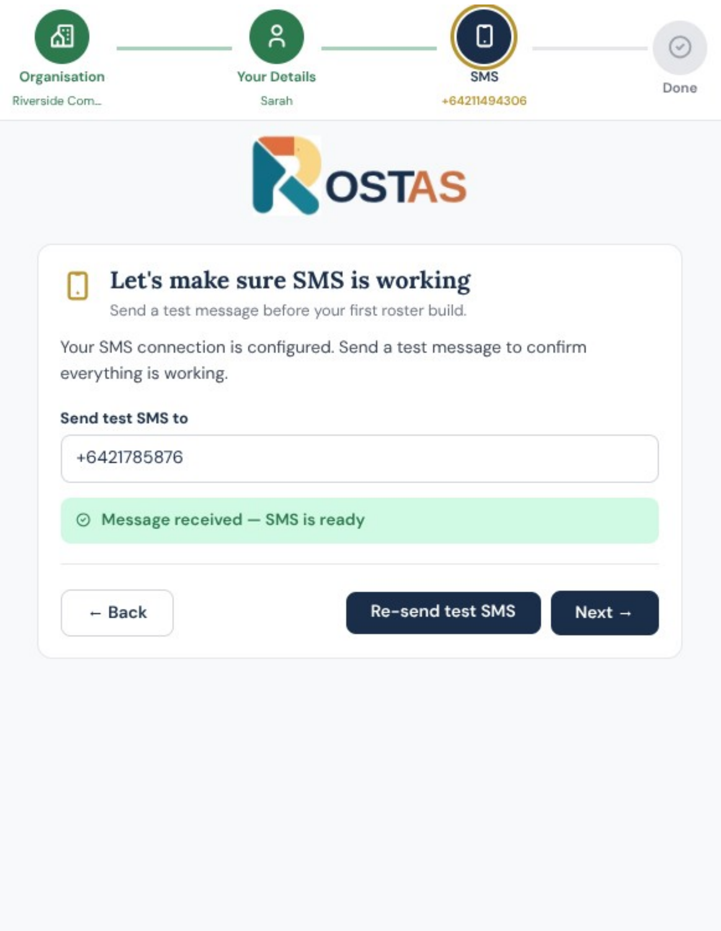
+6421550101

← Back
Send test SMS →

Step 4 — your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 3. Tap "Send test SMS" to send a real test message to your phone.

How to complete Step 4

Your mobile number is pre-filled from Step 3. Tap **Send test SMS →** and wait for the message to arrive on your phone — usually within 30 seconds. Once received, a green confirmation appears and the Next button enables.



Let's make sure SMS is working

Send a test message before your first roster build.

Your SMS connection is configured. Send a test message to confirm everything is working.

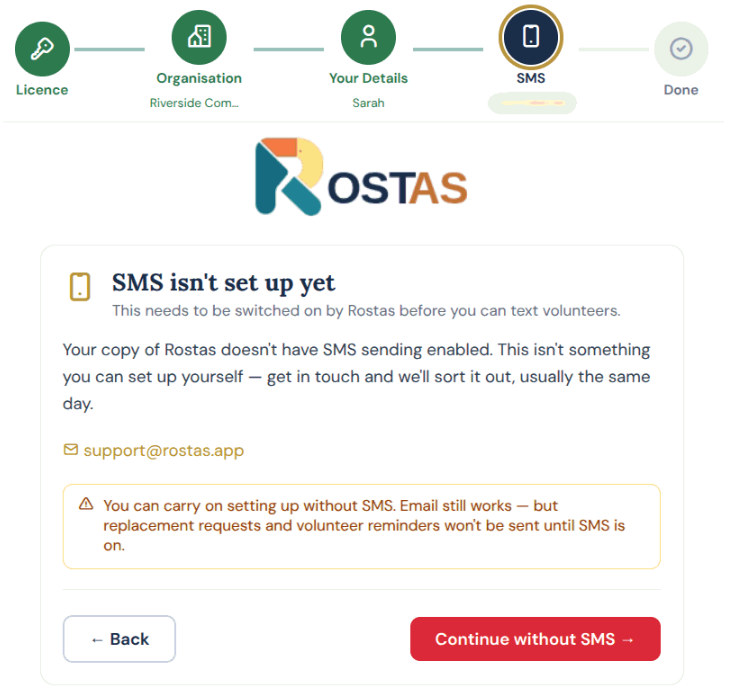
Send test SMS to: +6421785876

Message received — SMS is ready

When the test message arrives, a green "Message received — SMS is ready" confirmation appears. Tap Next to continue.

If the test message doesn't arrive within a minute, check that your mobile number is correct. You can edit the number in the field and try again. If it still fails, email support@rostas.app — SMS sending is set up by Rostas, not something you configure yourself.

If SMS isn't set up on your copy yet, Step 4 shows a "SMS isn't set up yet" screen instead of the test send, with a link to support@rostas.app and a **Continue without SMS** button. You can finish setup and start using Rostas by email — SMS replacement requests and reminders begin working once SMS is switched on. Your first 20 SMS credits are free; after that, texts use prepaid credit packs (see SMS Credits).


Licence
Organisation
Riverside Com…
Your Details
Sarah
SMS
Done
ROSTAS
← Back
Continue without SMS →

SMS isn't set up yet

This needs to be switched on by Rostas before you can text volunteers.

Your copy of Rostas doesn't have SMS sending enabled. This isn't something you can set up yourself — get in touch and we'll sort it out, usually the same day.

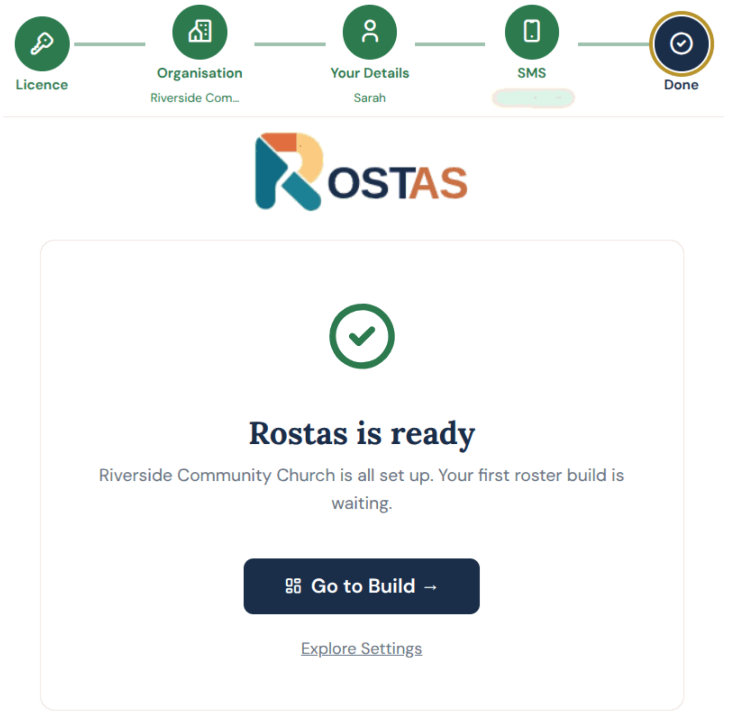
support@rostas.app

⚠ You can carry on setting up without SMS. Email still works — but replacement requests and volunteer reminders won't be sent until SMS is on.

If SMS isn't switched on for your copy yet, Step 4 looks like this. Email support@rostas.app, or click Continue without SMS and carry on.

Step 5 — Done

Once SMS is confirmed, the wizard completes and Rostas is ready to use.


Licence
Organisation
Riverside Com…
Your Details
Sarah
SMS
Done
ROSTAS
Go to Build →
Explore Settings

Rostas is ready

Riverside Community Church is all set up. Your first roster build is waiting.

"Rostas is ready" — setup is complete. Click "Go to Build" to open the Builds dashboard and start your first roster cycle.

From here you have two options:

- **Go to Build →** — takes you straight to the Builds dashboard, ready to start your first roster cycle. This is the right choice if your volunteers are already imported.
- **Explore Settings** — opens the Settings view if you want to review or customise anything before you import volunteers or do your first build.

Your coordinator link

When set-up finishes, Rostas emails you a **coordinator link** (to the Organisation email, or your own email if that's blank). This link is how you open Rostas from now on — **bookmark it** on every computer you use. It works like a password for the coordinator screens, so don't forward it to volunteers or post it anywhere.

If you open Rostas without it, you'll see a **Coordinator sign-in** box: paste your coordinator link there, or click **Email me the coordinator link** to have it sent again. A device you've signed in on remembers you, so this is usually only needed once per device.

Put Rostas on your desktop

Most coordinators use Rostas on a computer that's also signed in to their personal Google account. Google can't open Rostas when a browser has two Google accounts signed in, so the best setup is a separate **Church** profile in Chrome with only the church account in it, and a Rostas icon that always opens there. You do this once, and from then on you just click the icon.

Part 1 — Make a Church profile in Chrome

1. Open Chrome as normal.
2. Click your **profile picture** at the top right, just left of the three dots (if you have no picture, it's a small round person outline).
3. Click **Add** (some versions say **Add Chrome profile**).
4. In the new window, click **Sign in** and sign in with the **church Google account only**, the one that owns your copy of Rostas. Don't add any other accounts to this profile.
5. If Chrome asks **"Turn on sync?"**, either answer is fine.
6. Name the profile **Church** and pick a different colour, so you can tell its windows apart, then click **Done**.

Part 2 — Install Rostas as an app

1. In the **Church** window (check the name and colour at the top right), open your coordinator link and wait for Rostas to load.
2. Click the **three dots** (top right) → **Cast, save and share → Install page as app…**
3. Name it **Rostas** and click **Install**. Rostas opens in its own window, with the Rostas **R** as its icon.

Always open Rostas from the icon. It always opens in your Church profile, so it works even while your normal Chrome is signed in to other Google accounts, and it keeps working after a restart. If you ever click a Rostas link elsewhere and see "Sorry, unable to open the file", close that tab and use the icon

> instead.

What's Next

Rostas is set up. Next, get your volunteers in: head to **Part C — Profiles** to import or add them and set up how each one serves. Once your profiles are in, **Part E — The Roster Cycle** walks you through building your first roster.

- ✓ Organisation name set
- ✓ Coordinator contact details set
- ✓ SMS test confirmed working
- Volunteers imported or added
- Full profile set up for each volunteer in your first roster build
- SMS and Email test modes turned off, just before you send your first real roster

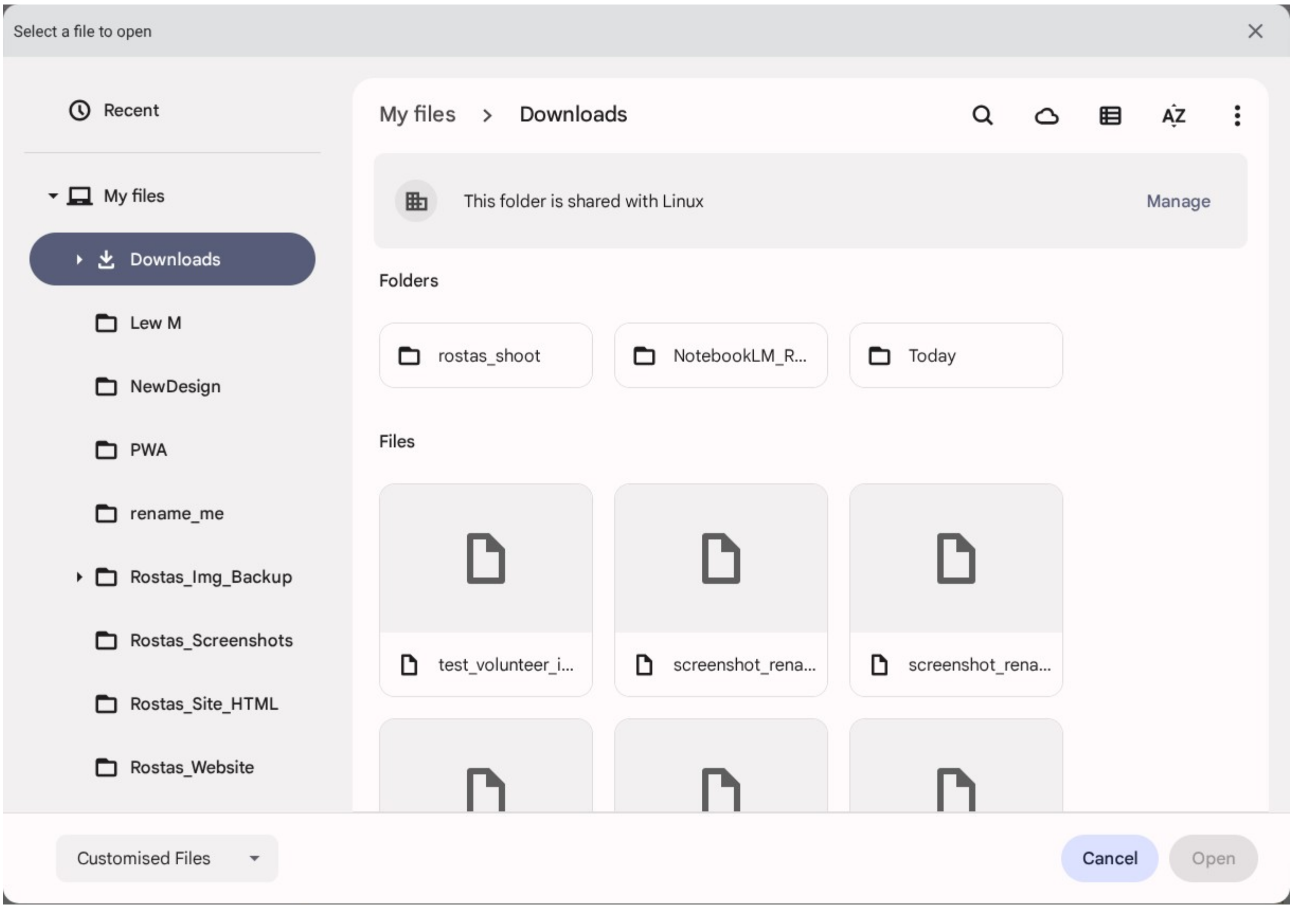
Your copy starts in test mode. A new copy of Rostas has **SMS test mode** and **Email test mode** switched on, so nothing reaches a volunteer while you set up and try things out: texts go to the coordinator's phone and emails come to you. The Status page shows an amber warning for each one while it's on. Leave them on while you import volunteers and try a build. **Turn them off just before you send your first real roster** (Step 6 — Notify): click **Turn off test mode** beside each warning on the Status page, or switch them off in Settings → Quick Controls. While a test mode is on, every volunteer's message for that channel comes to you instead.

The Profiles section is where you manage everyone who serves in your organisation. Access it by clicking **Profiles** in the sidebar. From here you can view all volunteers, add new ones, edit details, view role lists, and manage per-roster settings like role preferences, frequency caps, and availability.

Importing your volunteers from CSV

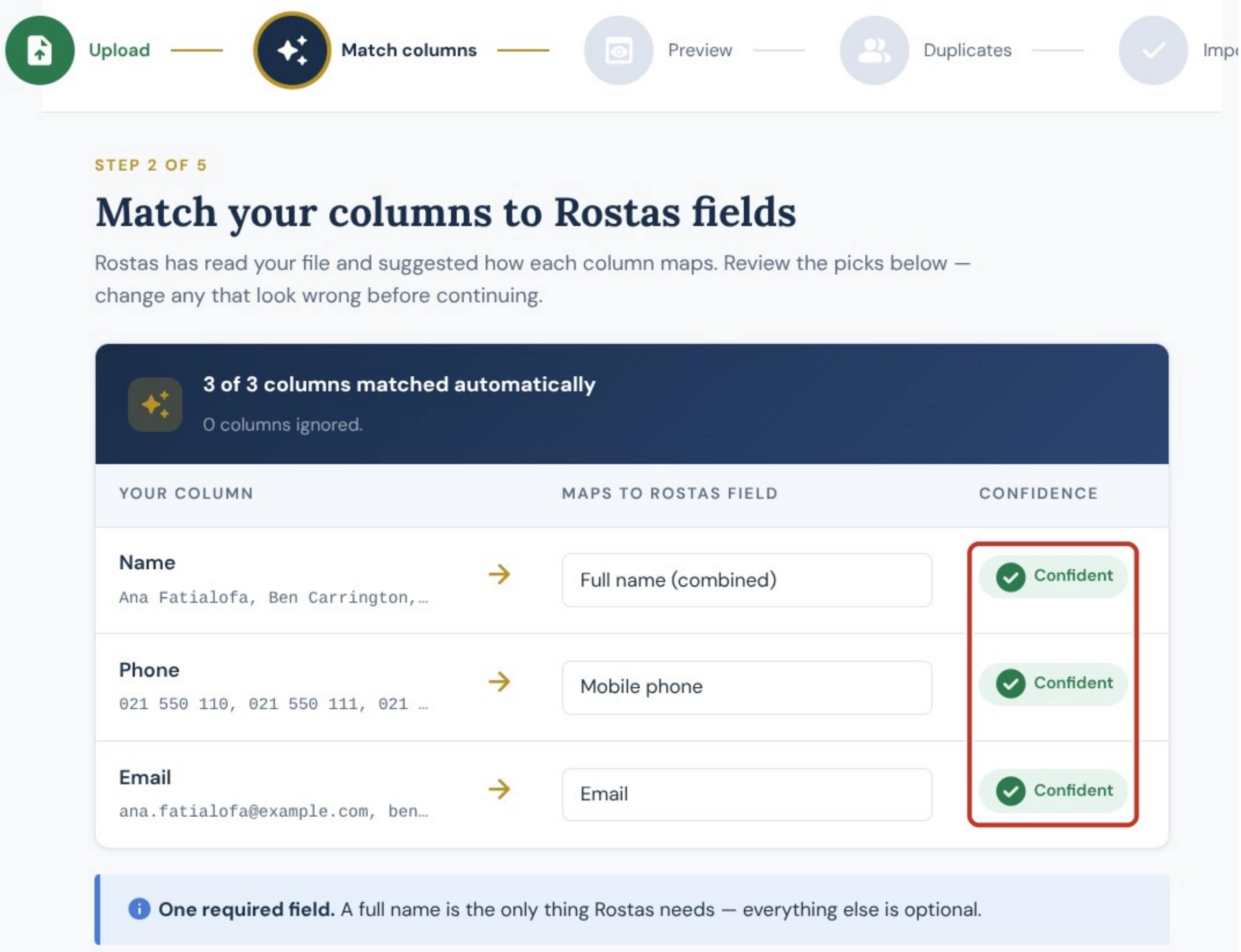
The quickest way to get your volunteers into Rostas is to import a spreadsheet — from a previous roster system, a church database, or even a simple contact list. This is how most organisations start. If your volunteers already live in another system, or in a Google Sheet you keep up to date, you can sync them automatically instead — see the Connector Appendix.

1. Open **Profiles** and click **Import Volunteer CSV** on the toolbar.
2. Click **Choose a file** and pick your spreadsheet, or drag the file onto the page.


Select a file to open
Recent
My files
Downloads
Lew M
NewDesign
PWA
rename_me
Rostas_Img_Backup
Rostas_Screenshots
Rostas_Site_HTML
Rostas_Website
My files > Downloads
This folder is shared with Linux
Manage
Folders
rostas_shoot
NotebookLM_R...
Today
Files
test_volunteer_i...
screenshot_rena...
screenshot_rena...
Customised Files
Cancel
Open

Pick your spreadsheet file.

3. Click **Continue to matching**.
4. Check how each of your columns has been matched, and change any that look wrong.



STEP 2 OF 5

Match your columns to Rostas fields

Rostas has read your file and suggested how each column maps. Review the picks below — change any that look wrong before continuing.

3 of 3 columns matched automatically

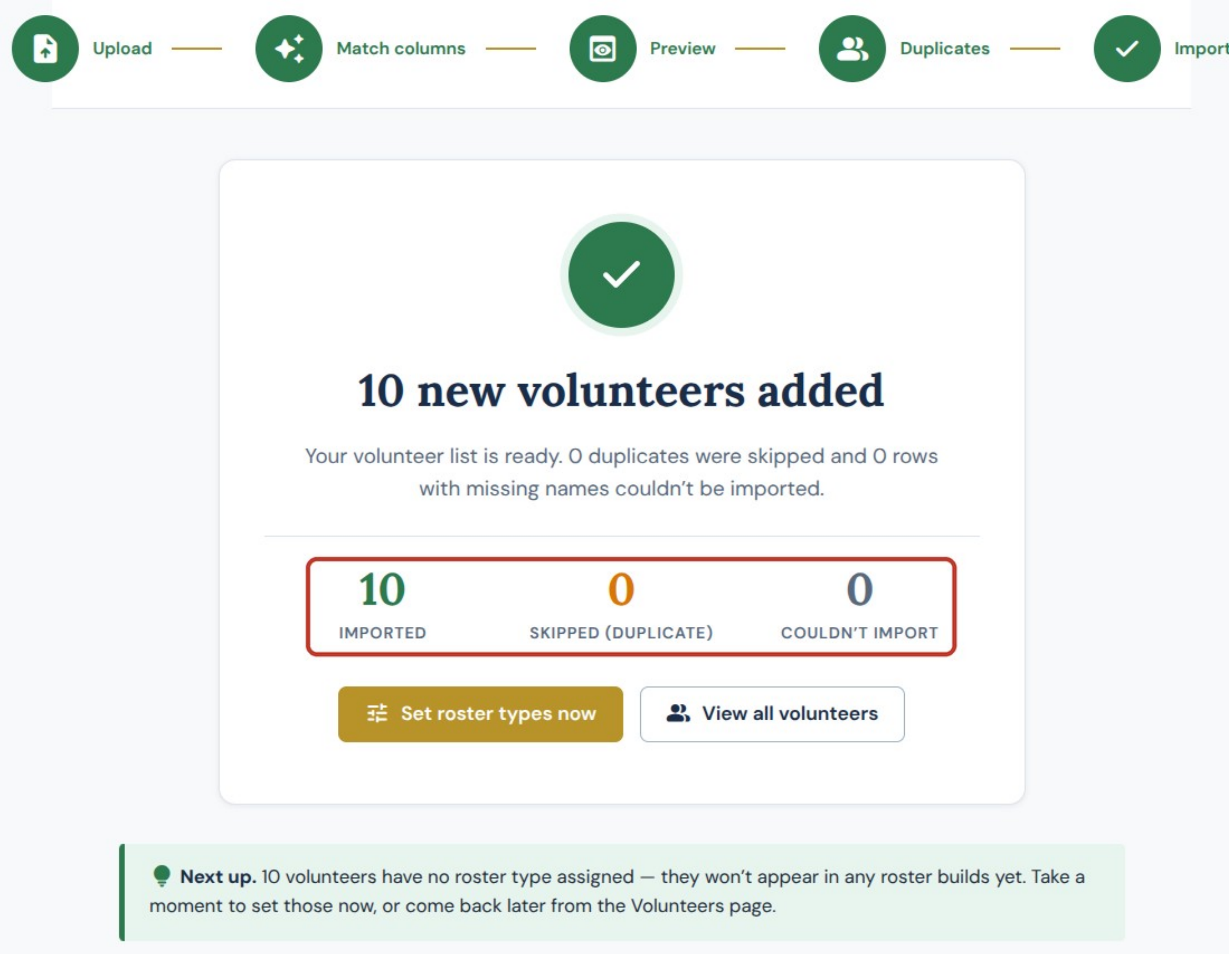
0 columns ignored.

YOUR COLUMN		MAPS TO ROSTAS FIELD	CONFIDENCE
Name `Ana Fatialofa, Ben Carrington,…`	→	Full name (combined)	✓ Confident
Phone `021 550 110, 021 550 111, 021 …`	→	Mobile phone	✓ Confident
Email `ana.fatialofa@example.com, ben…`	→	Email	✓ Confident

One required field. A full name is the only thing Rostas needs — everything else is optional.

Rostas matches the columns it recognises. Check the Confidence column and change any match that looks wrong.

5. Click **Preview [N] volunteers** and look over the list.
6. Click **Check for duplicates**.
7. If anyone is already in Rostas, choose **Skip duplicates** (recommended) or **Update existing records**.
8. Click **Import [N] volunteers**. A summary shows how many were added. They're in the Profiles list straight away.



10 new volunteers added

Your volunteer list is ready. 0 duplicates were skipped and 0 rows with missing names couldn't be imported.

10	0	0
IMPORTED	SKIPPED (DUPLICATE)	COULDN'T IMPORT

Next up. 10 volunteers have no roster type assigned — they won't appear in any roster builds yet. Take a moment to set those now, or come back later from the Volunteers page.

The summary: how many were imported, skipped as duplicates, or couldn't be imported.

9. Click **Set roster types now** to put the new volunteers on their rosters, or **View all volunteers** to do it later.

> **Only a name is required.** Include mobile numbers and emails if you have them, so volunteers can get texts, availability requests and notifications. If your spreadsheet has a column for roster type, map it during the import and volunteers are assigned to the right rosters automatically. Phone numbers missing a country code are corrected for you.

Importing a list of volunteers from your phone's contacts

If you don't have a spreadsheet to import — or you just want a quick way to try Rostas out — you can import straight from your phone's Contacts app. Rostas reads a **vCard** file (`.vcf`), the standard format every phone uses to export contacts. It's the same Import Wizard as a CSV, just a different file type in step 1.

1. Export your contacts as a vCard file.

Your phone	How to export
iPhone	Open icloud.com/contacts in a browser and sign in. Select all your contacts, click the ⚙ gear in the bottom-left corner, then choose **Export vCard**. One `.vcf` file downloads with everyone in it.
Android	Open the **Contacts** app, open the menu (⋮), choose **Settings → Export**, then **.vcf file**. Save it to your device's Downloads, or to Google Drive if you'd rather fetch it from there.

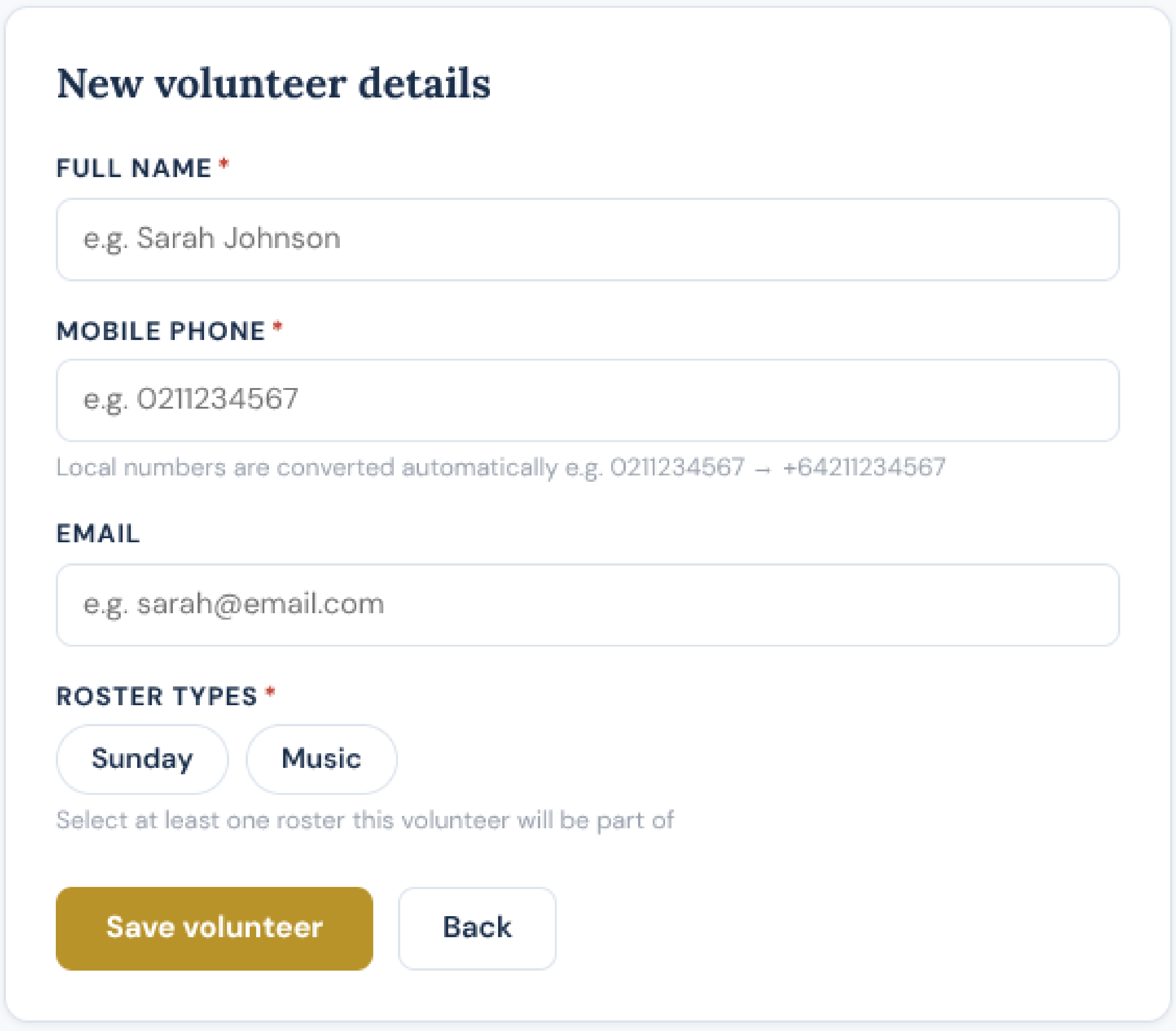
2. Get the `.vcf` file onto the computer you'll use to sign in to Rostas, if it isn't there already — email it to yourself, AirDrop it, or download it from Google Drive.
3. Open **Profiles** and click **Import Volunteer CSV** on the toolbar, then **Choose a file** and pick your `.vcf` file (or drag it onto the page). The page shows "*N* contacts" instead of rows and columns, so you know it's read it as a vCard.
4. Continue through **Match columns**, **Preview**, **Duplicates** and **Import** exactly as for a CSV — see Importing your volunteers from CSV above for what each of those screens does.

> **One phone number and one email per person.** A contact with several numbers or addresses (home, work, mobile) brings in just one of each: a mobile beats a landline, and whichever is marked "preferred" on your phone wins a tie. Nothing with roster types comes from a phone's contacts, so everyone imported this way is added with no roster — click **Set roster types now** at the end, or leave them until you're ready.

Adding a volunteer manually

For one new volunteer between imports:

1. Open **Profiles** and click **Add Volunteer** on the toolbar.
2. Type their **Full name** and **Mobile phone**. A local number such as 021 123 4567 is converted for you.
3. Type their **Email**, if they have one.
4. Under **Roster types**, click each roster they serve in.
5. Click **Save volunteer**. They appear in the list straight away and are included in your next build.


New volunteer details

FULL NAME *

e.g. Sarah Johnson

MOBILE PHONE *

e.g. 0211234567

Local numbers are converted automatically e.g. 0211234567 → +64211234567

EMAIL

e.g. sarah@email.com

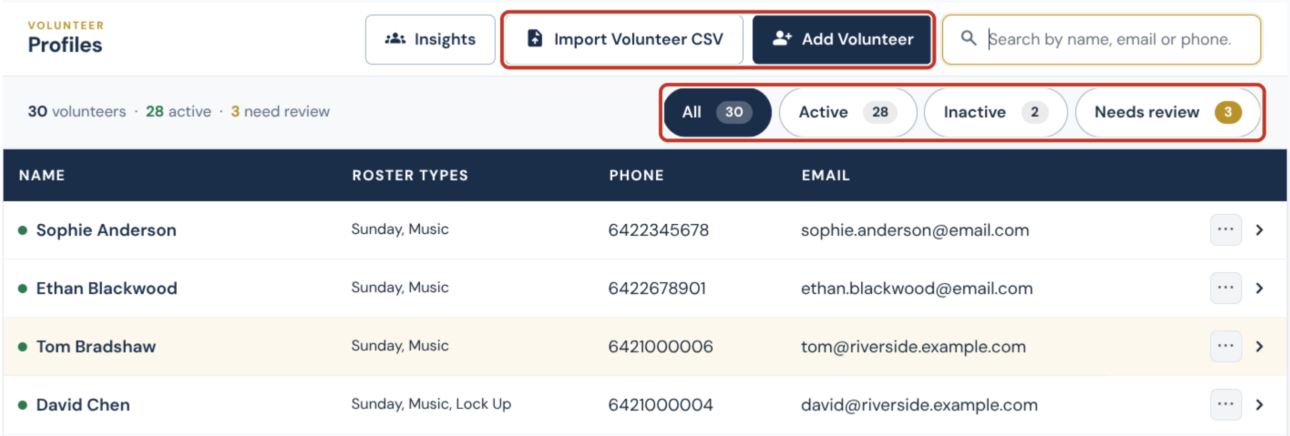
ROSTER TYPES *

Select at least one roster this volunteer will be part of

The Add Volunteer form.

The profiles list

Once your volunteers are in, the Profiles list shows everyone — name, roster types, phone, and email — in one place. Search by name, email, or phone, or filter by Roster Type at the top of the page, or Active, Inactive, or All using the chips below the search bar. Click any row to open that volunteer's profile.



30 volunteers · 28 active · 3 need review

NAME	ROSTER TYPES	PHONE	EMAIL
● Sophie Anderson	Sunday, Music	6422345678	sophie.anderson@email.com
● Ethan Blackwood	Sunday, Music	6422678901	ethan.blackwood@email.com
● Tom Bradshaw	Sunday, Music	6421000006	tom@riverside.example.com
● David Chen	Sunday, Music, Lock Up	6421000004	david@riverside.example.com

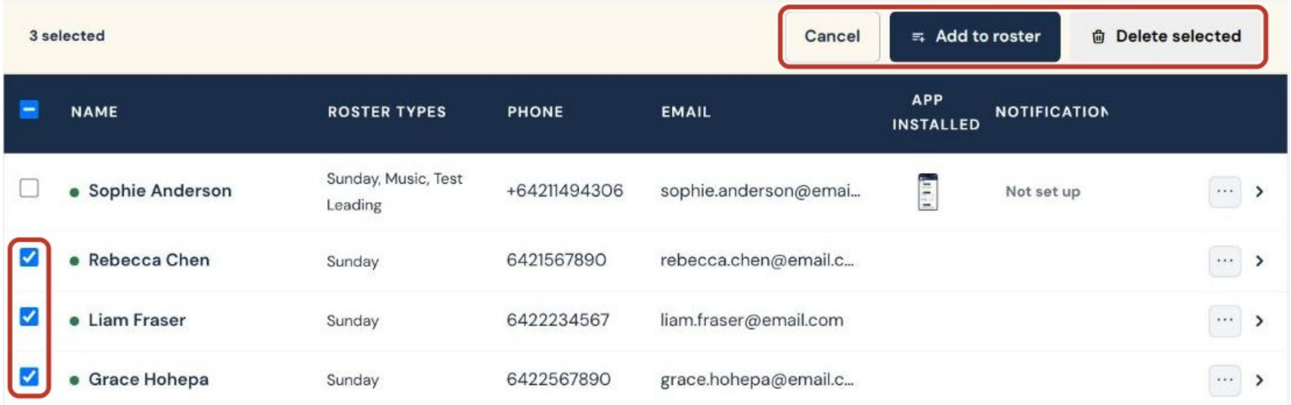
The Profiles list — everyone in one place. The toolbar holds Import Volunteer CSV and Add Volunteer; click any row to open a profile.

> **Click any row** to open that volunteer's full profile — where you edit their details, set the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with, and view their availability.

Working with several volunteers at once

Every row in the Profiles list has a tick box on the far left. Tick several people and you can put them all on a roster, or delete them all, in one go, instead of opening each profile in turn. It's handy after an import, when a whole group (say, everyone from the music team's spreadsheet) needs adding to the Music roster, or when you're clearing out people who have left.

1. Tick the box beside each volunteer you want. To pick everyone on screen, tick the box in the header row instead.
2. A bar appears above the list showing how many you've selected, with **Add to roster**, **Delete selected** and **Cancel**.
3. Choose what to do (both are explained below), or click **Cancel** to untick everyone.



3 selected

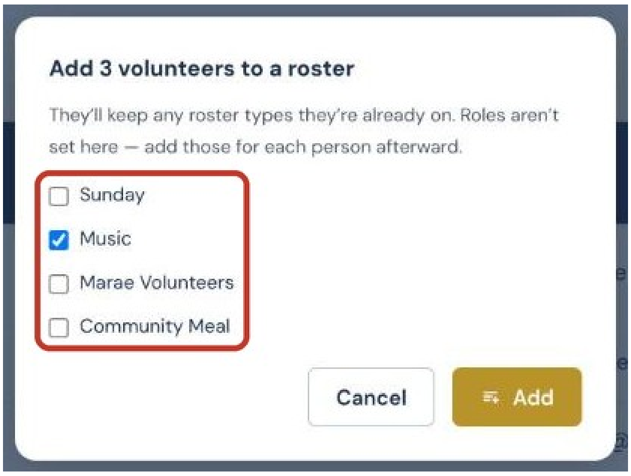
☐	NAME	ROSTER TYPES	PHONE	EMAIL	APP INSTALLED	NOTIFICATION		
☐	● Sophie Anderson	Sunday, Music, Test Leading	+64211494306	sophie.anderson@emai...	📱	Not set up	···	›
☑	● Rebecca Chen	Sunday	6421567890	rebecca.chen@email.c...			···	›
☑	● Liam Fraser	Sunday	6422234567	liam.fraser@email.com			···	›
☑	● Grace Hohepa	Sunday	6422567890	grace.hohepa@email.c...			···	›

Three volunteers ticked. The bar above the list says how many are selected and holds the actions.

> **Narrow the list first, then tick the header box.** Search, the roster pills and the Active / Inactive chips all work with the tick boxes, and the header box only ticks the people you can see. For example, choose *Inactive* and tick the header box to select everyone who's inactive. If a search or filter hides someone you'd ticked, they're unticked straight away, so you'll never act on anyone who isn't on screen.

Adding a group to a roster

1. Tick the volunteers, then click **Add to roster**.
2. A box lists every roster your church runs. Tick one or more: you can add the whole group to several rosters at once.
3. Click **Add**. The list reloads, and the new roster types show in each person's Roster types column.



Add 3 volunteers to a roster

They'll keep any roster types they're already on. Roles aren't set here — add those for each person afterward.

☐ Sunday
☑ Music
☐ Marae Volunteers
☐ Community Meal

Tick each roster to add the group to. Rosters they're already on stay as they are.

Adding never takes anyone off a roster. A volunteer already on Sunday who you add to Music ends up on both. If someone was taken off a roster earlier, adding them again puts them back on it.

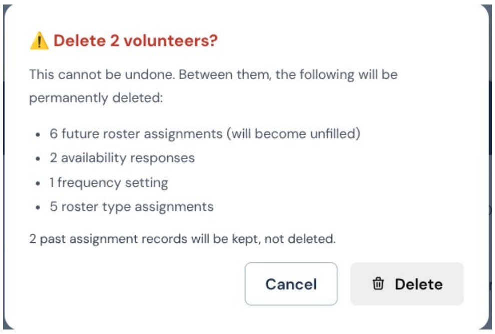
> **Add to roster doesn't set roles.** The group is on the roster, but nobody has any roles on it yet, and a volunteer with no roles is left out of builds. Straight afterwards, pick that roster's pill and use No roles set to step through just those

> people and choose their roles.

Deleting several volunteers

Use this for people who have left for good. If someone is only taking a break, turn off Active on their profile instead. That keeps their history and settings for when they come back.

1. Tick the volunteers, then click **Delete selected**. Rostas takes a moment to check them.
2. A box tells you how many volunteers will be deleted and what goes with them: their future roster assignments (those dates become unfilled), availability answers, frequency settings, roster types, and any buddy or household links other volunteers have to them.
3. Read it, then click **Delete**, or **Cancel** to change your mind. The list reloads without them.



⚠ **Delete 2 volunteers?**

This cannot be undone. Between them, the following will be permanently deleted:

- 6 future roster assignments (will become unfilled)
- 2 availability responses
- 1 frequency setting
- 5 roster type assignments

2 past assignment records will be kept, not deleted.

Before anything is deleted, Rostas adds up what goes with the people you ticked. Past assignments are kept.

> **This can't be undone.** Their past assignments are kept, so your record of who served on past dates stays correct. Everything else listed in the box is removed for good. Check the future assignments count: those dates will need someone new.

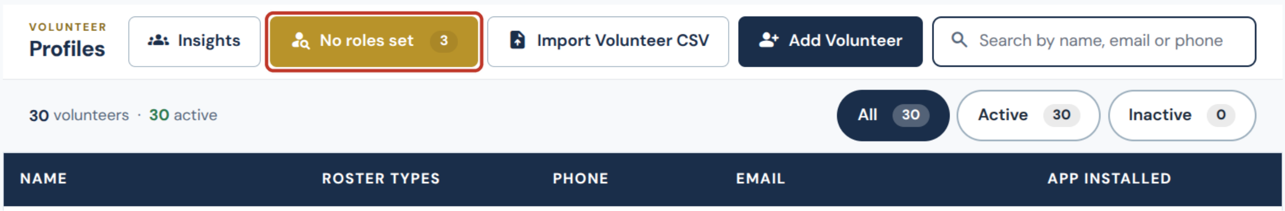
Volunteers synced from Infoodle or Planning Center are skipped. Your database owns these people, so Rostas won't delete them here. The box names anyone it's leaving out. Remove them in Infoodle or Planning Center, or turn off Active for them in Rostas. The exception is someone already marked *Deleted in Infoodle* (or deleted in Planning Center): they can be deleted here. If everyone you ticked is synced, Rostas says nothing can be deleted and suggests deactivating them instead.

Finding volunteers with no roles set

A volunteer who is ticked for a roster but hasn't been given any roles on it is left out of that roster's builds — Rostas has nothing to place them in. The **No roles set** button finds these people so you can set their roles in one sitting.

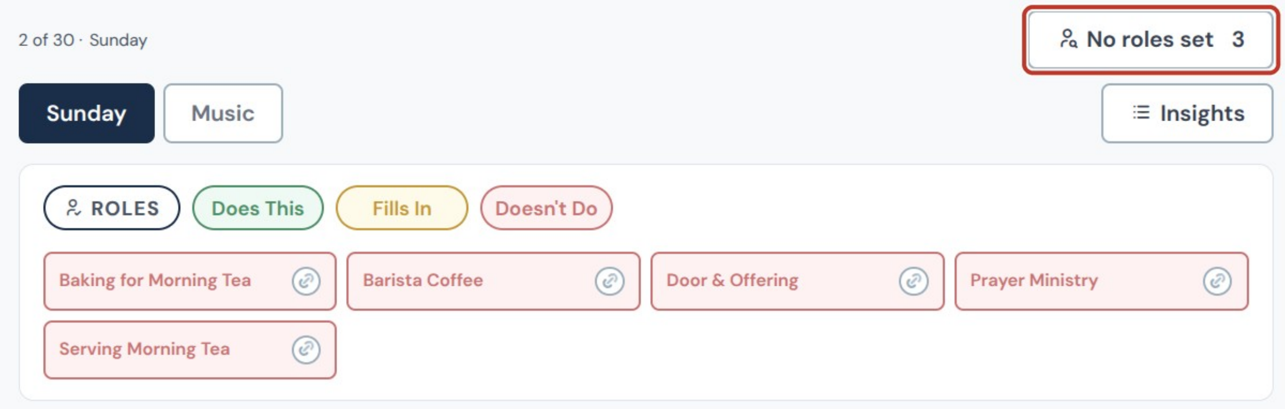
1. Pick a roster using the pills at the top of the Profiles page. The **No roles set** button next to Insights shows how many volunteers on that roster still have no roles.
2. Click the button. The list narrows to just those volunteers, and the button turns gold. Click it again to see everyone.

3. Click a name to open their profile. A bar at the top shows *No roles set*, the roster, and where you are in the list (for example "volunteer 2 of 3").
4. Choose their roles and save. Then press **Next** — the arrows now step only through the volunteers who still have no roles, and anyone you've just set up drops off the list.
5. When you're finished, click **Back to Profiles** in the bar.


VOLUNTEER
Profiles
Insights
No roles set 3
Import Volunteer CSV
Add Volunteer
Search by name, email or phone
30 volunteers · 30 active
All 30
Active 30
Inactive 0
NAME
ROSTER TYPES
PHONE
EMAIL
APP INSTALLED

The No roles set button, with the number of volunteers on the chosen roster who still have no roles.

The same button is on every volunteer's profile, on the row that shows where you are in the list. Its count is for the roster tab you're looking at, and it changes when you switch tabs. Click it to start stepping through the people with no roles from wherever you are; click it again (it's gold while you're doing this) to go back to stepping through everyone on that roster.


2 of 30 · Sunday
No roles set 3
Sunday
Music
Insights
ROLES
Does This
Fills In
Doesn't Do
Baking for Morning Tea
Barista Coffee
Door & Offering
Prayer Ministry
Serving Morning Tea

The No roles set button on a profile — switch the walk on or off without going back to the list.

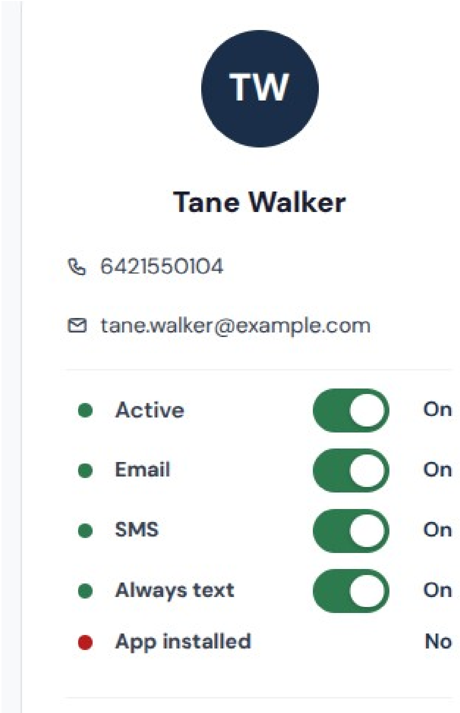
Who counts as "no roles set"? Active volunteers who are on that roster and have no role marked *Does This* or *Fills In* for it. A role set to *Doesn't Do* counts as not set. Inactive volunteers, and anyone finishing or removed from the roster, are left out of the count. Each roster is counted separately — roles on Sunday don't count towards Music.

The Profile Detail Page

Click any volunteer in the list to open their profile. This is where you manage everything about that person — their contact details, which rosters they serve in, the roles they do, how often they serve, who they serve alongside, and their availability. The left panel holds their contact details and a tab pill per roster type; the right panel holds the settings for whichever roster tab is selected, so each roster a volunteer serves in has its own independent setup.

Contact details & toggles

The left panel shows the volunteer's name, phone, email, and status, with four toggles that control how Rostas treats them, plus an automatic App Installed indicator described below:



TW

Tane Walker

☎ 6421550104

✉ tane.walker@example.com

● Active On

● Email On

● SMS On

● Always text On

● App installed No

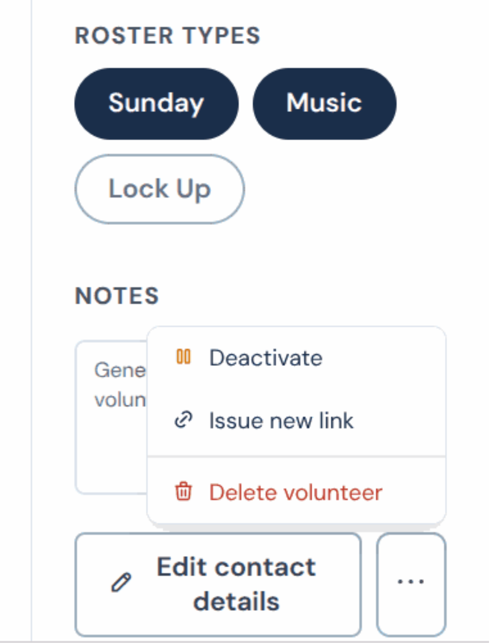
The left panel's toggles. "Always text" is the last — it opts a volunteer in to reminder texts even when they'd normally be reached by email.

> It's a handy way to spot who's worth encouraging toward the app: a red dot is your cue to mention it next time you see that volunteer, or to send them their app link straight away. Getting more volunteers onto the app pays off twice over — it makes it easier for them to check and adjust their own roster, and every reminder the app can deliver in place of a text is one less SMS your organisation pays for.

Issuing a volunteer a new link

Every volunteer's emails, texts and app carry a link that is private to them. Anyone holding that link can see their roster, reply for them and set up the app as them, so treat it like a key. If a link may have got into the wrong hands, give the volunteer a new one:

1. Open their profile.
2. Click the ··· button beside **Edit contact details**.



The ··· button beside Edit contact details opens this menu.

3. Click **Issue new link**.
4. Click **OK** to confirm. Their old links stop working straight away, and the app on their phone signs out. Their next email or text carries the new link, and they set the app up again from it.

Use it when:

- A volunteer **forwarded** one of their emails or texts to someone else.
- Their phone was **lost, stolen, or sold** with the app still on it.
- They see **"This link has already set up the app on 3 devices"** when setting up the app. Each link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets.

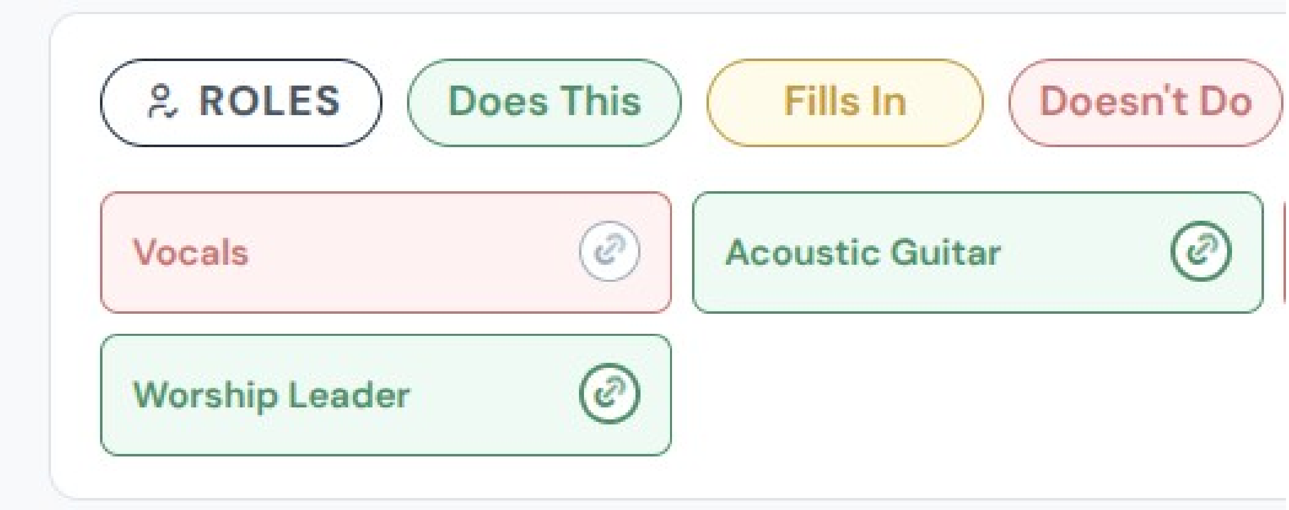
Rostas asks you to confirm first. Straight away:

- Their **old links stop working**, including links in earlier emails and texts. Anyone who opens one sees "This link has been replaced — please use the link in your latest email or text."
- The **app signs out** on every phone it was set up on, and app notifications stop until they set it up again.
- Their **next email or text carries the new link**. They set the app up again from that link, just as the first time (see How volunteers install it).

> **Let the volunteer know.** Issuing a new link doesn't send anything, so the volunteer won't have their new link until their next Rostas email or text arrives. Tell them their app has signed out and that the new link is on its way.

Roles — what they do

The Roles section on the right panel is where you set which roles this volunteer performs in this roster. Each role shows as **Does This**, **Fills In**, or **Doesn't Do**

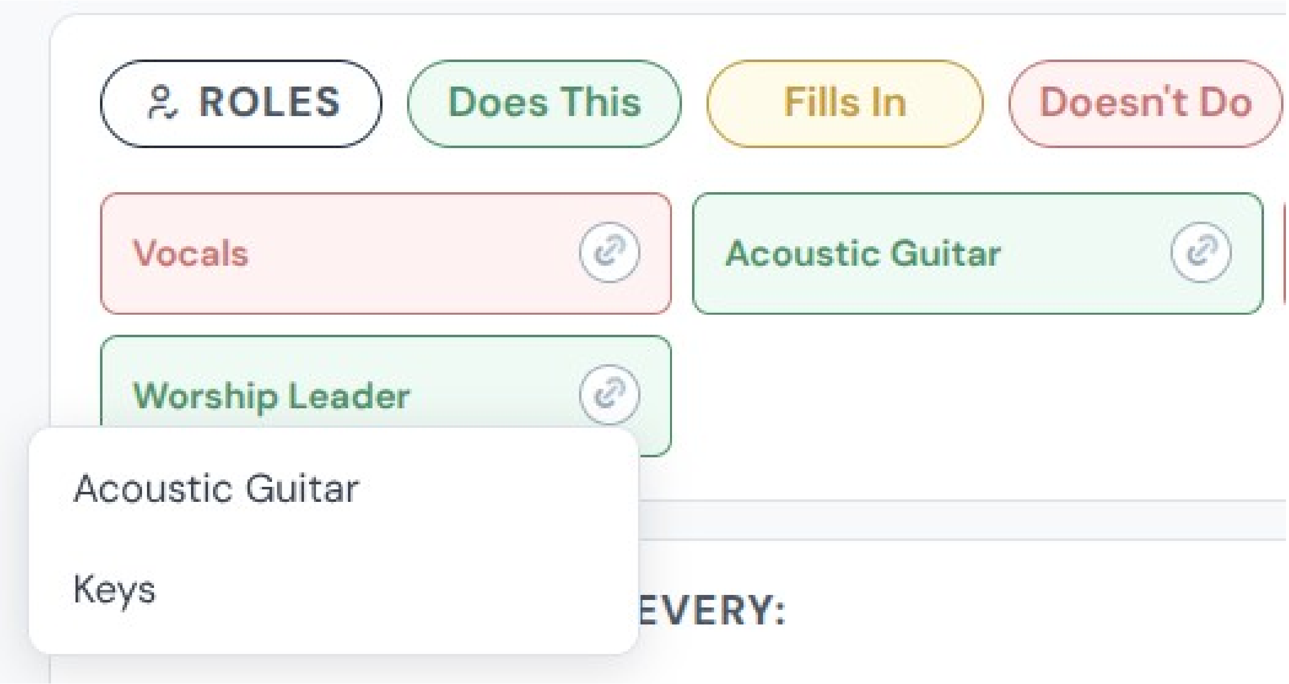

ROLES
Does This
Fills In
Doesn't Do
Vocals
Acoustic Guitar
Worship Leader

The Roles section. Set each role to Does This (a primary role they do regularly), Fills In (they'll cover it when needed), or Doesn't Do.

Linking roles together

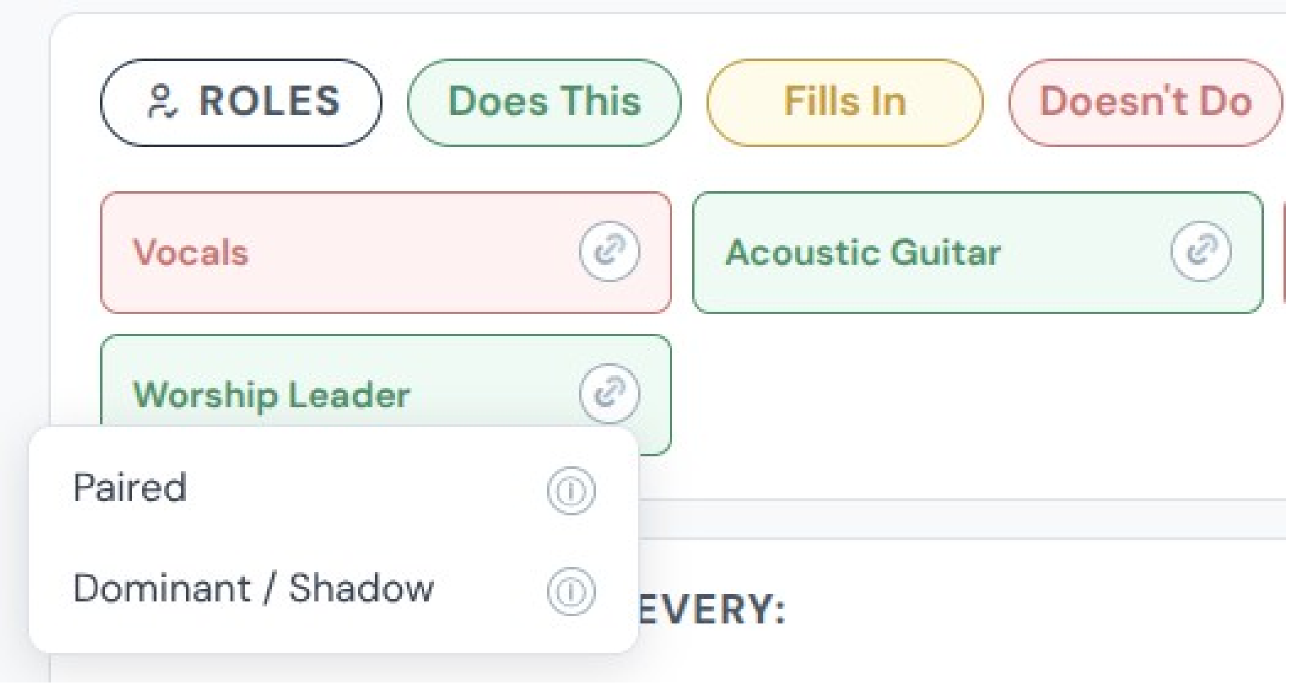
Sometimes two roles should travel together — Say a worship leader always also plays an acoustic guitar. Role linking handles this.

1. On the volunteer's profile, set both roles to **Does This**.
2. Click the link icon (🔗) on one of the two role cards. A list of the roles you can link it to opens.


ROLES
Does This
Fills In
Doesn't Do
Vocals
Acoustic Guitar
Worship Leader
Acoustic Guitar
Keys
EVERY:

The roles this one can be linked to.

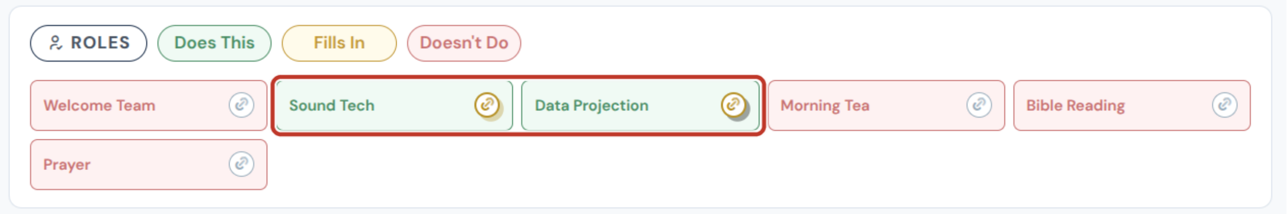
3. Click the other role.
4. Choose the link type: **Dominant — Shadow** or **Equal Pairing** (see the table below).


ROLES
Does This
Fills In
Doesn't Do
Vocals
Acoustic Guitar
Worship Leader
Paired
Dominant / Shadow
EVERY:

Choose the link type.

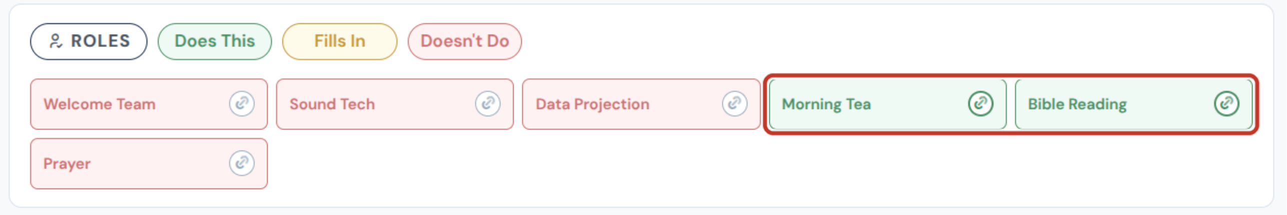
Linked roles are ringed on the profile so you can see the relationship at a glance.

A **gold drop-shadow** marks the dominant role, a **grey drop-shadow** its shadow pairing.


ROLES
Does This
Fills In
Doesn't Do
Welcome Team
Sound Tech
Data Projection
Morning Tea
Bible Reading
Prayer

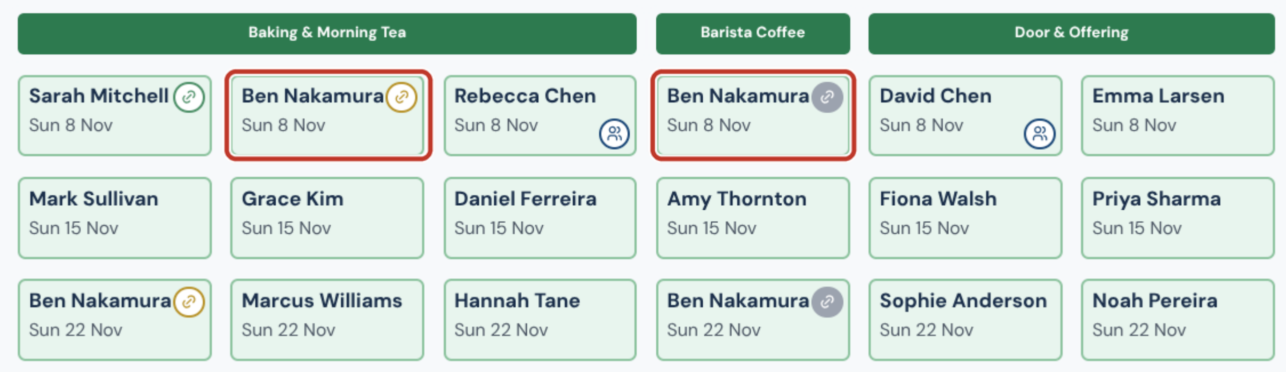
Gold drop-shadow and grey drop-shadow pairing

A highlighted g**reen circle border** marks paired roles in profile settings.


ROLES
Does This
Fills In
Doesn't Do
Welcome Team
Sound Tech
Data Projection
Morning Tea
Bible Reading
Prayer

Paired roles are marked with a green border on the profile.

On the Board, a linked card carries a small link badge in the same colours: **gold** for the dominant role, **grey** for its shadow and a **green** ring for an equal pairing. Click one and the other card that day gets a bold, pulsing border (see Seeing a card's connected cards).



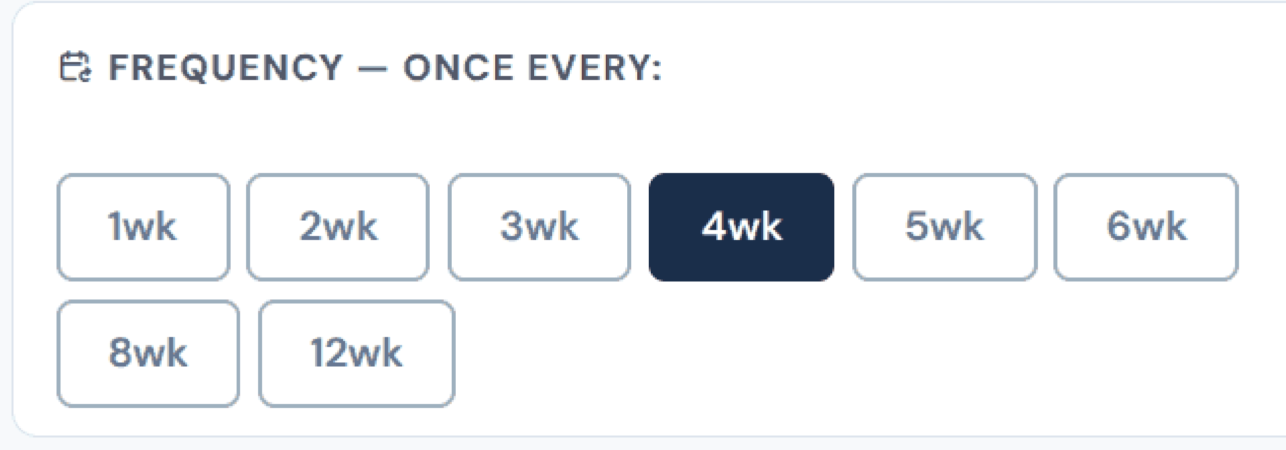
Baking & Morning Tea			Barista Coffee	Door & Offering	
Sarah Mitchell Sun 8 Nov	Ben Nakamura Sun 8 Nov	Rebecca Chen Sun 8 Nov	Ben Nakamura Sun 8 Nov	David Chen Sun 8 Nov	Emma Larsen Sun 8 Nov
Mark Sullivan Sun 15 Nov	Grace Kim Sun 15 Nov	Daniel Ferreira Sun 15 Nov	Amy Thornton Sun 15 Nov	Fiona Walsh Sun 15 Nov	Priya Sharma Sun 15 Nov
Ben Nakamura Sun 22 Nov	Marcus Williams Sun 22 Nov	Hannah Tane Sun 22 Nov	Ben Nakamura Sun 22 Nov	Sophie Anderson Sun 22 Nov	Noah Pereira Sun 22 Nov

Ben Nakamura's dominant role (Baking & Morning Tea) has the gold link badge and his shadow role (Barista Coffee) the grey one, so a linked assignment is easy to spot. The navy people badge marks a buddy or household link instead.

> **To change or remove a link**, click the link icon on an already-linked role — the dropdown then shows the linked partner and an option to unlink.

Frequency — how often they serve

The Frequency control — labelled **ONCE EVERY** — caps how often this volunteer is rostered in this roster, so nobody is over-used even when they're always available. Tap a pill: once every **1wk**, **2wk**, and so on up to **12wk**. If none is set, Rostas uses once every 4 weeks.

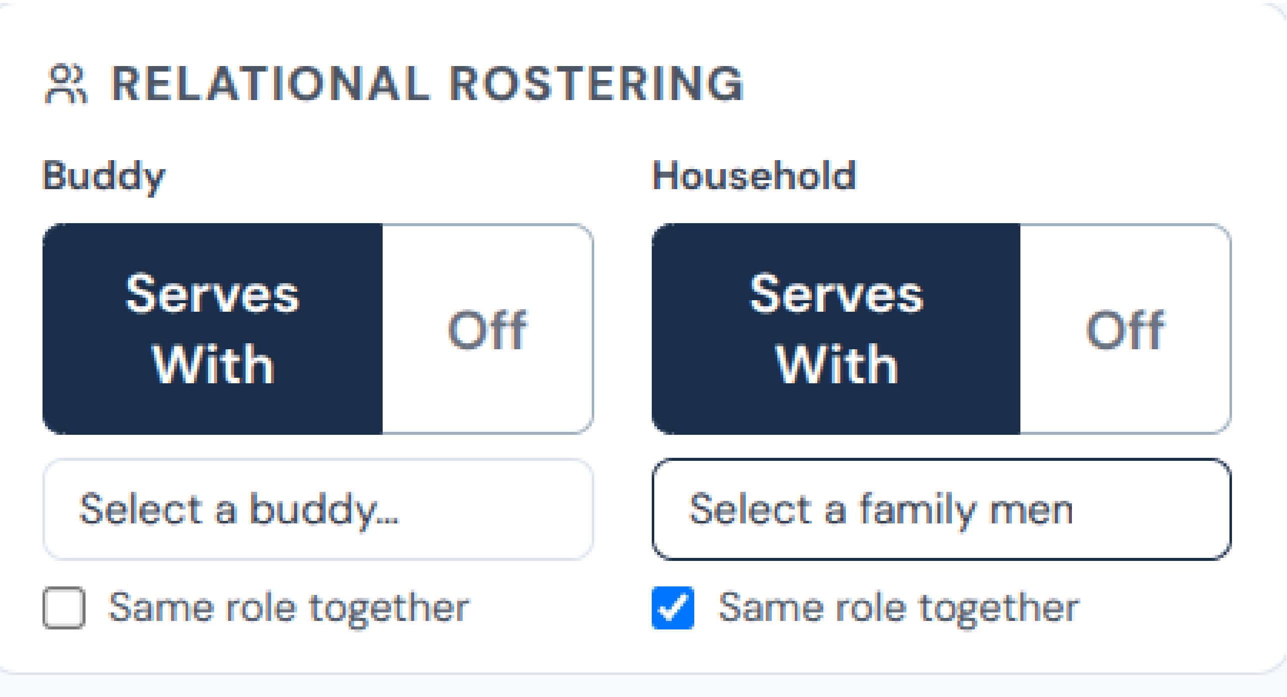


The Frequency control. "1wk" means they can be rostered every week; "4wk" means at most once every four weeks, and so on.

> **The cap counts distinct dates, not roles.** A volunteer rostered to two roles on the same day counts as one date — so serving twice in one Sunday doesn't use up two of their allocation.

Relational rostering — serving together

Relational rostering asks Rostas to place people *together* on the same dates — a **Buddy** they like to serve alongside, or a **Household** so family members share the same rota. Turn on "Serves With" and pick who, then choose how closely they should be linked: the same date, or the same role too.



RELATIONAL ROSTERING

Buddy

Select a buddy...

☐ Same role together

Household

Select a family men

☑ Same role together

Relational rostering — Buddy and Household "Serves With" settings, each now carrying a "Same role together" checkbox. Household is ticked here, linking two family members to the identical role every time.

Who you can pick. The **Buddy** list shows everyone on this roster. The **Household** list puts the likely family first, under "Same surname or household" (the same surname, or the same household in Infoodle or Planning Center), then everyone else under "Everyone else on this roster". So a couple or blended family with different surnames can still be linked as a household.

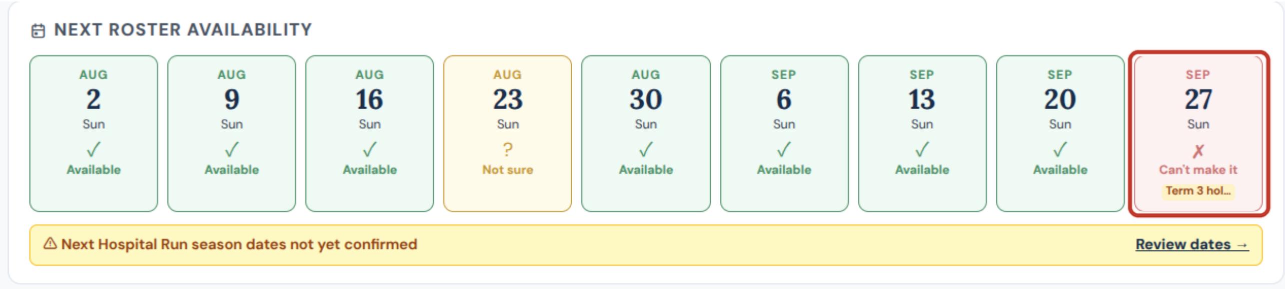
Their frequencies need to line up. Rostas can only keep a pair together when they serve equally often, or one serves a multiple of the other's frequency (say every 2 weeks and every 4 weeks: they serve together on the 4-weekly person's turns, and the other also serves alone in between). Combinations like 2 and 3 weeks, or 4 and 6, would rarely meet, so the profile won't accept them. If you pick someone like that, or change the frequency to one that doesn't fit, the choice goes back to what it was and a red message explains why, with a **Match** button that sets this person to their partner's frequency and makes the link. If one of the pair has been away, Rostas may hold the other back for a turn so they get back in step and serve together again.

Two ways to serve together. Left unticked, a Buddy or Household pair just needs to be rostered on the *same date* — any role each of them is capable of is fine. This suits people who want to travel in together or simply be there on the same Sunday. Tick **"Same role together"** when one person is mentoring or training the other — this asks Rostas to put them on the *same role*, together, every time. Because that's a tighter constraint, a same-role pair is held back more often, and only placed once a slot exists that fits them both.

Relational rostering is not the same as role linking. Role linking ties two *roles* together for the same person; relational rostering places two *people* on the same dates. One is about jobs, the other about company.

Next roster availability

The availability grid shows this volunteer's responses for the upcoming dates — the same three states they set on their own form:



NEXT ROSTER AVAILABILITY

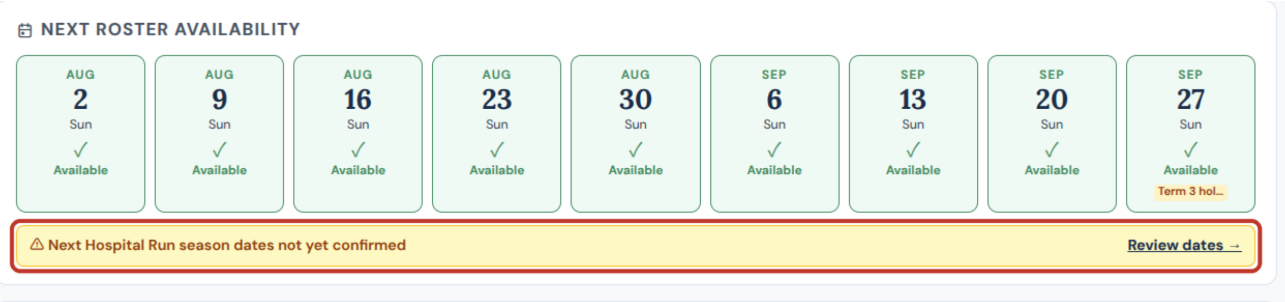
AUG 2 Sun	AUG 9 Sun	AUG 16 Sun	AUG 23 Sun	AUG 30 Sun	SEP 6 Sun	SEP 13 Sun	SEP 20 Sun	SEP 27 Sun
✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	? Not sure	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✗ Can't make it Term 3 hol...

⚠ Next Hospital Run season dates not yet confirmed

Review dates →

The Next Roster Availability grid. Holiday dates are tagged automatically so you can see at a glance which dates are affected.

If the season's dates aren't confirmed yet, a yellow banner appears at the bottom of this section — it's good to get season dates confirmed. Adding or deleting dates helps volunteers accurately know dates for the next roster.



NEXT ROSTER AVAILABILITY

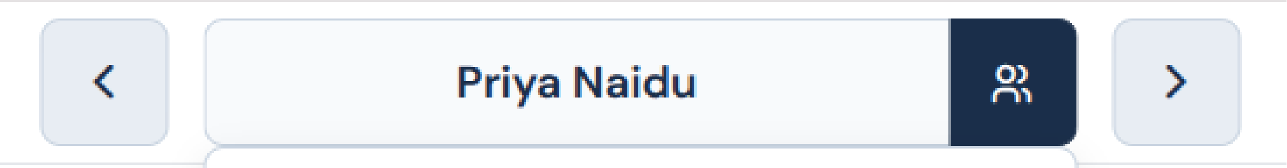
AUG 2 Sun	AUG 9 Sun	AUG 16 Sun	AUG 23 Sun	AUG 30 Sun	SEP 6 Sun	SEP 13 Sun	SEP 20 Sun	SEP 27 Sun
✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available	✓ Available Term 3 hol...

⚠ Next Hospital Run season dates not yet confirmed

Review dates →

The season-dates-unconfirmed banner — a reminder to confirm the season before availability can be gathered.

Searching across rosters. The prev/next arrows at the top of the profile step through volunteers. Next to them is a search-scope toggle (people icons) — switch it on to search across every roster rather than just the current one.

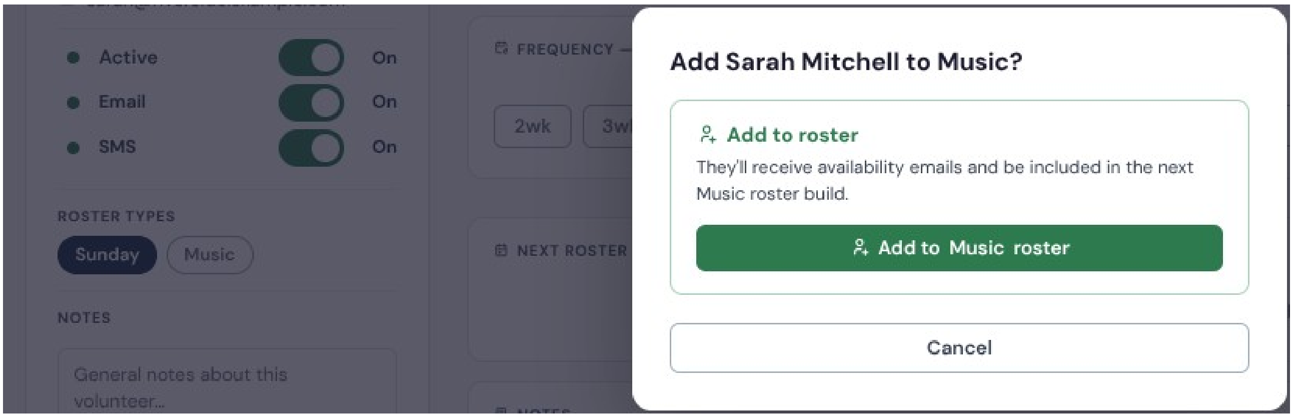

Priya Naidu

The profile top bar — step between volunteers with the arrows, and widen the search to all rosters with the scope toggle.

Putting a volunteer on another roster

When a volunteer starts serving on another roster:

1. Open their profile.
2. Under **Roster Types**, click the white pill for the new roster (for example *Music*).
3. Click **Add to [roster] roster**. They're included in that roster's next build.


Active
On
Email
On
SMS
On
ROSTER TYPES
Sunday
Music
NOTES
General notes about this volunteer...
FREQUENCY
2wk
3w
NEXT ROSTER
NOTES
Add to roster
Add to Music roster
Cancel

Add Sarah Mitchell to Music?

They'll receive availability emails and be included in the next Music roster build.

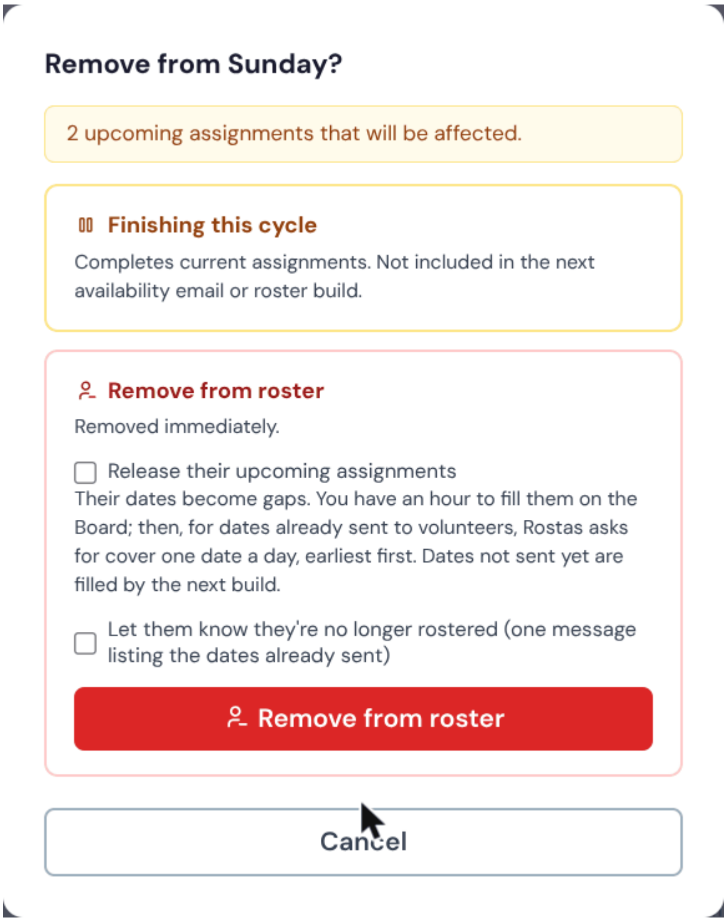
The confirmation before Rostas adds them.

4. Set their roles, frequency and partners for the new roster. These start fresh.

Taking a Volunteer Off a Roster

When someone stops serving on a roster:

1. Open their profile.
2. Under **Roster Types**, click that roster's navy pill (for example *Sunday*). A box asks *Remove from Sunday?*. If they're on any upcoming dates, a yellow line at the top says how many.



Remove from Sunday?

2 upcoming assignments that will be affected.

Finishing this cycle

Completes current assignments. Not included in the next availability email or roster build.

Remove from roster

Removed immediately.

☐ Release their upcoming assignments

Their dates become gaps. You have an hour to fill them on the Board; then, for dates already sent to volunteers, Rostas asks for cover one date a day, earliest first. Dates not sent yet are filled by the next build.

☐ Let them know they're no longer rostered (one message listing the dates already sent)

Both tick boxes under Remove from roster start unticked.

3. Click **Finishing this cycle** if they'll serve the dates they already have. Then you're done.
4. Or, to take them off now, first tick whichever boxes you want under it: **Release their upcoming assignments** and **Let them know they're no longer rostered** (both explained below).
5. Click **Remove from roster**.

Release their upcoming assignments takes them off every upcoming date on that roster (today's date is left alone; change that on the Board). Each of those cards becomes an empty gap (a red dashed *Unfilled* card) and the date's count drops, for example from 10/10 to 9/10.

Removing someone straight away is often urgent or sad, so Rostas fills their dates gently rather than sending a burst of requests:

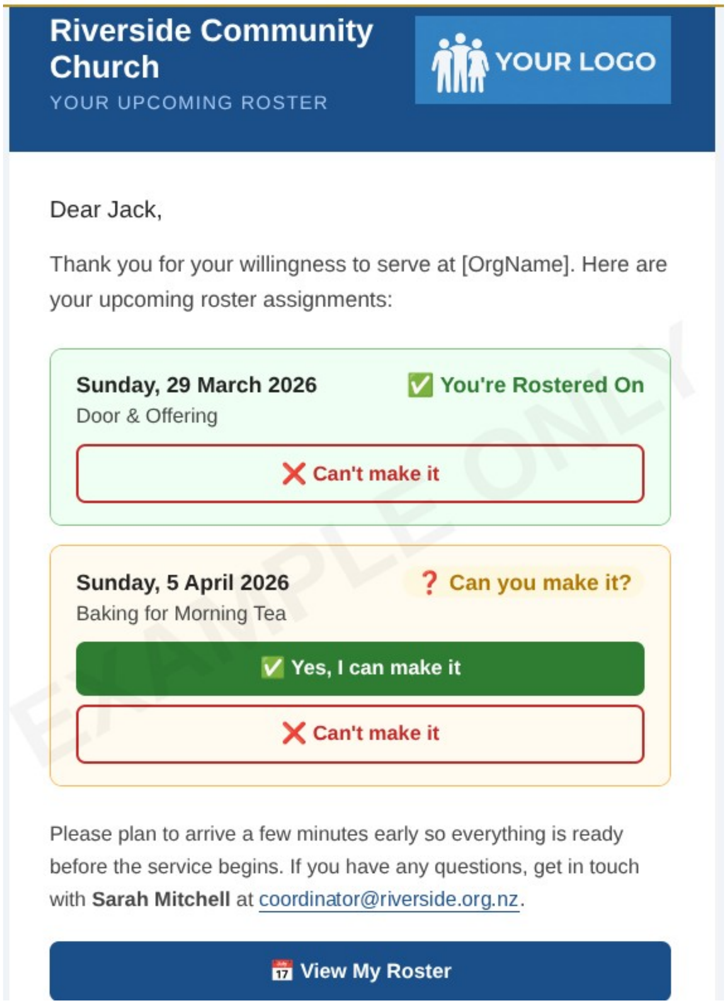
- **You have an hour** to fill any of the gaps yourself on the Board, for example with someone you've already spoken to.
- **Dates whose roster has already gone out:** after the hour, Rostas sends replacement requests for **one date a day, earliest first**, just as if the person had tapped *Can't make it*. A date you've filled meanwhile is skipped. A date coming up soon is never left until less than two days before it.
- **Dates whose roster hasn't gone out yet:** nobody is asked; the next roster build fills them, or you can fill them on the Board.
- **Roster paused:** no requests go out; the gaps wait for you.

Let them know they're no longer rostered starts unticked. Tick it to send the person one message (in the app, or by text) listing every date whose roster had already gone out, for example "you're no longer rostered for Welcomer on Sun 4 Oct, Sun 11 Oct and Sun 25 Oct". Leave it unticked when a message would be unkind or unwanted, for example if they have died, and tell them or their family yourself.

Changed your mind? Click the same roster pill on their profile and choose *Add to Sunday roster* (or whichever roster it is). Dates you released aren't given back to them; put them back on a date from the Board if you need to.

What Volunteers See

Volunteers interact with Rostas through personalised links, and — if they've installed it — the Rostas app. Installing is entirely optional: nothing is ever gated behind it, and a volunteer who never installs keeps using email and SMS links exactly as before. These are the main things volunteers are sent:



Riverside Community Church
YOUR UPCOMING ROSTER

Dear Jack,

Thank you for your willingness to serve at [OrgName]. Here are your upcoming roster assignments:

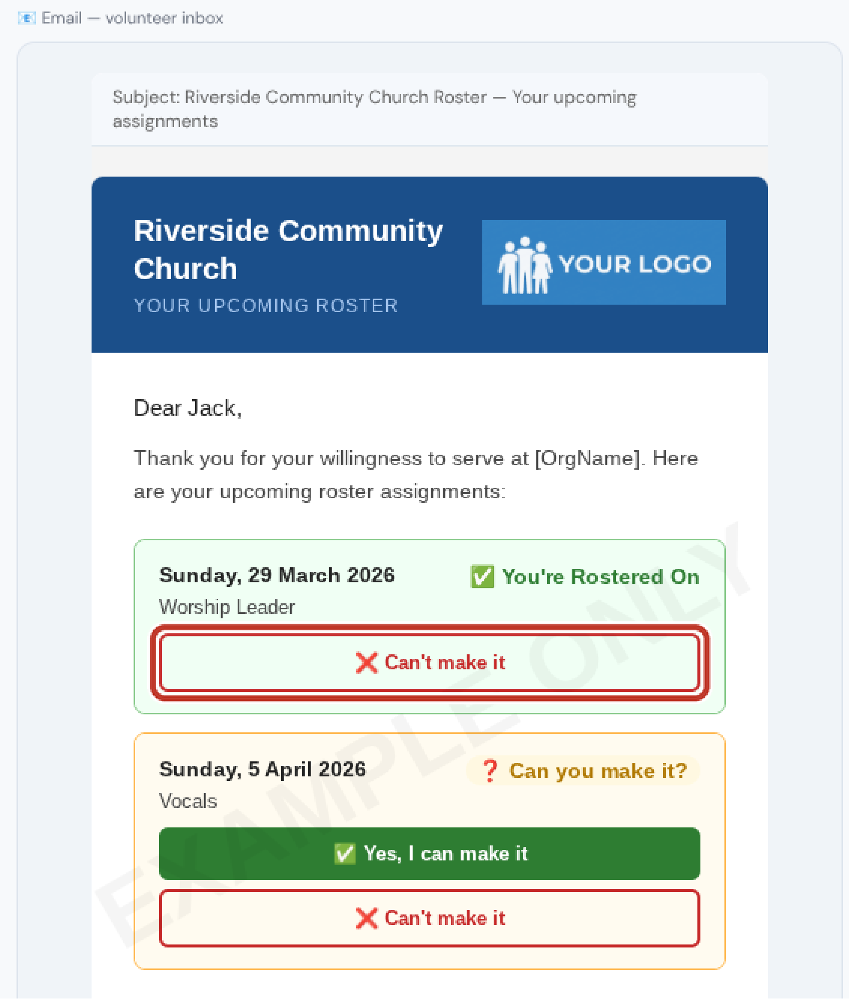
Sunday, 29 March 2026
Door & Offering

Sunday, 5 April 2026
Baking for Morning Tea

Please plan to arrive a few minutes early so everything is ready before the service begins. If you have any questions, get in touch with **Sarah Mitchell** at coordinator@riverside.org.nz.

EXAMPLE ONLY

The volunteer roster view — shows upcoming assignments in a clean mobile-friendly layout. Volunteers access this via the link in their notification email.



Email — volunteer inbox

Subject: Riverside Community Church Roster — Your upcoming assignments

Riverside Community Church

YOUR UPCOMING ROSTER

Dear Jack,

Thank you for your willingness to serve at [OrgName]. Here are your upcoming roster assignments:

Sunday, 29 March 2026
Worship Leader

Sunday, 5 April 2026
Vocals

EXAMPLE ONLY

The roster notification email — every rostered volunteer receives a personalised email with their assignments. The "Can't make it?" button at the bottom starts the replacement chain if tapped.

> **All volunteer pages are mobile-optimised.** Most volunteers will open them on their phone directly from an email or SMS, whether or not they've installed the app.

When an old link no longer applies

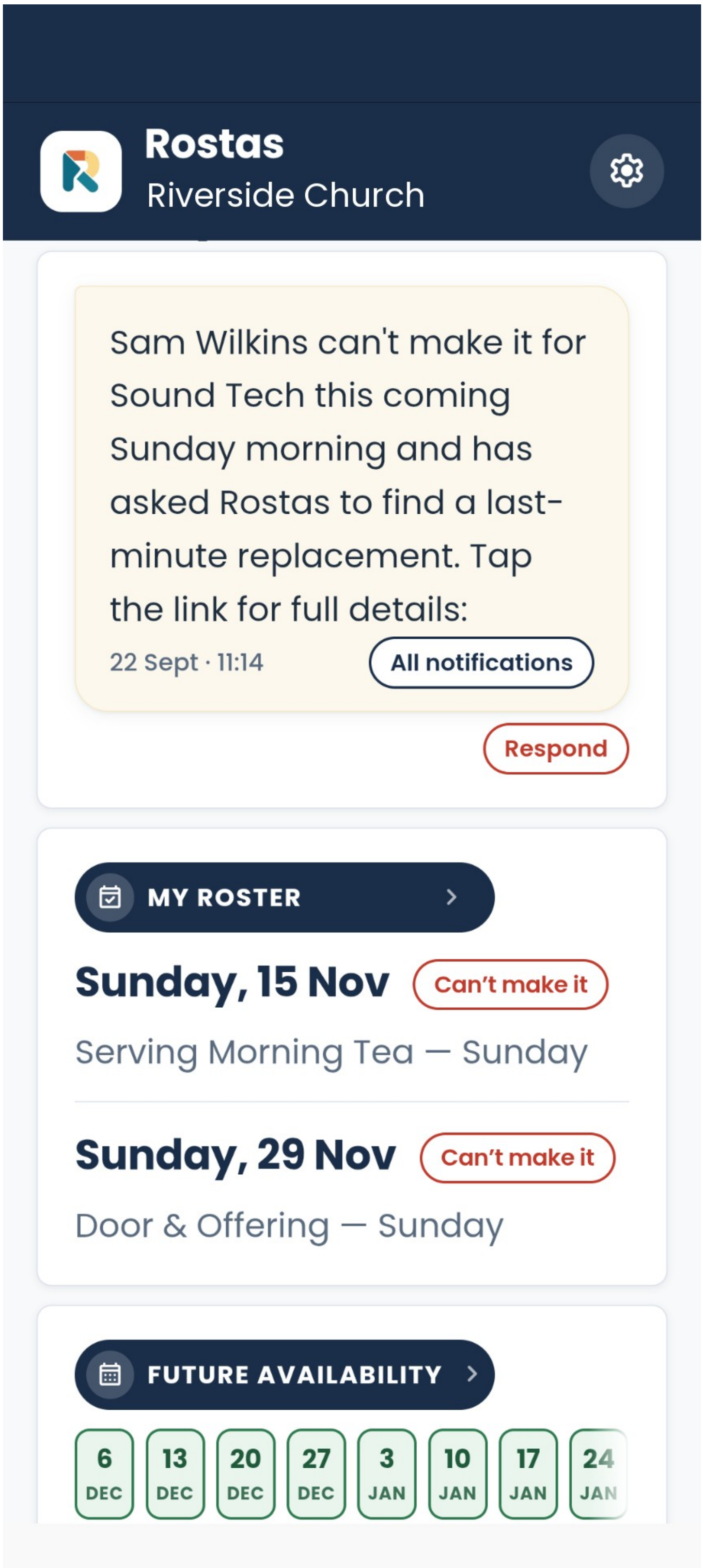
Volunteers sometimes tap a link in an older email or text after things have moved on: you've replaced them on the Board, or they've already said they can't make it. Rostas checks every answer against the roster as it is now, so an old link can never undo a change you've made or put back someone who has been replaced. Instead of changing anything, the volunteer sees a plain explanation:

> If a volunteer calls to say they can make it after all, put them back from the Board: **Undo decline** on a Declined card, or **Keep [name], stop requests** while Rostas is still looking. See Changing a card on the Board.

The Rostas App

Rostas has an installable app — technically a "Progressive Web App", not something from an app store — at **mobile.rostas.app**. It's a front end for exactly the same data volunteers already see by link: nothing changes about what Rostas does, only how it's reached.

Across the top of every screen is a navy header: the **R** button (tap it from anywhere to go back to Home), your **church name**, and a three-line **Menu** button on the right. The Menu holds **News**, **Podcasts** and **Settings**; News and Podcasts only appear once your church has filled in their addresses (see News and podcasts in the app).



Rostas
Riverside Church

Sam Wilkins can't make it for Sound Tech this coming Sunday morning and has asked Rostas to find a last-minute replacement. Tap the link for full details:

22 Sept · 11:14

All notifications
Respond
MY ROSTER

Sunday, 15 Nov

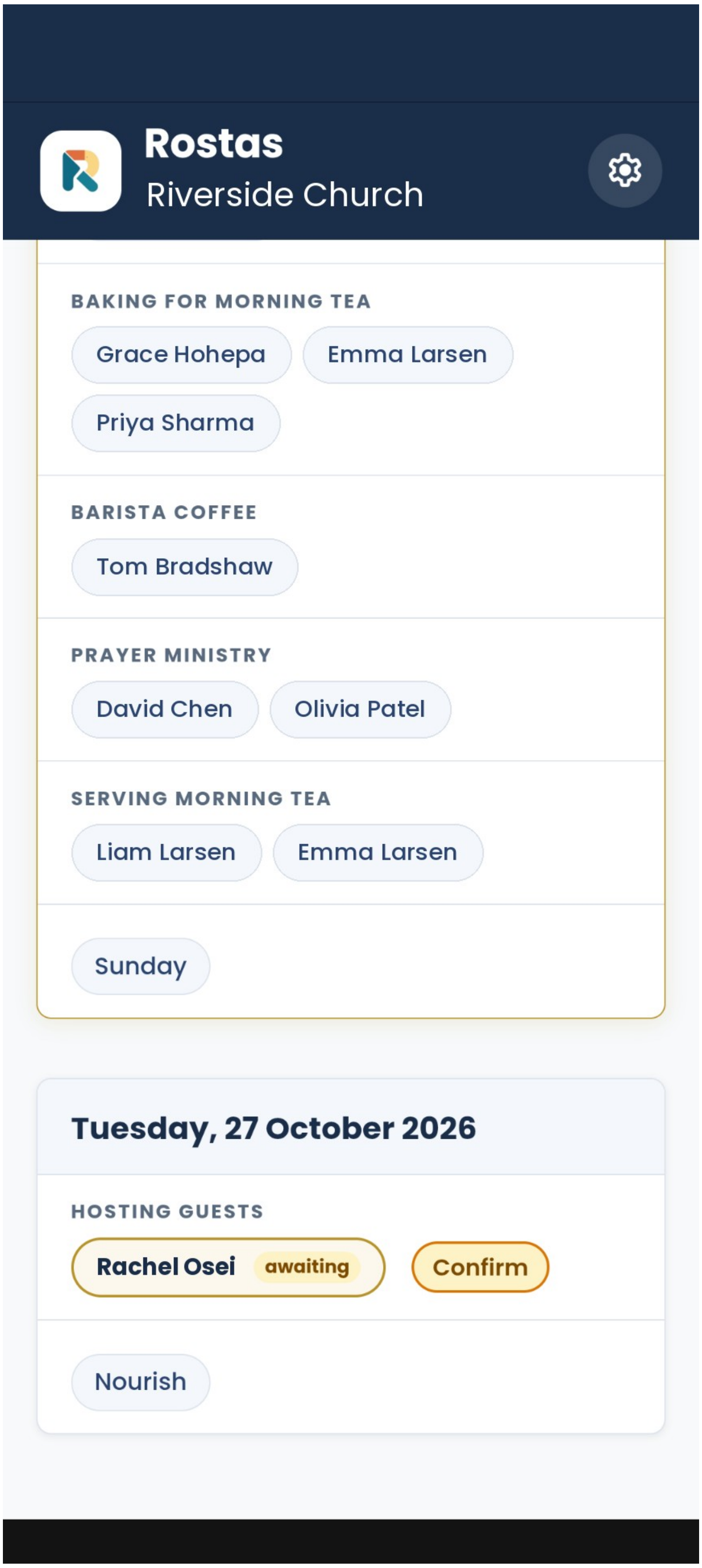
Serving Morning Tea — Sunday

Sunday, 29 Nov

Door & Offering — Sunday

Can't make it
Can't make it
FUTURE AVAILABILITY
6 DEC
13 DEC
20 DEC
27 DEC
3 JAN
10 JAN
17 JAN
24 JAN

The app's Home screen — latest notification with a one-tap Respond, upcoming assignments under My Roster with a one-tap Can't make it, and a Future availability strip to scroll through.



Rostas
Riverside Church

BAKING FOR MORNING TEA
Grace Hohepa · Emma Larsen · Priya Sharma

BARISTA COFFEE
Tom Bradshaw

PRAYER MINISTRY
David Chen · Olivia Patel

SERVING MORNING TEA
Liam Larsen · Emma Larsen

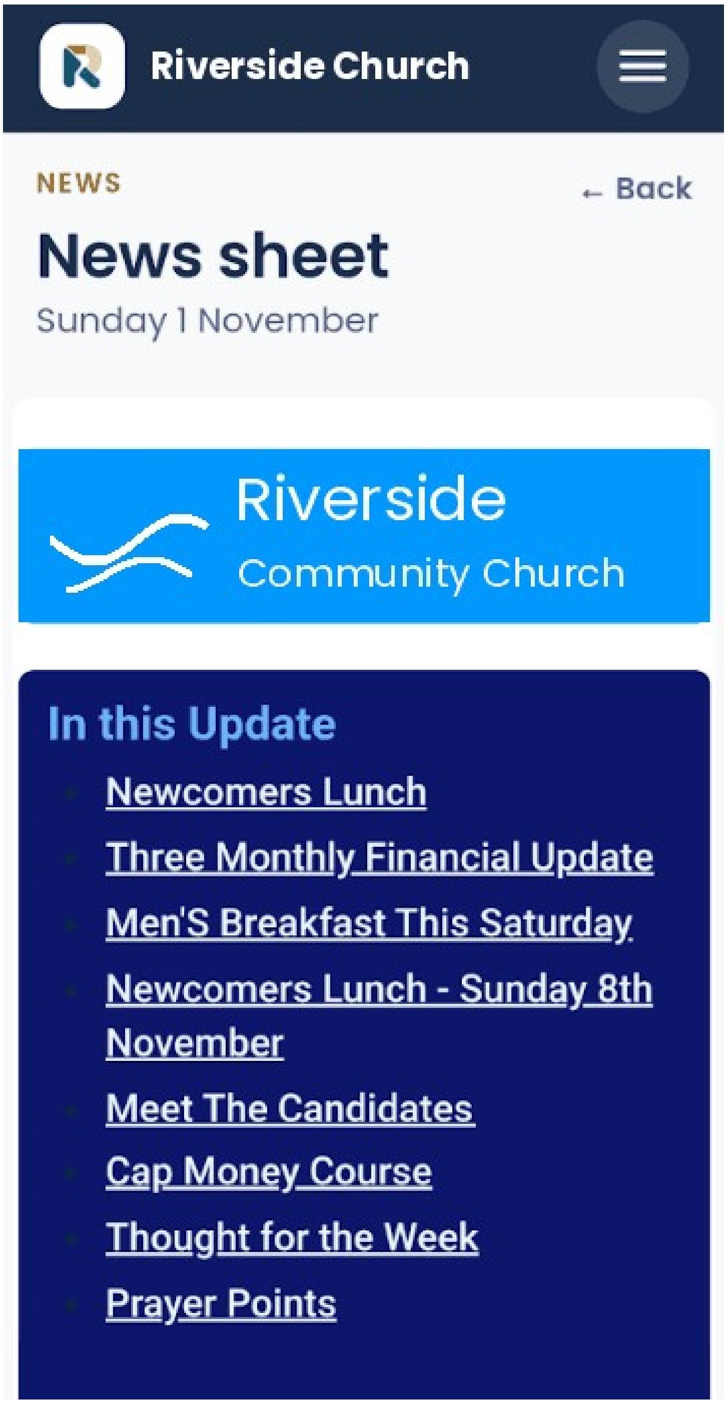
Sunday

Tuesday, 27 October 2026

HOSTING GUESTS
Rachel Osei awaiting · Confirm

Nourish

Your Roster — the amber pill means the assignment is still pending confirmation; tapping it opens a Yes/No sheet.



Riverside Church

NEWS

← Back

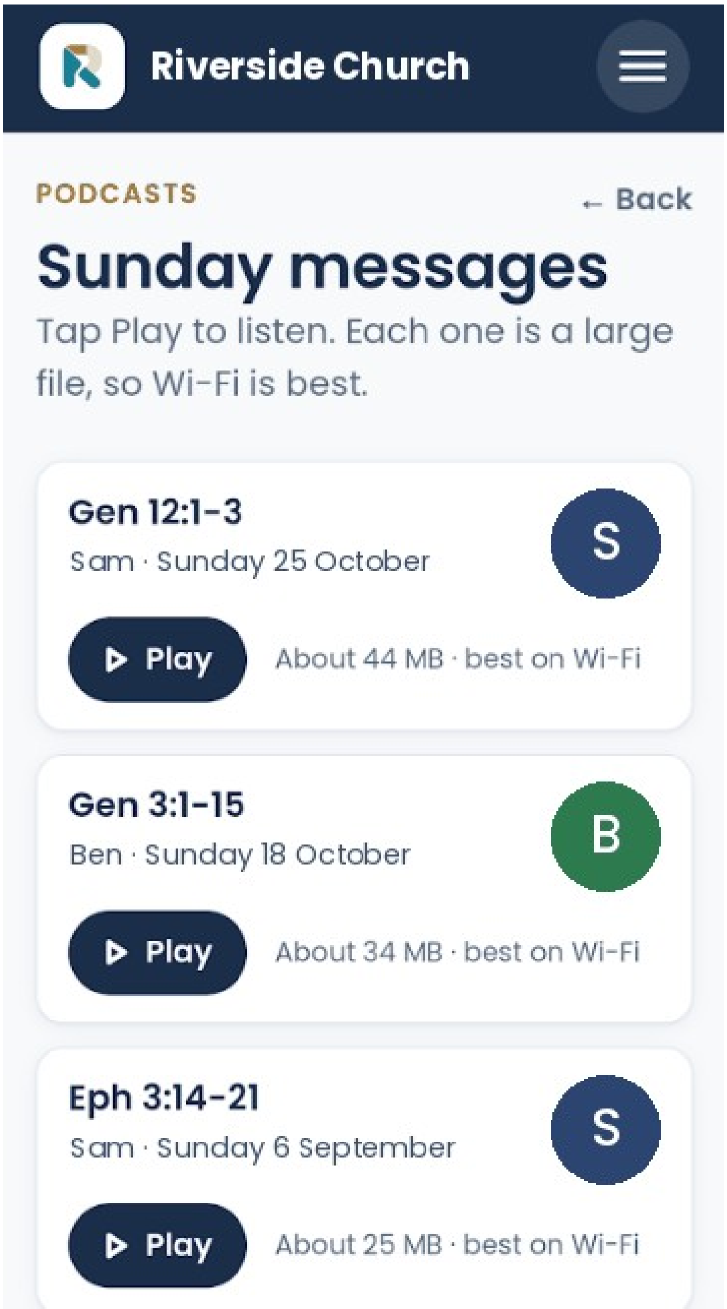
News sheet

Sunday 1 November

In this Update

- Newcomers Lunch
- Three Monthly Financial Update
- Men'S Breakfast This Saturday
- Newcomers Lunch - Sunday 8th November
- Meet The Candidates
- Cap Money Course
- Thought for the Week
- Prayer Points

News — this week's news sheet. Tap a line under In this Update to jump to it.



Sunday messages

Tap Play to listen. Each one is a large file, so Wi-Fi is best.

Gen 12:1-3
Sam · Sunday 25 October

About 44 MB · best on Wi-Fi

Gen 3:1-15
Ben · Sunday 18 October

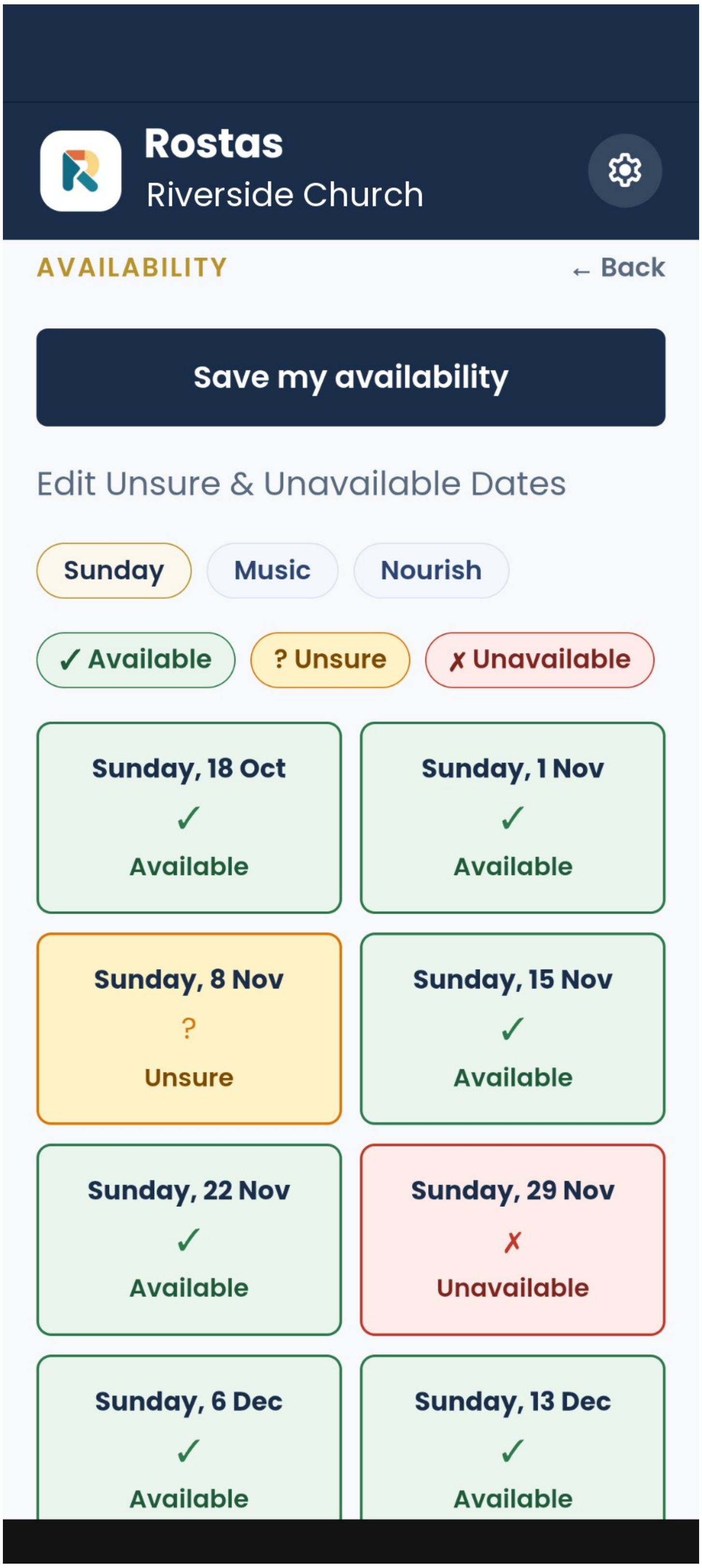
About 34 MB · best on Wi-Fi

Eph 3:14-21
Sam · Sunday 6 September

About 25 MB · best on Wi-Fi

Podcasts — Sunday messages with a Play button and the file size. A speaker's photo shows top right when your podcast page has one.

> **The app opens instantly, then checks for changes.** Home, Your Roster, Availability, News and Podcasts show what the phone last saw straight away, with "Checking for changes…" at the top. The answer buttons (Can't make it, Confirm, Respond and the date cards) stay greyed out until the fresh copy arrives a moment later, so nobody acts on out-of-date information. With no signal, the screen says when it was last correct.


Rostas
Riverside Church
AVAILABILITY
← Back
Save my availability
Edit Unsure & Unavailable Dates
Sunday
Music
Nourish
✓ Available
? Unsure
✗ Unavailable

Sunday, 18 Oct ✓ Available
Sunday, 1 Nov ✓ Available
Sunday, 8 Nov ? Unsure
Sunday, 15 Nov ✓ Available
Sunday, 22 Nov ✓ Available
Sunday, 29 Nov ✗ Unavailable
Sunday, 6 Dec ✓ Available
Sunday, 13 Dec ✓ Available

A volunteer serving on both Sunday and Nourish sees a pill for each — availability is set independently per roster.

How volunteers install it

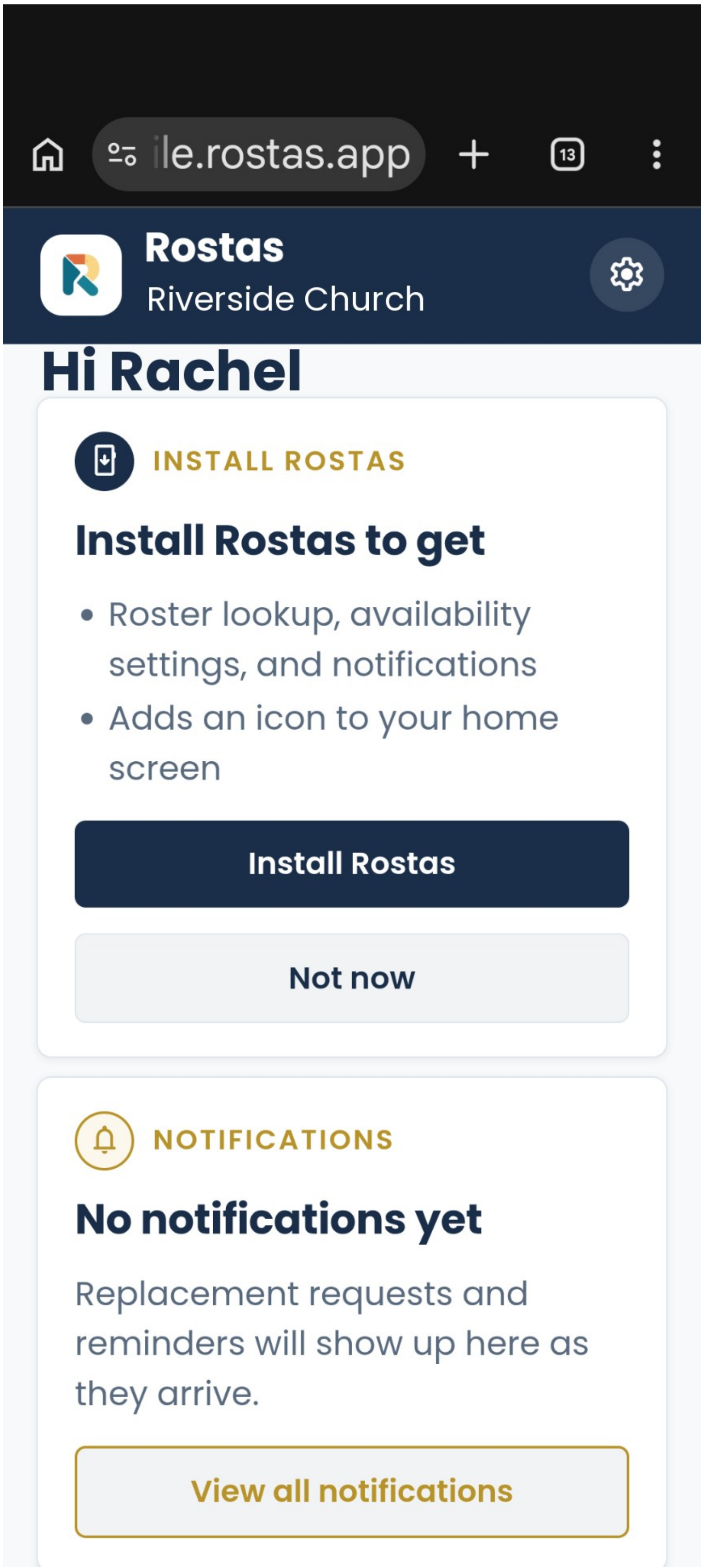
Every volunteer email carries a permanent "Get the app" card in the footer — automatic, not something you configure per email. To send someone their link straight away, see Sending a volunteer their app link. Installing looks different depending on the volunteer's phone:

The **Show me how** guide is also on the app's Home screen and in the app's **Settings** (the **App** row), so a volunteer can reopen it at any time. It ends on a **Your turn** list that stays at the top of the screen while they tap through Safari's menus.

Helping someone set up an iPhone. Three things catch people out:

- **It must be Safari.** If the link opened in another browser or inside an app, the page says so. Open the link from their text message instead.
- **Leave "Open as Web App" switched on** (green) in the last step. If it's off, the icon just opens a Safari tab.
- **If the icon shows "Set up this device"**, it was added from the wrong page. Delete the icon, tap their link again, and add it from there.

"This link has already set up the app on 3 devices." Each volunteer's link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets. If they need another, or have changed phones more than twice, issue them a new link.



ile.rostas.app
13

Rostas
Riverside Church

Hi Rachel

INSTALL ROSTAS

Install Rostas to get

- Roster lookup, availability settings, and notifications
- Adds an icon to your home screen

Install Rostas
Not now

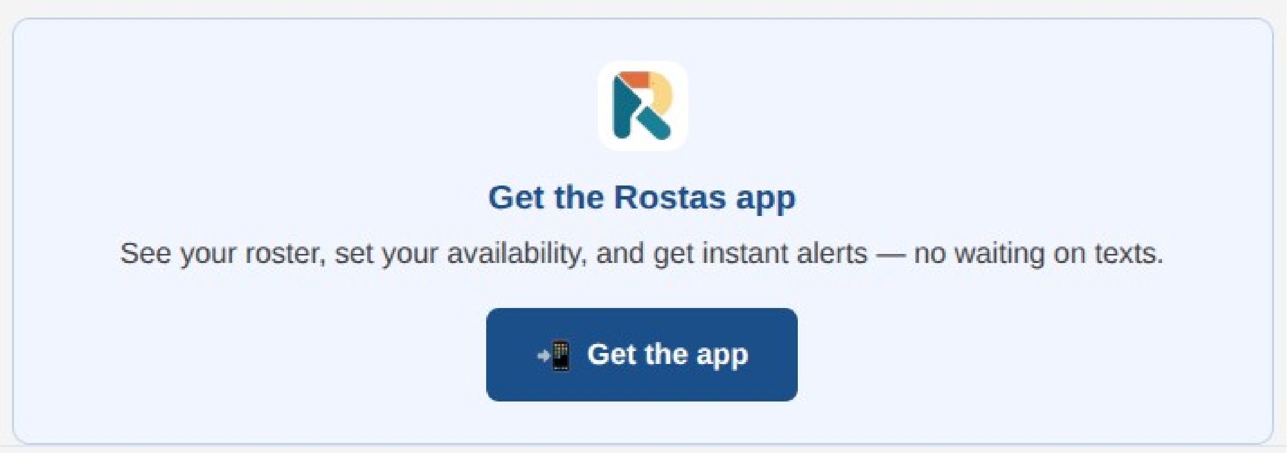
NOTIFICATIONS

No notifications yet

Replacement requests and reminders will show up here as they arrive.

View all notifications

The Android install prompt — one tap installs the app, no app store involved.



Get the Rostas app

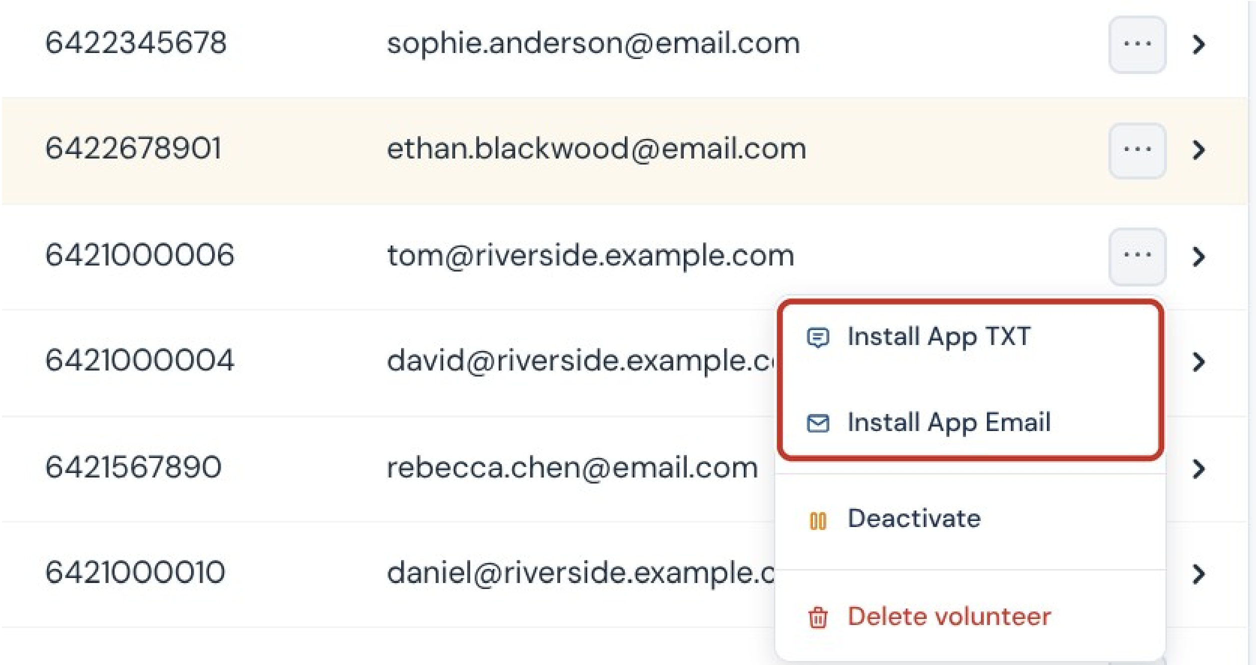
See your roster, set your availability, and get instant alerts — no waiting on texts.

Every volunteer email carries this footer card automatically.

Sending a volunteer their app link

You don't have to wait for the next roster email. You can send any volunteer their own app link straight away, by text or by email:

1. Open **Profiles**.
2. Click the **⋯** button at the right-hand end of their row.



6422345678	sophie.anderson@email.com
6422678901	ethan.blackwood@email.com
6421000006	tom@riverside.example.com
6421000004	david@riverside.example.c
6421567890	rebecca.chen@email.com
6421000010	daniel@riverside.example.c

The two Install App options are at the top of the menu.

3. Click **Install App TXT** or **Install App Email**.

Rostas confirms with a short message, such as *Text sent to Judy Aitkinson.* If it can't send, the message says why and suggests the other option. The usual reasons are:

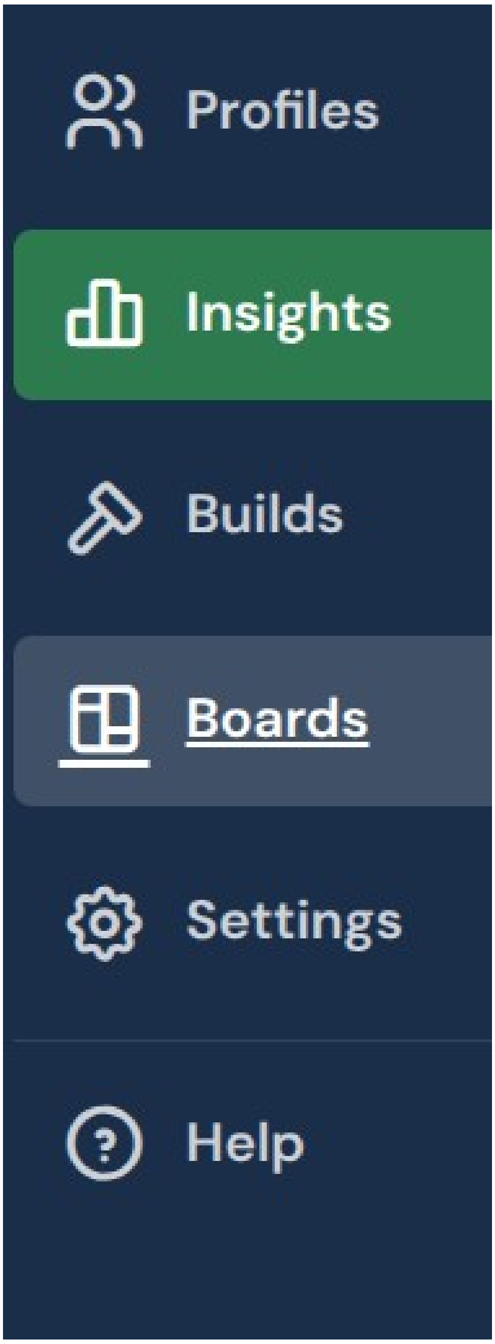
- The volunteer has **no mobile number** or **no email address** on file.
- The volunteer has **opted out** of texts or emails. You can check this with the toggles on their profile.
- Texts are **held during your SMS quiet hours** (see Settings). Use **Install App Email**, or try again later.

Both options send the volunteer's existing link, so it's fine to send it again if they lose it. Remember that each link can set up the app on up to three phones or tablets. If someone needs more, issue them a new link.

Running an app table after a service. Some churches find it easiest to set up a table where volunteers who are comfortable with phones help others. Look the person up with the search box on the Profiles page, choose **Install App TXT**, and ask them to open the text on their own phone. The helper never needs a password, because there isn't one — the link does the work. For iPhones, see *Helping someone set up an iPhone* in the section above.

Cost and test mode. A text uses one text from your SMS allowance, like any other text Rostas sends. The email costs nothing. While SMS test mode is on in Settings, the text goes to the coordinator's phone instead of the volunteer's, and the confirmation says **TEST MODE**. Email test mode works the same way.

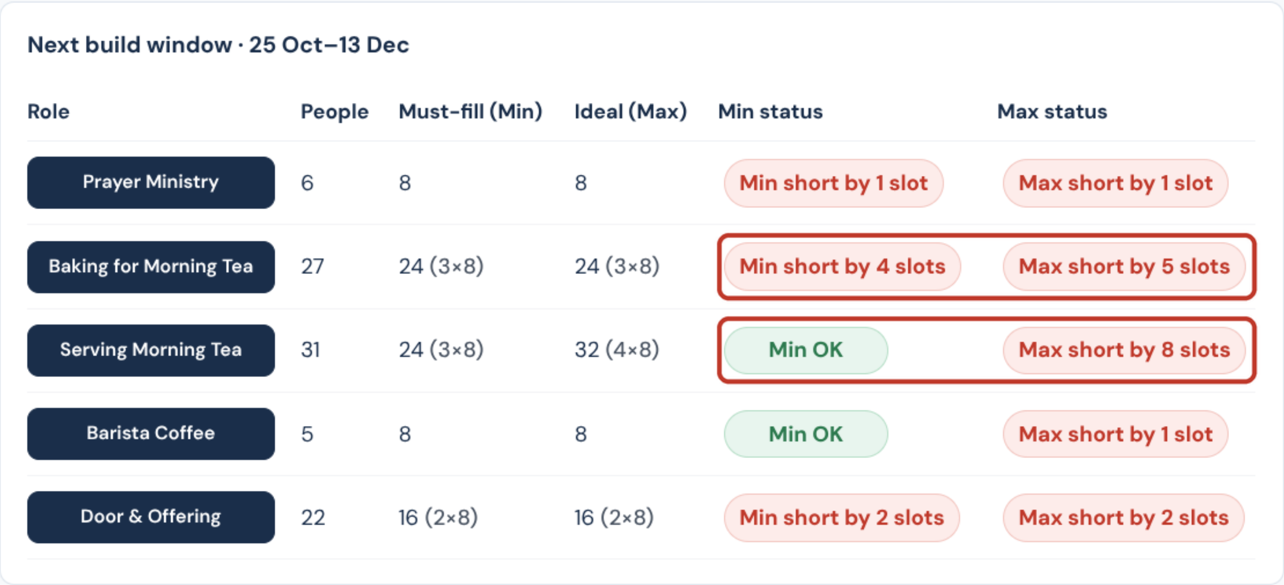
Insights is your at-a-glance health check for an upcoming roster — reachable any time from the **Insights** item in the side navigation (it sits right below Profiles), or via the "Insights" shortcut buttons on Profiles and a volunteer's own detail page. Insights refreshes whenever the roster, your volunteers or Settings change, so it always reflects your current forecast. It's worth a look between builds, not just when something's already gone wrong.


Profiles
Insights
Builds
Boards
Settings
Help

Insights lives in the side nav, right below Profiles.

The overview table

Pick a roster type along the top (Sunday, Music, Lock Up, and so on) and Insights shows every one of its roles against your next unbuilt window of dates. Two separate numbers matter for each role:



Next build window · 25 Oct–13 Dec

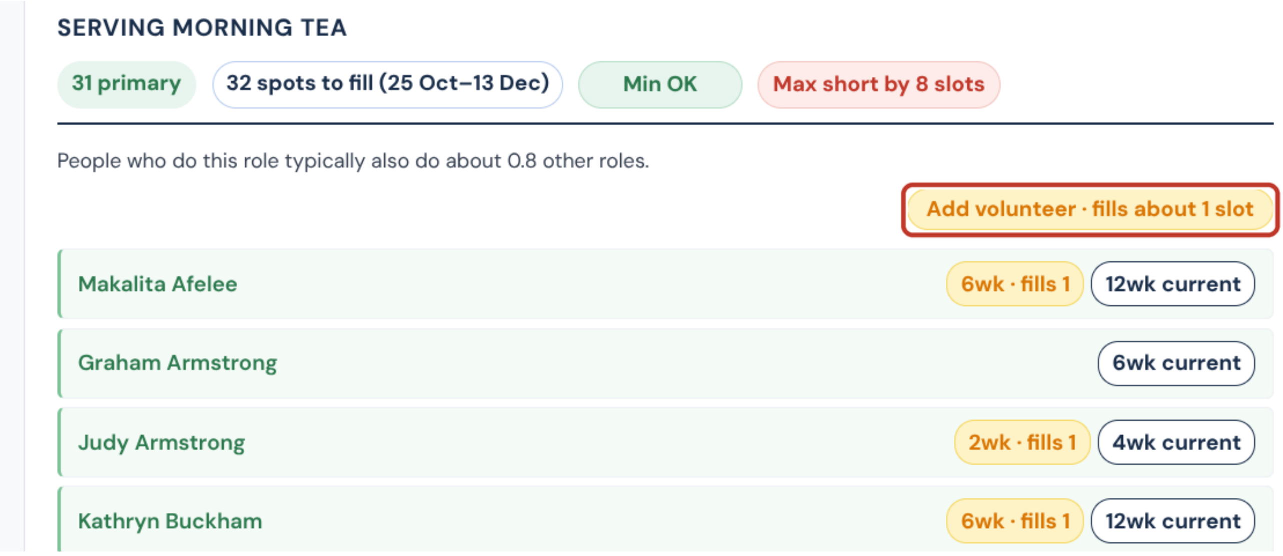
Role	People	Must-fill (Min)	Ideal (Max)	Min status	Max status
Prayer Ministry	6	8	8	Min short by 1 slot	Max short by 1 slot
Baking for Morning Tea	27	24 (3×8)	24 (3×8)	Min short by 4 slots	Max short by 5 slots
Serving Morning Tea	31	24 (3×8)	32 (4×8)	Min OK	Max short by 8 slots
Barista Coffee	5	8	8	Min OK	Max short by 1 slot
Door & Offering	22	16 (2×8)	16 (2×8)	Min short by 2 slots	Max short by 2 slots

The overview table for Sunday's next build window. Baking for Morning Tea is short on both Min and Max; Serving Morning Tea meets its minimum but is short of the ideal.

> **Min and Max are different questions.** A role can be "Min OK" — enough people to function — while still short of "Ideal (Max)", the fuller complement you'd rather have. Watch Min status first; it's the number that actually stops a roster running short-handed.

Digging into a role

Click a role's name to jump to its detail card further down the page. Each card repeats that role's numbers, then lists every volunteer linked to it with a pill showing their current frequency cap — and, where it would genuinely help, a second pill suggesting a change.



SERVING MORNING TEA

31 primary · 32 spots to fill (25 Oct–13 Dec) · Min OK · Max short by 8 slots

People who do this role typically also do about 0.8 other roles.

Add volunteer · fills about 1 slot

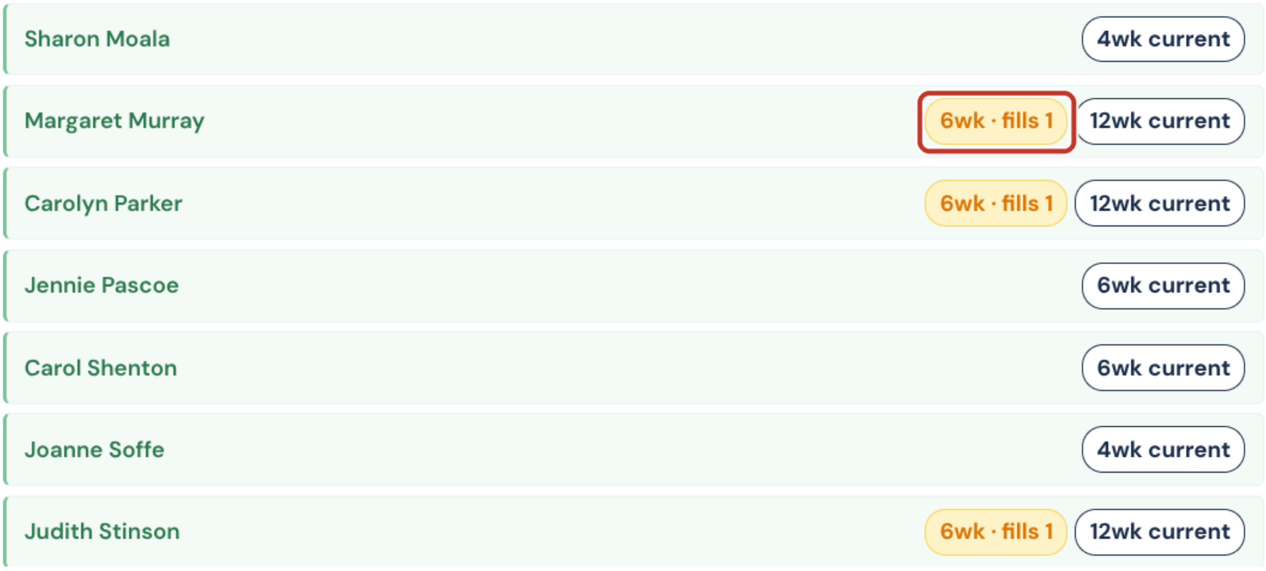
Makalita Afelee — 6wk · fills 1 — 12wk current

Graham Armstrong — 6wk current

Judy Armstrong — 2wk · fills 1 — 4wk current

Kathryn Buckham — 6wk · fills 1 — 12wk current

A role's detail card — headcount pills at top, then a suggestion (here, recruiting a new volunteer) and the full volunteer list below.



Sharon Moala — 4wk current

Margaret Murray — 6wk · fills 1 — 12wk current

Carolyn Parker — 6wk · fills 1 — 12wk current

Jennie Pascoe — 6wk current

Carol Shenton — 6wk current

Joanne Soffe — 4wk current

Judith Stinson — 6wk · fills 1 — 12wk current

Most volunteers just show their current cap. A few carry an amber suggestion too — loosening their cap would fill the number of slots shown.

You'll also see a line like "People who do this role typically also do about 0.8 other roles" — a reminder that many of your volunteers are shared across roles, which is exactly what the fill-order effect below is about.

Reordering roles

Some shortfalls aren't about headcount at all — they're about **fill order**. Rostas fills roles top-to-bottom in the order they're listed on Adding and changing roles: once a volunteer is placed in one role for a date, they're not considered for any role further down the list that same date. A role near the bottom can end up short simply because every volunteer who could have filled it was claimed by an earlier role first.

Where moving a short role earlier in that order would help, its card shows a distinct suggestion:

> **Example reorder suggestion:** "Moving this role to the 1st position would fill 2 of 3 slots. Cost: Serving Morning Tea loses 2 slot(s)." with an **Open Manage Roles** link.

> **Always a trade, never free capacity.** Moving a role earlier redistributes an existing shared volunteer — it doesn't create a new one. Whatever slots the short role gains, another role loses, and Insights always names which one and by how much before you act. If nothing else would get worse, it says so plainly ("No other role gets worse").

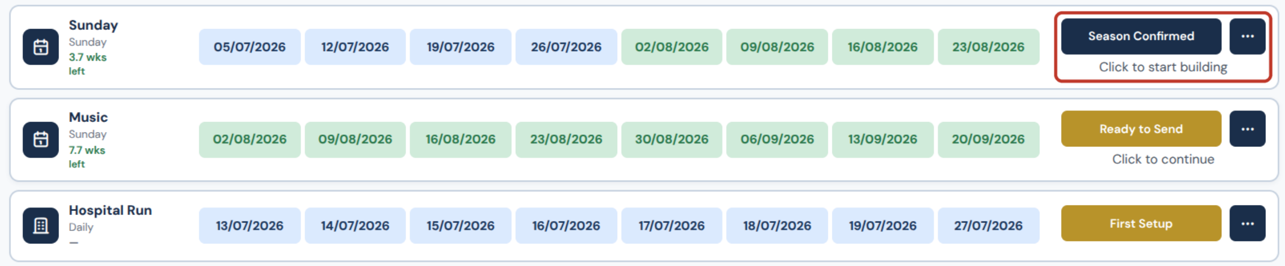
> **Insights tells you, it doesn't do it for you.** Every suggestion on this page is informational. Reactivating a volunteer, loosening a cap, recruiting someone new, or reordering roles are all things you choose to do yourself — from a Profile, or from Adding and changing roles. Insights just points you at what's worth trying.

There are two roster wizards in Rostas. **Set up a new roster** runs once when you set up a new roster type — it defines the name, roles, season dates, and volunteers. **Run a roster cycle** runs every few weeks to collect availability, build the roster, and send notifications to volunteers.

Both start from the **Builds dashboard**.

The Builds Dashboard

The Builds dashboard is your home base for all roster activity. Open it by clicking **Builds** in the sidebar. Every roster type appears as a full-width row — one per roster — so you can see the state of your whole operation at a glance and act on any roster without leaving the page.


Sunday
Sunday
3.7 wks left
05/07/2026
12/07/2026
19/07/2026
26/07/2026
02/08/2026
09/08/2026
16/08/2026
23/08/2026
Season Confirmed
···
Click to start building
Music
Sunday
7.7 wks left
02/08/2026
09/08/2026
16/08/2026
23/08/2026
30/08/2026
06/09/2026
13/09/2026
20/09/2026
Ready to Send
···
Click to continue
Hospital Run
Daily
—
13/07/2026
14/07/2026
15/07/2026
16/07/2026
17/07/2026
18/07/2026
19/07/2026
27/07/2026
First Setup
···

The Builds dashboard — each roster type is a full-width row. On the left are the roster's icon, name, day and weeks left; across the middle, a date-chip strip shows the dates in its last build; on the right, a state button tells you where that roster is in its cycle, with the ··· menu beside it.

The state button

The coloured button on the right of each row tells you where that roster is in its cycle, with a short hint underneath (for example "Click to continue"). Clicking the button, or anywhere on the row, opens that roster's wizard at the right step, so you never have to remember where you left off.

Under the roster's name and day you'll also see how many **weeks are left** on the current roster (for example "7.4 wks left"). It turns red when the roster is running short and it's time to build again.

The date-chip strip

Across the middle of each row is a strip of date chips: the dates in the roster's last build. The colours are deliberately simple: **blue means a date that has already passed**, and **green means an upcoming date**. A roster that hasn't been built yet shows "No roster built yet" instead.

> **These two colours aren't the same as the date bands in the wizard.** On the Builds dashboard, chip colour just means past (blue) or upcoming (green). On the Build Dates screen you'll see a richer set of coloured bands for last build, this build, next build, and excluded dates. That's a different view with a different job.

Beside the state button, the **···** menu holds the rest of what you can do with a roster: pausing, adjusting dates, roles and season length, resetting, or deleting. See the ··· menu below for the full walkthrough.

> **Starting a brand-new roster type?** The green **New Roster** row at the bottom of the Builds dashboard sets one up from scratch. See Set up a new roster below.

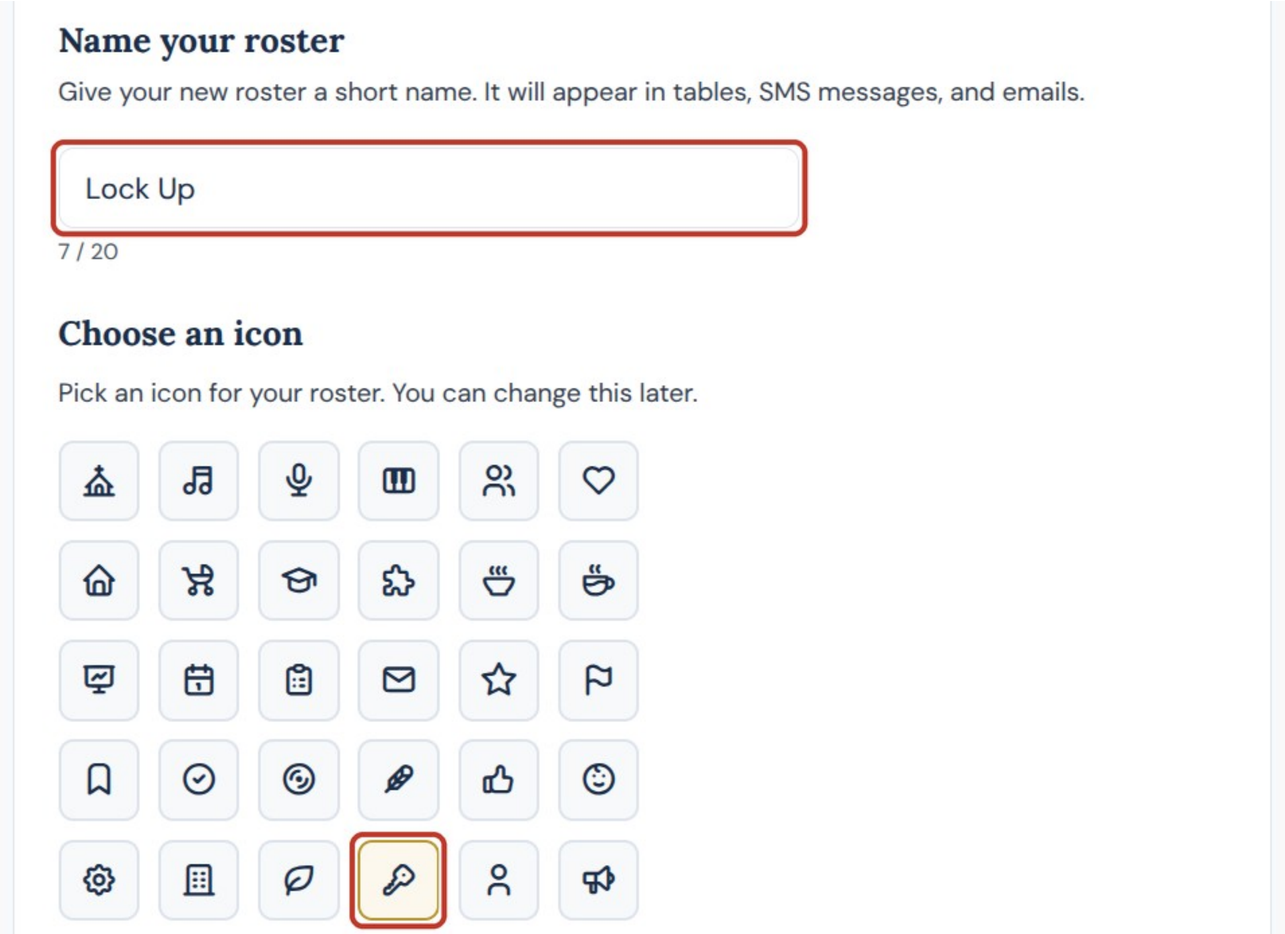
Set up a new roster

Run this wizard when you're setting up a roster type for the first time — for example, adding a Music roster or a Hospitality team. It takes about 10 minutes and walks you through five steps: Name & Icon, Roles, Season, Volunteers, and Review.

> **You only set up a roster once per roster type.** After setup is complete, every future build is a roster cycle instead.

Step 1 — Name & Icon

Give your roster a short name and choose an icon. The name appears in SMS messages, emails, and the coordinator app — so keep it brief and clear. A few words are kept for Rostas's own settings and can't be used as a roster name: Name, Email, Phone, ID, Key and Role.



Name your roster

Give your new roster a short name. It will appear in tables, SMS messages, and emails.

Lock Up

7 / 20

Choose an icon

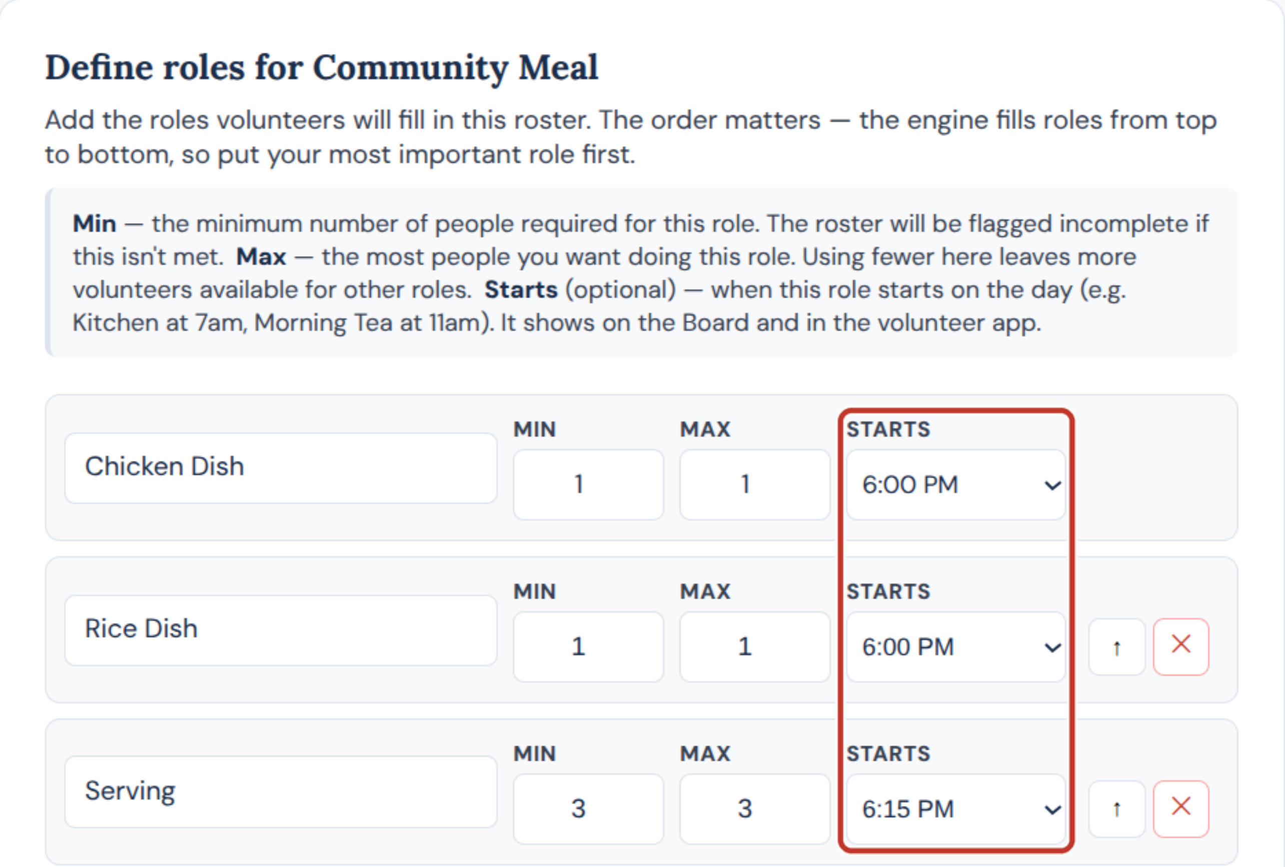
Pick an icon for your roster. You can change this later.

Step 1 — name your roster, then choose an icon. The name appears in all volunteer communications, so keep it short and recognisable — e.g. "Sunday", "Music", "Hospitality". The icon appears on the roster's row on the Builds dashboard and beside its name in the app.

Step 2 — Roles

Define the roles that need to be filled each time this roster runs. For each role, set a minimum and maximum number of people required, and, if you like, the time it **Starts**. You can add, rename, or retire roles later from Adding and changing roles.

Role times are optional. On a roster where roles start at different times (a marae day with the kitchen at 7am and the karanga at 10am, or Morning Tea at 11am), choose each role's **Starts** time. It then shows after the role name in the Roster Board's green role bars, on the volunteer's roster in the app and in emails, e.g. "Serving Morning Tea · 11am". Text messages leave it out to stay within one text. Leave it on **No time** and nothing extra is shown. You can set the same times later on the roster cycle's Roles step or in Manage roles.



Define roles for Community Meal

Add the roles volunteers will fill in this roster. The order matters — the engine fills roles from top to bottom, so put your most important role first.

Min — the minimum number of people required for this role. The roster will be flagged incomplete if this isn't met. **Max** — the most people you want doing this role. Using fewer here leaves more volunteers available for other roles. **Starts** (optional) — when this role starts on the day (e.g. Kitchen at 7am, Morning Tea at 11am). It shows on the Board and in the volunteer app.

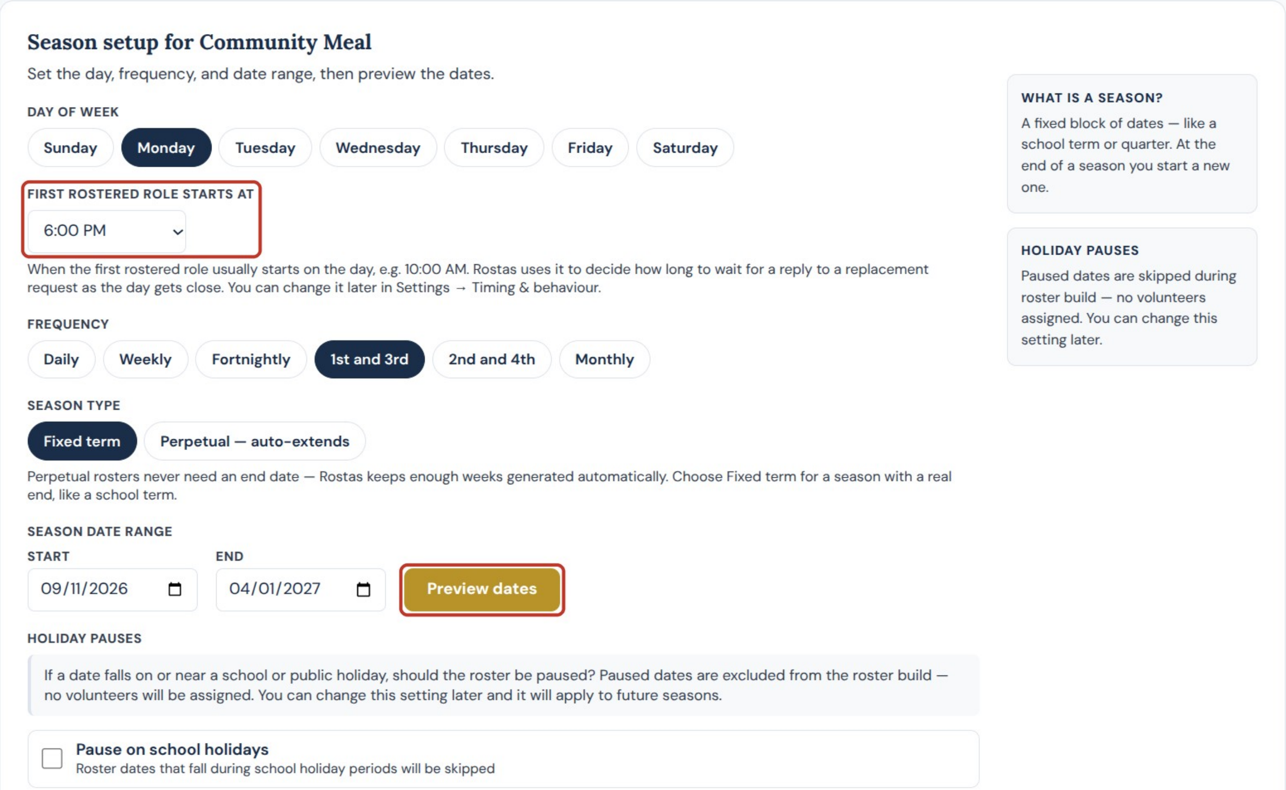
	MIN	MAX	STARTS
Chicken Dish	1	1	6:00 PM
Rice Dish	1	1	6:00 PM
Serving	3	3	6:15 PM

Step 2 — add the roles for this roster. Set minimum and maximum people for each role, and optionally when it Starts. The engine will always try to fill the minimum; it won't exceed the maximum.

Role names matter. Use clear, specific names that volunteers will recognise — e.g. "Sound Desk", "Welcome Team", "Data Projection". These names appear in SMS messages and emails sent to volunteers.

Step 3 — Season

A season defines the date range, frequency, and day of week for this roster. Rostas uses seasons to calculate which dates to roster for, and to overlay public and school holidays automatically.



Season setup for Community Meal

Set the day, frequency, and date range, then preview the dates.

DAY OF WEEK

Sunday · **Monday** · Tuesday · Wednesday · Thursday · Friday · Saturday

FIRST ROSTERED ROLE STARTS AT

6:00 PM

When the first rostered role usually starts on the day, e.g. 10:00 AM. Rostas uses it to decide how long to wait for a reply to a replacement request as the day gets close. You can change it later in Settings → Timing & behaviour.

FREQUENCY

Daily · Weekly · Fortnightly · **1st and 3rd** · 2nd and 4th · Monthly

SEASON TYPE

Fixed term · Perpetual — auto-extends

Perpetual rosters never need an end date — Rostas keeps enough weeks generated automatically. Choose Fixed term for a season with a real end, like a school term.

SEASON DATE RANGE

START: 09/11/2026

END: 04/01/2027

Preview dates

HOLIDAY PAUSES

If a date falls on or near a school or public holiday, should the roster be paused? Paused dates are excluded from the roster build — no volunteers will be assigned. You can change this setting later and it will apply to future seasons.

☐ Pause on school holidays
Roster dates that fall during school holiday periods will be skipped

WHAT IS A SEASON?

A fixed block of dates — like a school term or quarter. At the end of a season you start a new one.

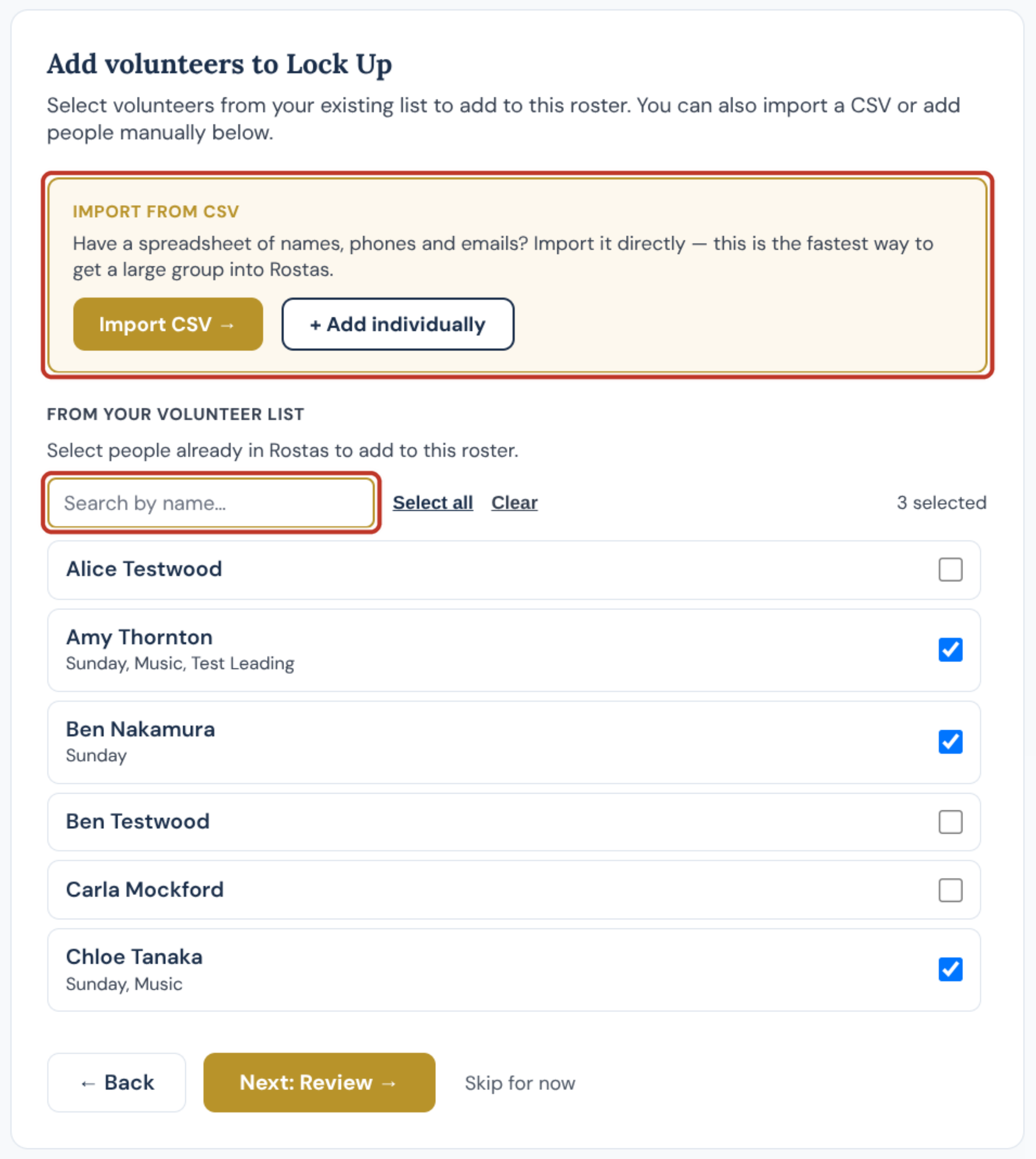
HOLIDAY PAUSES

Paused dates are skipped during roster build — no volunteers assigned. You can change this setting later.

Step 3 — set up your first season. Choose day of week, frequency, and date range. First rostered role starts at is filled in from the earliest role time you set in Step 2. Click Preview dates and the projected dates appear as pills below — school holidays are labelled automatically so you can see which dates will be paused.

Step 4 — Volunteers

Select which volunteers from your list will serve on this roster. Tick each volunteer you want to include. Only volunteers already in Rostas appear here — if someone is missing, add them in Profiles first then return to this step.



Add volunteers to Lock Up

Select volunteers from your existing list to add to this roster. You can also import a CSV or add people manually below.

IMPORT FROM CSV

Have a spreadsheet of names, phones and emails? Import it directly — this is the fastest way to get a large group into Rostas.

FROM YOUR VOLUNTEER LIST

Select people already in Rostas to add to this roster.

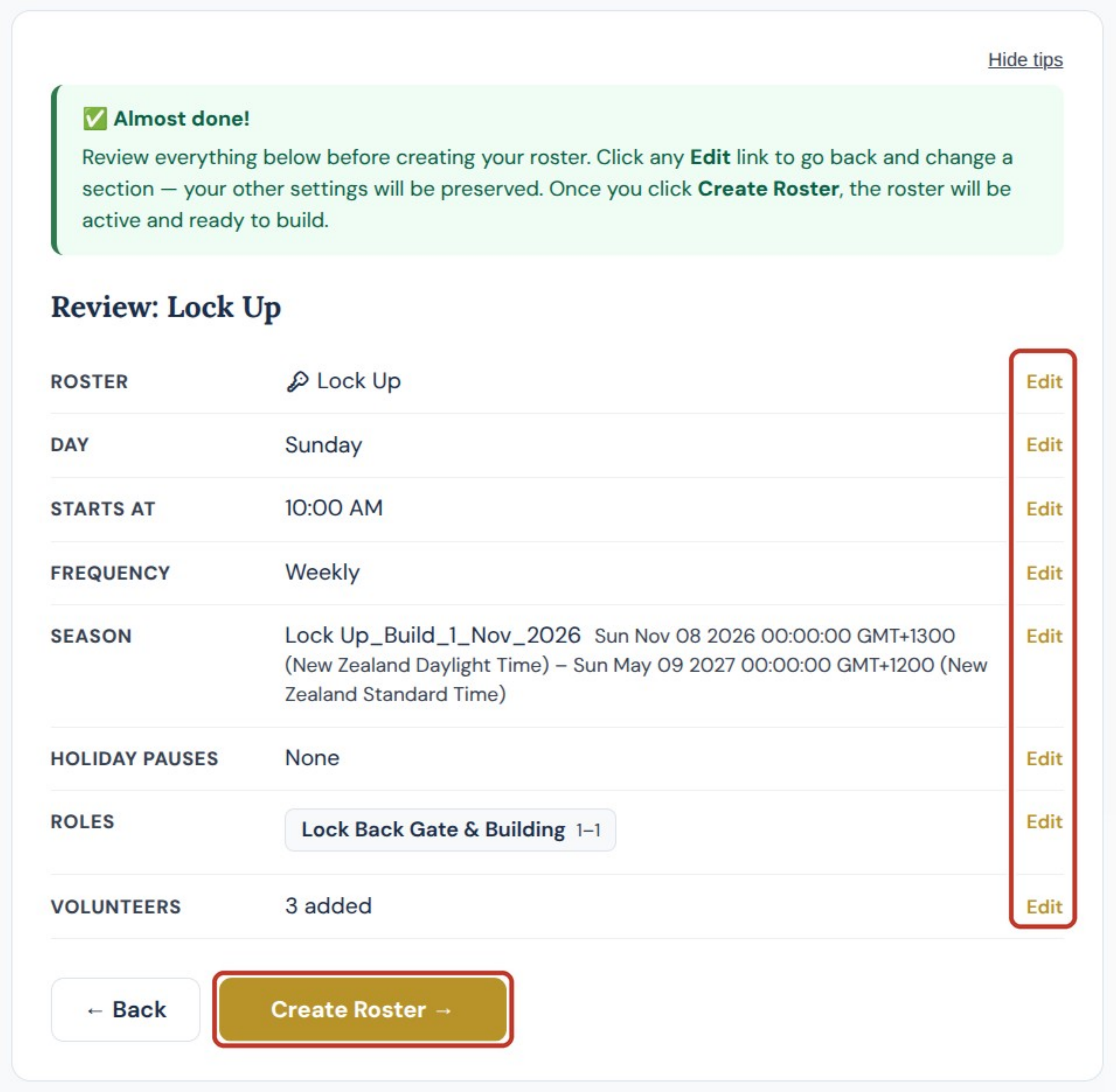
3 selected

- **Alice Testwood** ☐
- **Amy Thornton** — Sunday, Music, Test Leading ☑
- **Ben Nakamura** — Sunday ☑
- **Ben Testwood** ☐
- **Carla Mockford** ☐
- **Chloe Tanaka** — Sunday, Music ☑

Step 4 — tick each volunteer who serves in this roster. Use the search field to find someone quickly if you have a large list. You can also import additional volunteers via CSV from this step.

Step 5 — Review

The final step shows a summary of everything you've set up — roster name, icon, roles, season dates, and volunteer count. Review it carefully before confirming.



Hide tips

✅ **Almost done!**

Review everything below before creating your roster. Click any **Edit** link to go back and change a section — your other settings will be preserved. Once you click **Create Roster**, the roster will be active and ready to build.

Review: Lock Up

ROSTER	Lock Up	Edit
DAY	Sunday	Edit
STARTS AT	10:00 AM	Edit
FREQUENCY	Weekly	Edit
SEASON	Lock Up_Build_1_Nov_2026 Sun Nov 08 2026 00:00:00 GMT+1300 (New Zealand Daylight Time) – Sun May 09 2027 00:00:00 GMT+1200 (New Zealand Standard Time)	Edit
HOLIDAY PAUSES	None	Edit
ROLES	Lock Back Gate & Building 1–1	Edit
VOLUNTEERS	3 added	Edit

Step 5 — review your roster setup before confirming. You can go back to any previous step to make changes. Once confirmed, the roster appears on the Builds dashboard.

Click **Create Roster →** to finish. Rostas takes you straight into the roster cycle for your new roster, ready for its first build, and the roster appears on the Builds dashboard.

Run a roster cycle

The roster cycle is what you run every few weeks. Each roster type has its own (the page is headed "Run the [your roster] roster cycle") and it takes you through the same six steps every time: **Confirm Dates, Roles, Role Prefs, Availability, Build & Check, and Notify**.

To start, open the **Builds** dashboard and click a roster's row or state button. If a build is already under way, you're taken straight back to the step you left off at.

Finding your way around the wizard

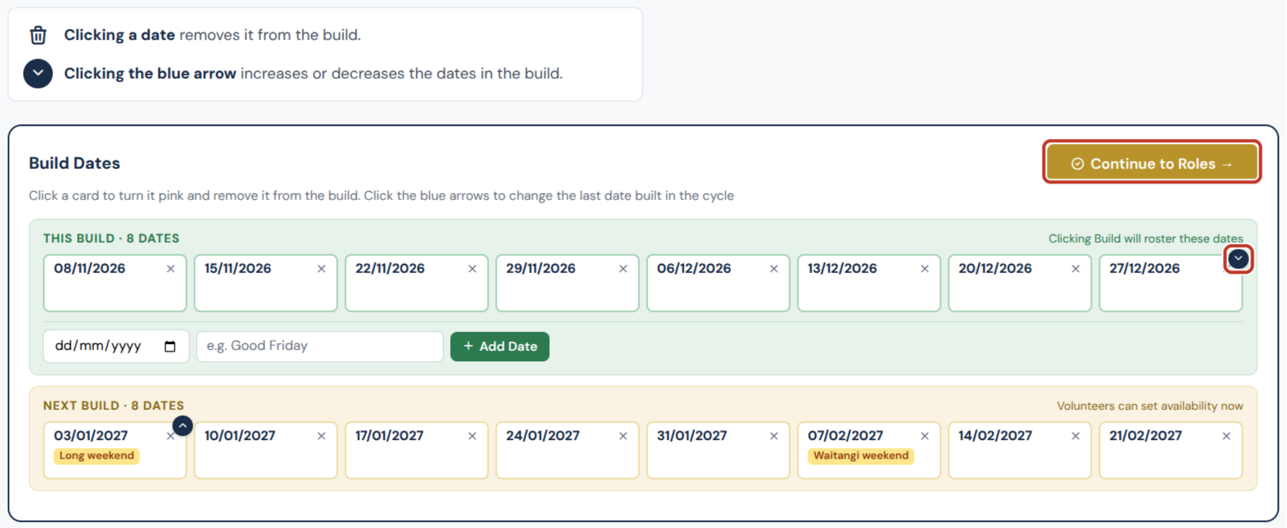
Across the top of every step is a row of six circles, one per step. Each says how that step stands: **Completed**, **Skipped**, **In progress**, **Ready** or **Pending**. Click a completed or skipped circle to look at that step again; click **Confirm Dates** at any time to go back to the dates.

Directly under the circles is one bar that stays in the same place on every step: **← Back** on the left, "Step N of 6" in the middle, and the main button (for example **Continue to Role Prefs →**) on the right. Some steps have their own buttons inside the card instead, and then the right-hand button is hidden.

Step 1 — Confirm Dates

The wizard opens on the **Build Dates** screen, where you confirm which dates this build covers. A small box at the top reminds you how it works: **clicking a date** removes it from the build, and **clicking the blue arrow** makes the build longer or shorter. You can also add a one-off date with **+ Add Date**. All of this is explained in [Choosing which dates to build]() below.

When the dates look right, click **Continue to Roles →** on the Build Dates title row. That saves the dates and takes you to the next step.



Clicking a date removes it from the build.

Clicking the blue arrow increases or decreases the dates in the build.

Build Dates

Click a card to turn it pink and remove it from the build. Click the blue arrows to change the last date built in the cycle

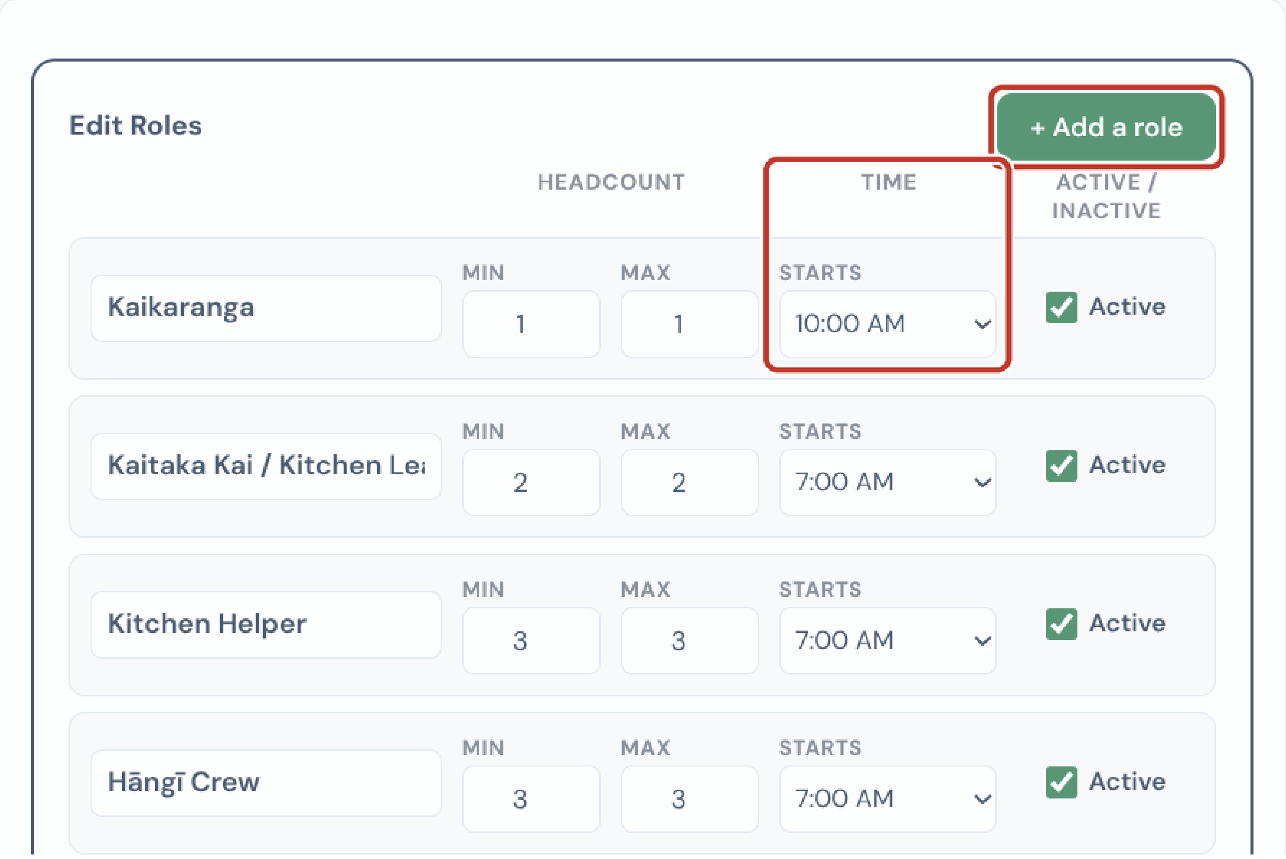
Continue to Roles →
THIS BUILD · 8 DATES
Clicking Build will roster these dates
08/11/2026
15/11/2026
22/11/2026
29/11/2026
06/12/2026
13/12/2026
20/12/2026
27/12/2026
dd/mm/yyyy
e.g. Good Friday
+ Add Date
NEXT BUILD · 8 DATES
Volunteers can set availability now
03/01/2027
Long weekend
10/01/2027
17/01/2027
24/01/2027
31/01/2027
07/02/2027
Waitangi weekend
14/02/2027
21/02/2027

Step 1 — Confirm Dates. Last Build dates are locked (change those on the Board); This Build shows how many dates this build will roster. Remove or add dates, move the boundary with the blue arrow, then click Continue to Roles.

Step 2 — Roles

This step shows one card, **Edit Roles**: every role on this roster with its name, its **Min** and **Max** headcount, the time it **Starts**, and an **Active** tick box. You can rename a role, change its headcount, set or change its start time, untick it to leave it out, or use **+ Add a role**. What you set here carries forward to later builds. Roles start out as they were last time, so on a routine build you can usually just click **Continue to Role Prefs →**.

There's no separate Save button: any change you make is saved when you leave the step, whether by Back, Continue, or clicking a circle at the top.



	HEADCOUNT		TIME	ACTIVE / INACTIVE
	MIN	MAX	STARTS	
Kaikaranga	1	1	10:00 AM	☑ Active
Kaitaka Kai / Kitchen Le	2	2	7:00 AM	☑ Active
Kitchen Helper	3	3	7:00 AM	☑ Active
Hāngī Crew	3	3	7:00 AM	☑ Active

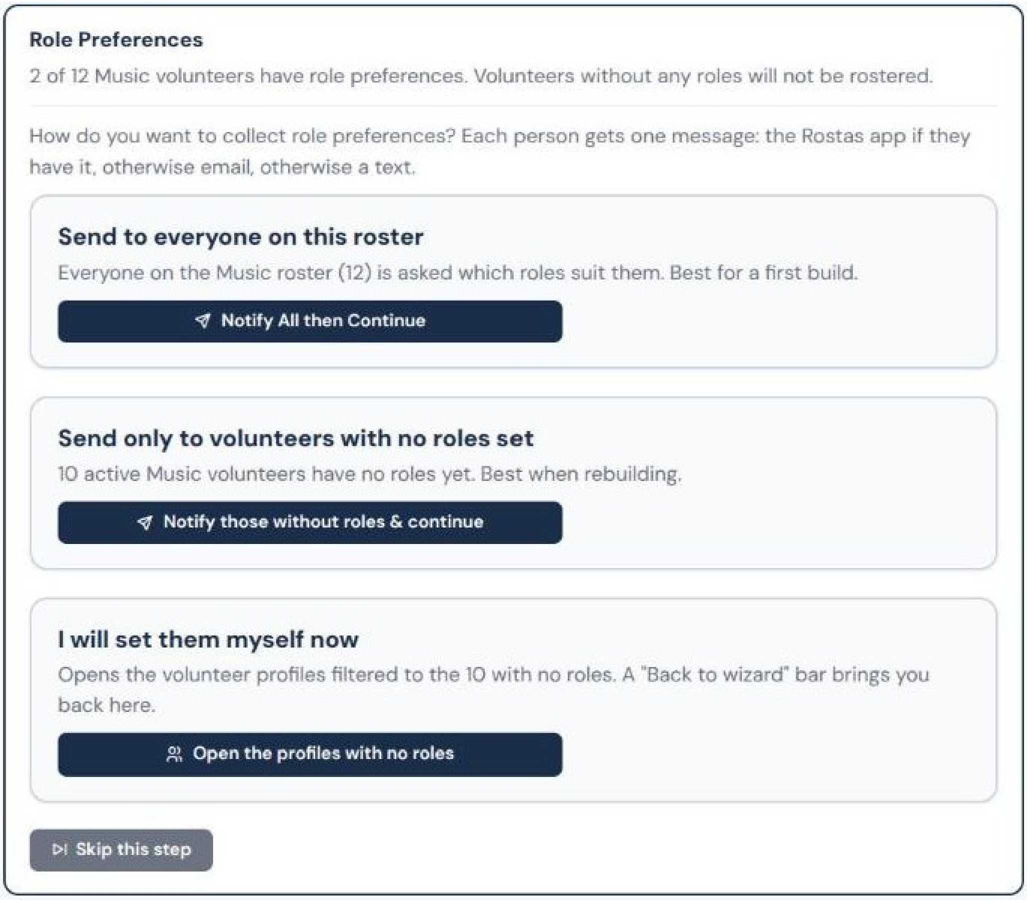
Step 2 — Roles. Set the minimum and maximum people each role needs, or untick a role you don't need. + Add a role adds a blank row at the bottom: type the new role's name and set its headcount.

> **Changing the order roles are filled in?** Do that from Manage roles on the ··· menu.

Step 3 — Role Prefs

This step asks volunteers which roles suit them. At the top it tells you how many volunteers on this roster already have role preferences. Volunteers with no roles set won't be rostered. Choose one of these:

The two "send only..." and "set them myself" options only appear when some volunteers have no roles. Each volunteer gets **one message**: through the Rostas app if they have it, otherwise by email, otherwise by text.



Role Preferences

2 of 12 Music volunteers have role preferences. Volunteers without any roles will not be rostered.

How do you want to collect role preferences? Each person gets one message: the Rostas app if they have it, otherwise email, otherwise a text.

Send to everyone on this roster

Everyone on the Music roster (12) is asked which roles suit them. Best for a first build.

Send only to volunteers with no roles set

10 active Music volunteers have no roles yet. Best when rebuilding.

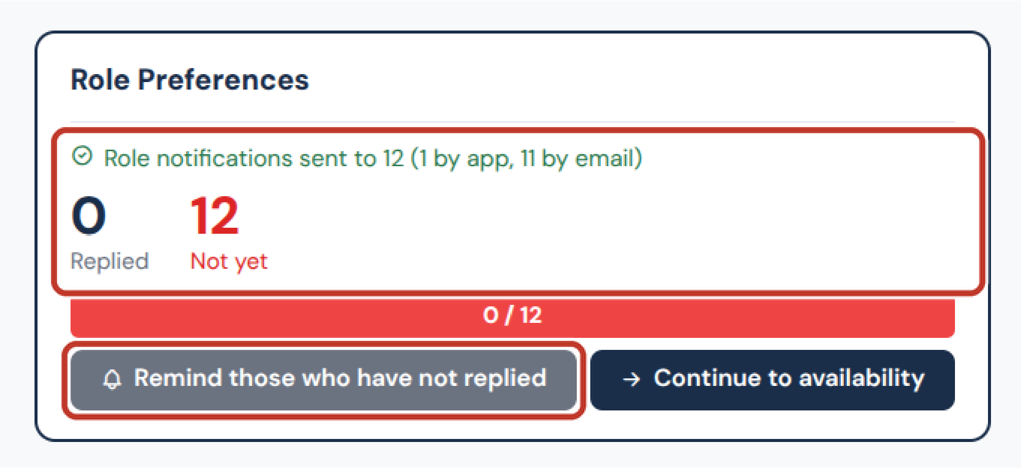
I will set them myself now

Opens the volunteer profiles filtered to the 10 with no roles. A "Back to wizard" bar brings you back here.

Notify All then Continue
Notify those without roles & continue
Open the profiles with no roles
Skip this step

The Role Prefs options. The line at the top says how many volunteers already have role preferences, and each card says how many it would reach.

After you send, the step shows how the messages went (for example "Role notifications sent to 24 (18 by app, 5 by email, 1 by text)"), with a count of who has **Replied** and who has **Not yet**. Use **Remind those who have not replied** if you want to give people a nudge, and **Continue to availability** when you're ready to move on. You don't have to wait for every reply before moving on.



Role Preferences

Role notifications sent to 12 (1 by app, 11 by email)

0 Replied

12 Not yet

0 / 12

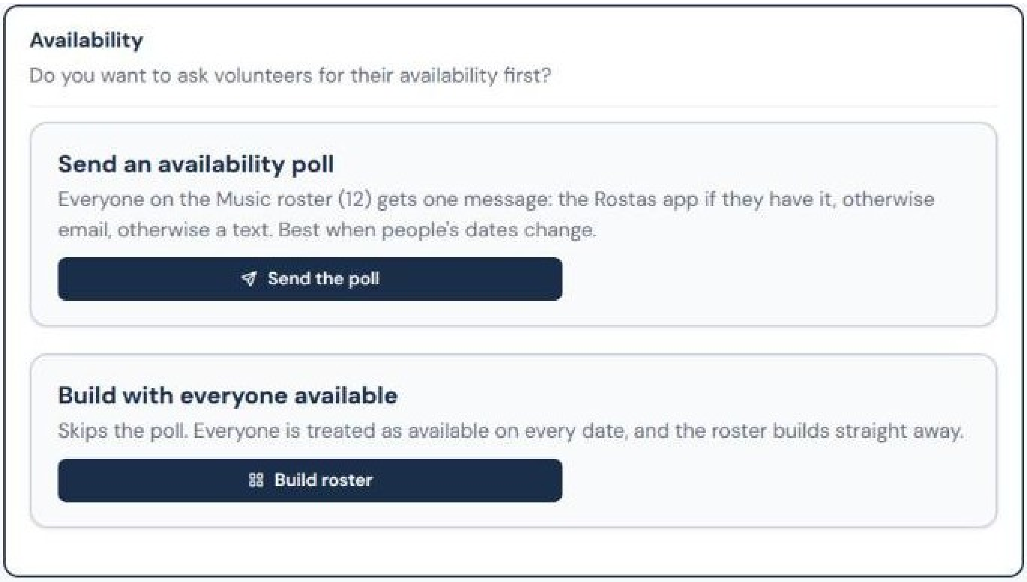
Remind those who have not replied
Continue to availability

Role Prefs after sending. The Replied and Not yet counts update as volunteers answer.

> **Changed your mind after skipping?** Click the Role Prefs circle at the top. A skipped step shows the same options again, and choosing one replaces the skip.

Step 4 — Availability

This step asks: *do you want to ask volunteers for their availability first?* You have two choices:



Availability

Do you want to ask volunteers for their availability first?

Send an availability poll

Everyone on the Music roster (12) gets one message: the Rostas app if they have it, otherwise email, otherwise a text. Best when people's dates change.

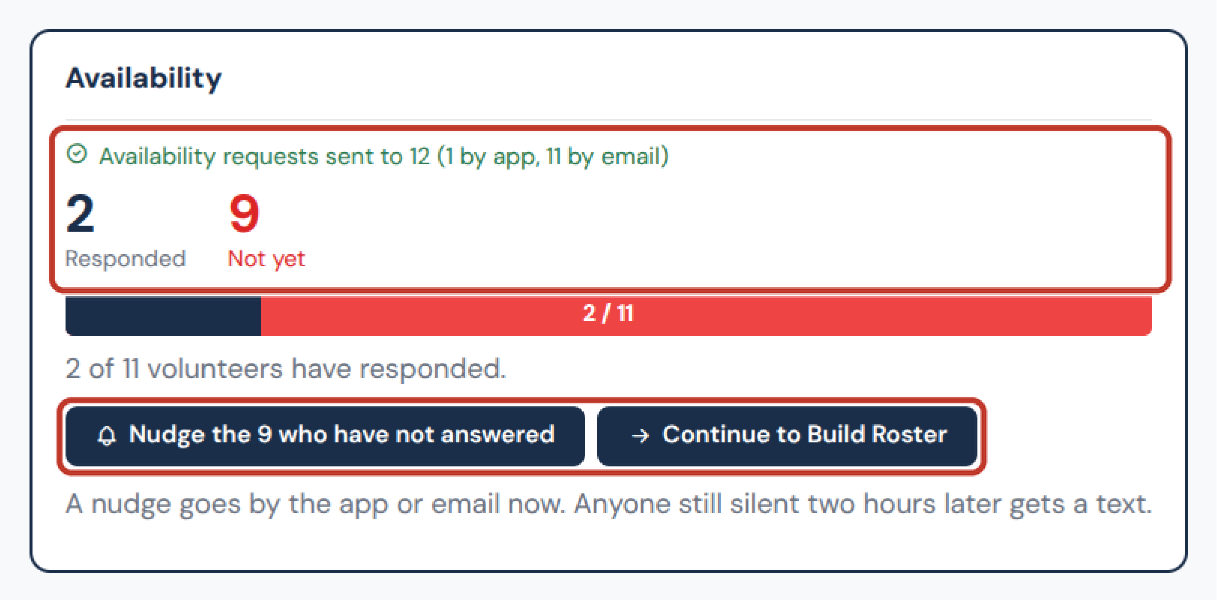
Build with everyone available

Skips the poll. Everyone is treated as available on every date, and the roster builds straight away.

The Availability question. The poll card says how many volunteers it will go to.

To send the poll:

1. Choose **Send an availability poll**.
2. Click **Send the poll**. Sending takes about a minute.
3. Watch the **Responded** and **Not yet** counts as replies come in. The step also says how the poll went out (for example "Availability requests sent to 30 (30 by email)").



Availability

Availability requests sent to 12 (1 by app, 11 by email)

2 Responded

9 Not yet

2 of 11 volunteers have responded.

A nudge goes by the app or email now. Anyone still silent two hours later gets a text.

Waiting for replies. The counts update as volunteers answer.

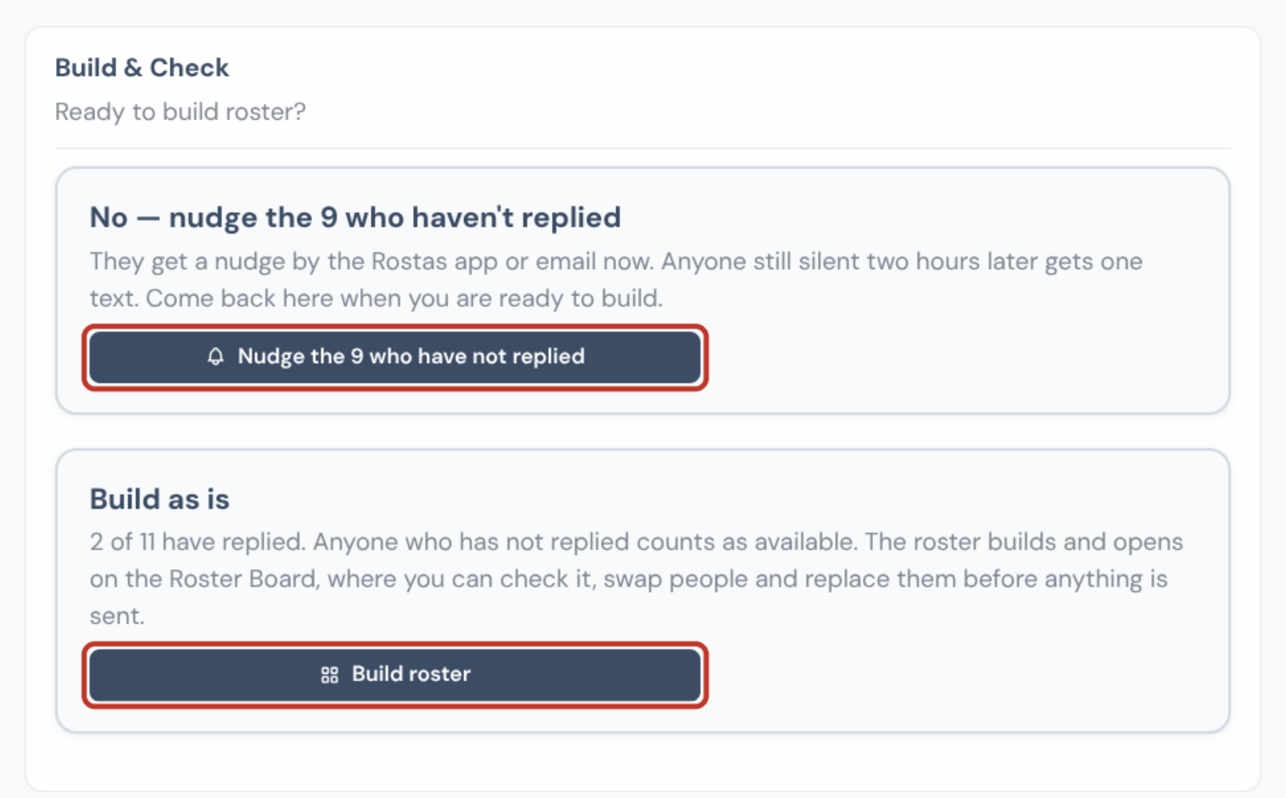
4. To chase the rest, click **Nudge the [N] who have not answered**. The nudge goes by the app or email straight away. Anyone still silent two hours later gets one text (never during quiet hours).

5. When you're ready, click **Continue to Build Roster**.

> **Give people a few days to reply** before you build. You can leave the wizard and come back; the roster shows **Gathering** on the Builds dashboard in the meantime.

Step 5 — Build & Check

This step asks **Ready to build roster?** If some volunteers still haven't answered the poll, you can **nudge** them first and come back later. Otherwise choose **Build as is** → *Build roster*. Anyone who hasn't replied counts as available.


Build & Check

Ready to build roster?

No — nudge the 9 who haven't replied

They get a nudge by the Rostas app or email now. Anyone still silent two hours later gets one text. Come back here when you are ready to build.

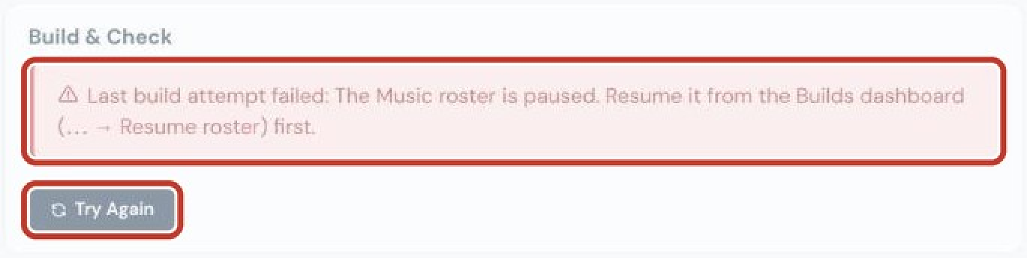
Build as is

2 of 11 have replied. Anyone who has not replied counts as available. The roster builds and opens on the Roster Board, where you can check it, swap people and replace them before anything is sent.

Step 5 — Build & Check. Nudge the stragglers, or build now.

The roster engine looks at every volunteer's availability, role preferences, how recently they've served and how often they want to serve, and fills every slot it can (see [The Intelligent Matching Engine](#)). A build can take up to 5–10 minutes for a big roster. When it's finished, the **Roster Board opens by itself**.

> **If a build can't complete** (for example the roster is paused, your Rostas subscription has lapsed, or a role or date setting blocks it), the step says "Last build attempt failed" with the reason, and a **Try Again** button for once it's fixed.



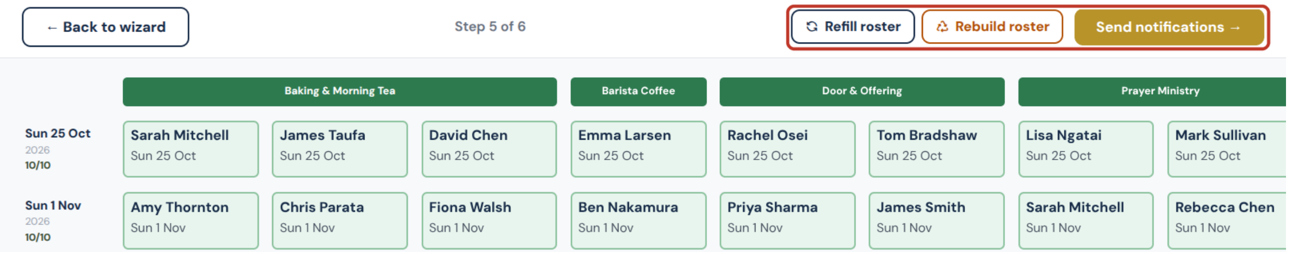
Build & Check

⚠ Last build attempt failed: The Music roster is paused. Resume it from the Builds dashboard (… → Resume roster) first.

If a build fails, the step shows exactly why (here, the roster was paused) and lets you try again once it's fixed.

Checking the roster on the Board

The Board is where you check the roster before anyone is told. Until you send, it shows the wizard's step circles across the top and a bar with ← **Back to wizard**, "Step 5 of 6", and three buttons:

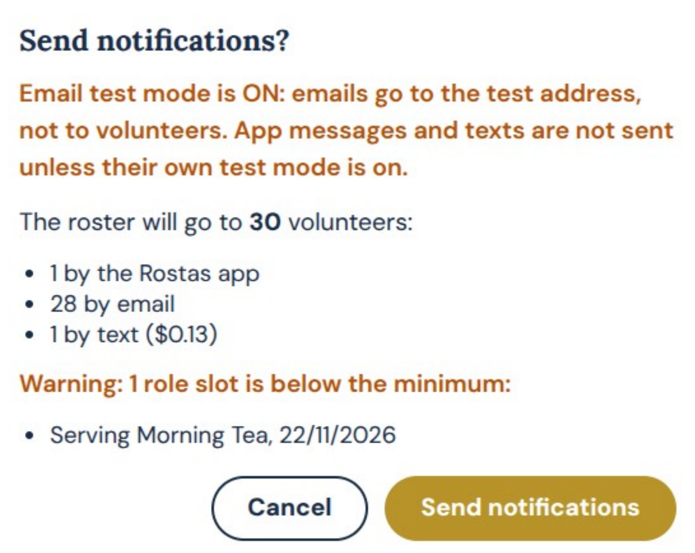


	Baking & Morning Tea			Barista Coffee	Door & Offering		Prayer Ministry	
Sun 25 Oct 2026 10/10	Sarah Mitchell Sun 25 Oct	James Taufa Sun 25 Oct	David Chen Sun 25 Oct	Emma Larsen Sun 25 Oct	Rachel Osei Sun 25 Oct	Tom Bradshaw Sun 25 Oct	Lisa Ngatai Sun 25 Oct	Mark Sullivan Sun 25 Oct
Sun 1 Nov 2026 10/10	Amy Thornton Sun 1 Nov	Chris Parata Sun 1 Nov	Fiona Walsh Sun 1 Nov	Ben Nakamura Sun 1 Nov	Priya Sharma Sun 1 Nov	James Smith Sun 1 Nov	Sarah Mitchell Sun 1 Nov	Rebecca Chen Sun 1 Nov

The Board after a build. Click any cell to swap or replace someone, then Send notifications when you're happy.

When the roster looks right:

1. Click **Send notifications →** on the Board. Nothing is sent yet.
2. Read the box. It shows how many volunteers will be told by the Rostas app, by email and by text (with the cost of the texts), anyone who must wait until quiet hours end, anyone who can't be reached, and any role still **below its minimum**.



Send notifications?

Email test mode is ON: emails go to the test address, not to volunteers. App messages and texts are not sent unless their own test mode is on.

The roster will go to **30** volunteers:

- 1 by the Rostas app
- 28 by email
- 1 by text ($0.13)

Warning: 1 role slot is below the minimum:

- Serving Morning Tea, 22/11/2026

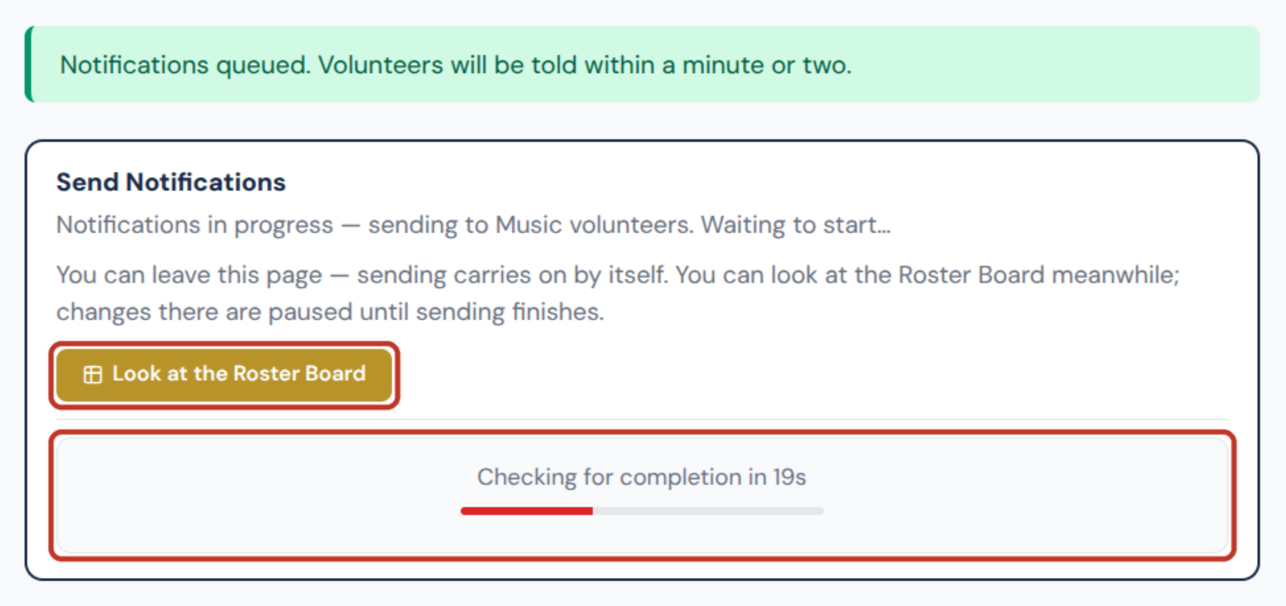
The check before anything is sent.

3. Click **Send notifications** in the box to go ahead. (Click **Cancel** to keep working on the Board.)

> **Don't skip the check.** It's your last chance to catch problems before volunteers are told. Look for red (unfilled) slots and make any swaps you need first.

Step 6 — Notify

After you send from the Board, the wizard opens on the Notify step. While messages are going out it shows "Sent N of M so far". You can leave the page and sending carries on by itself. You can look at the Board meanwhile (**Look at the Roster Board**), but changes there are paused until sending finishes. The Notify circle reads "Sending…" until it's done.



Notifications queued. Volunteers will be told within a minute or two.

Send Notifications

Notifications in progress — sending to Music volunteers. Waiting to start...

You can leave this page — sending carries on by itself. You can look at the Roster Board meanwhile; changes there are paused until sending finishes.

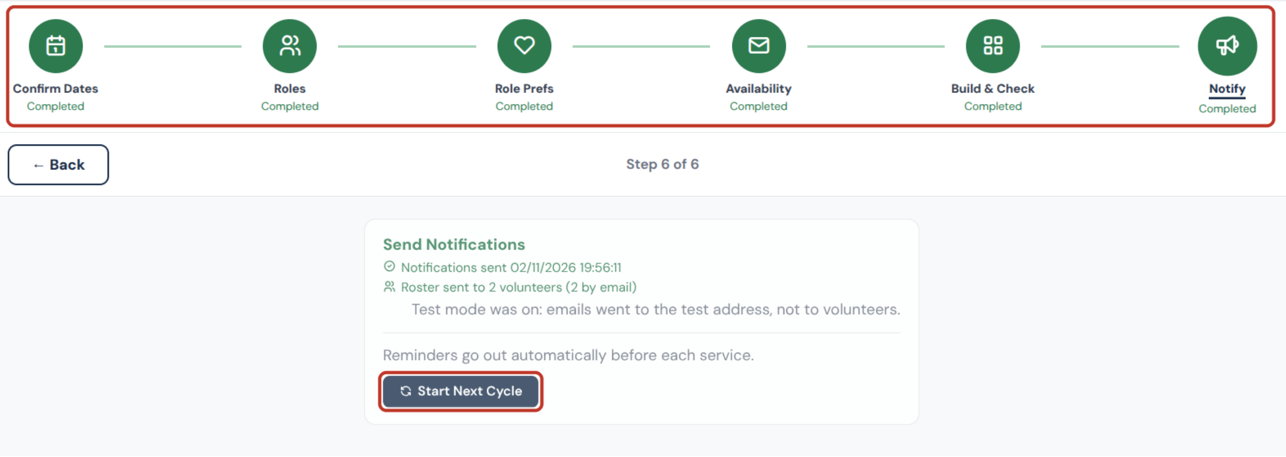
Checking for completion in 19s

Sending in progress. The page checks every few seconds and shows the result when sending finishes.

Each volunteer gets one message with their roles and dates and confirm and decline links: through the Rostas app if they have it, otherwise by email, otherwise by text. When it's done, the step shows when notifications were sent and how many people were told and how (for example "Roster sent to 29 volunteers (29 by email)"). It also tells you about anyone who wasn't reached:

- **Text-only volunteers during quiet hours**: their text waits until quiet hours end.
- **Couldn't be reached just now**: the message didn't go through.
- **No app, email or phone number**: they can't be told; add their details on their profile.

If anyone can still be reached, a **Send to the N not yet reached** button tries them again. When you're ready to start the next roster, click **Start Next Cycle**.


Confirm Dates
Completed
Roles
Completed
Role Prefs
Completed
Availability
Completed
Build & Check
Completed
Notify
Completed
← Back
Step 6 of 6
Start Next Cycle

Send Notifications

Notifications sent 02/11/2026 19:56:11

Roster sent to 2 volunteers (2 by email)

Test mode was on: emails went to the test address, not to volunteers.

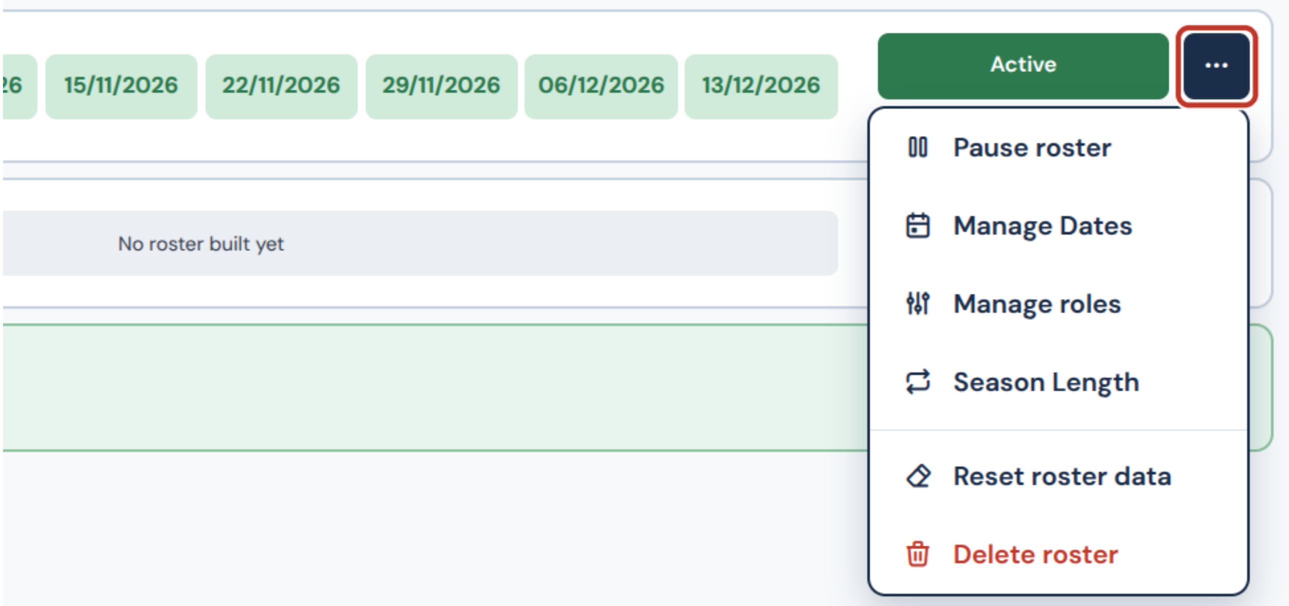
Reminders go out automatically before each service.

Step 6 — Notify. All six circles show complete, and automatic reminders are queued.

- Reminder email sent 3 days before each rostered date (change this in Settings → Timing & behaviour → Reminder days before service)
- The day before, an app notification or a text, depending on Settings → Timing & behaviour → Day-before reminder texts
- If a volunteer taps "Can't make it", the SMS replacement chain starts automatically

Pausing, re-dating or removing a roster (the ··· menu)

The ··· menu beside each row's state button on the Builds dashboard holds everything you do with a roster between builds — pausing it, adjusting its dates or roles, changing its season length, clearing its data, or deleting it outright. Click it to open a pop-up of options.


26
15/11/2026
22/11/2026
29/11/2026
06/12/2026
13/12/2026
Active
···
No roster built yet
Pause roster
Manage Dates
Manage roles
Season Length
Reset roster data
Delete roster

The ··· menu open on a roster row. When a roster is paused, the top option reads "Resume roster" instead of "Pause roster".

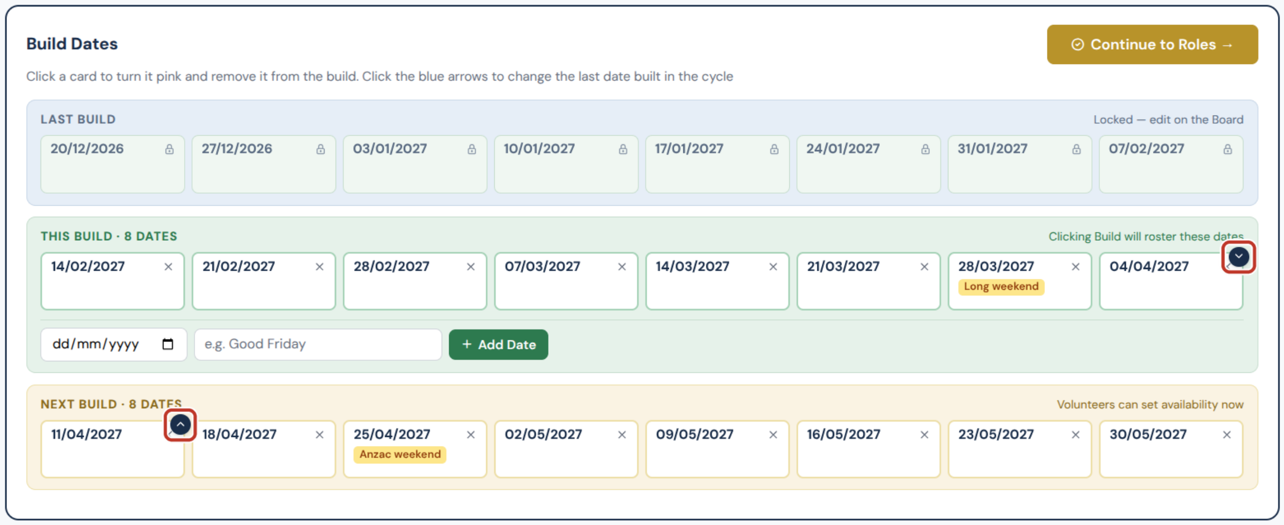
Pause / Resume roster

Pausing a roster stops all automatic activity for it straight away — no builds, no reminder emails or texts, no availability emails or nudges, and no replacement chains (a chain already running stops asking people) — without losing any history. Anything that falls due while it's paused is skipped, not saved up for later. The menu option and the row's state button both switch to **Resume roster** while paused; click either to pick back up exactly where you left off.

Choosing which dates to build

Before each build you confirm exactly which dates it covers, on the **Build Dates** screen. It lays out your roster's dates in three bands — what's already built, what this build will cover, and what's coming next — and lets you drop a date you don't want, shift the boundary between builds, or add a one-off extra date such as Christmas Day or Good Friday.

You reach it two ways: as the first step of a build (Confirm Dates), or on its own from the Builds dashboard — **···** — **Manage Dates**. A small box at the top of the screen sums up the two main controls: clicking a date removes it from the build, and clicking the blue arrow makes the build longer or shorter.



Build Dates

Click a card to turn it pink and remove it from the build. Click the blue arrows to change the last date built in the cycle

LAST BUILD — Locked — edit on the Board
20/12/2026 · 27/12/2026 · 03/01/2027 · 10/01/2027 · 17/01/2027 · 24/01/2027 · 31/01/2027 · 07/02/2027

THIS BUILD · 8 DATES — Clicking Build will roster these dates
14/02/2027 · 21/02/2027 · 28/02/2027 · 07/03/2027 · 14/03/2027 · 21/03/2027 · 28/03/2027 (Long weekend) · 04/04/2027

NEXT BUILD · 8 DATES — Volunteers can set availability now
11/04/2027 · 18/04/2027 · 25/04/2027 (Anzac weekend) · 02/05/2027 · 09/05/2027 · 16/05/2027 · 23/05/2027 · 30/05/2027

The Build Dates screen — each date is a card, grouped into three bands. Coloured tags on a card show anything Rostas has flagged about that date: a public holiday, a long weekend, or a label you've added yourself. The blue arrows sit on the dates at the edge of each band.

Removing a date

Click any date card in This Build or Next Build to exclude it — the card turns pink and drops out of the build. Click it again to bring the date back. Cards in Last Build can't be removed this way, since they're already built.

Shifting the boundary between builds

A small blue arrow sits on the date at the boundary between This Build and Next Build. Click it to move that date across the line — pulling the next upcoming date into This Build to extend how far this build reaches, or sending the last date of This Build back into Next Build to shorten it.

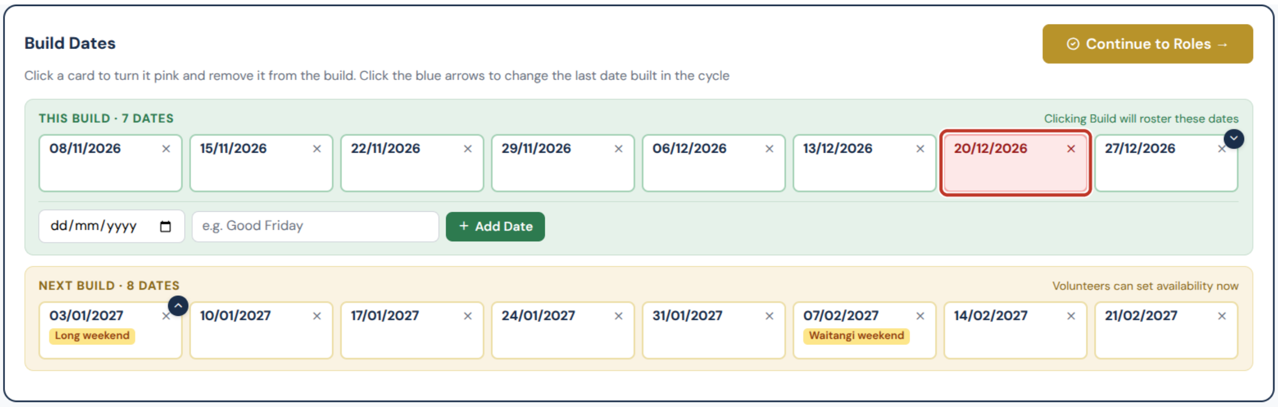
Adding an extra date

To add a one-off date outside the normal pattern, such as Christmas Eve, Good Friday or a special event:

1. In the date box under **This Build**, pick the date.
2. In the box beside it, type a short label (for example "Good Friday").
3. Click **+ Add Date**. The new card appears in This Build with your label as a tag, and is included the next time you build.

> **Holidays are tagged automatically — but tagging and pausing aren't the same thing.** Dates that fall directly on a public holiday or a school

holiday are labelled for you, and look distinct from dates you've excluded by hand, so you can tell an automatic holiday from a deliberate choice. Long weekends (Labour Weekend, Anzac Weekend, and others) get their own distinct yellow tag too — but the tag alone doesn't pause anything. Only a **direct hit** on the public holiday or school holiday itself pauses the roster (and only if you've ticked **Pause public holidays** / **Pause school holidays** for this roster type). A long-weekend Sunday that isn't itself the public holiday still needs rostering as normal — exclude it by hand if you don't want it covered.



Build Dates

Click a card to turn it pink and remove it from the build. Click the blue arrows to change the last date built in the cycle

THIS BUILD · 7 DATES

Clicking Build will roster these dates

08/11/2026 ×
15/11/2026 ×
22/11/2026 ×
29/11/2026 ×
06/12/2026 ×
13/12/2026 ×
20/12/2026 ×
27/12/2026 ×

NEXT BUILD · 8 DATES

Volunteers can set availability now

03/01/2027 × Long weekend
10/01/2027 ×
17/01/2027 ×
24/01/2027 ×
31/01/2027 ×
07/02/2027 × Waitangi weekend
14/02/2027 ×
21/02/2027 ×

Excluding a date — a common example is the Sunday just after Christmas, when most people are away: click the × to turn it pink and it drops out of the build.

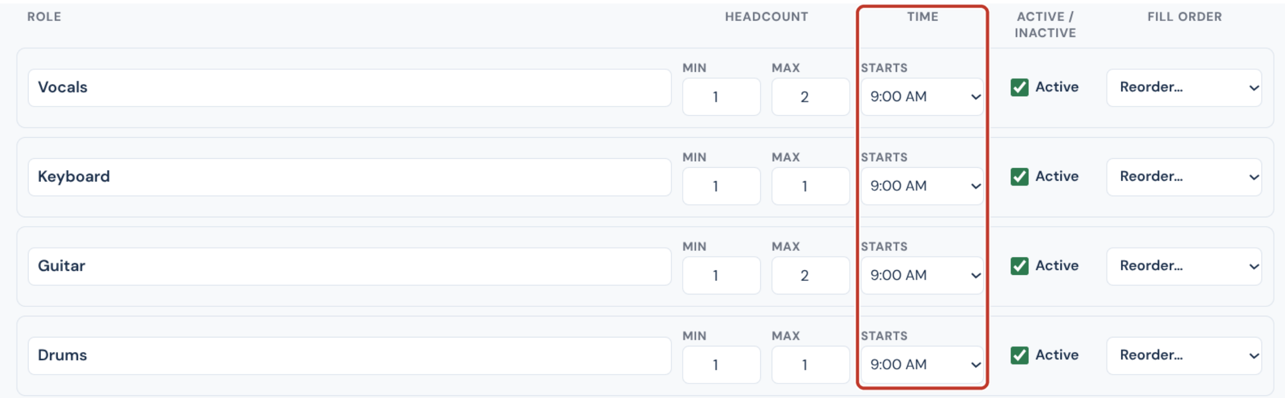
Confirm early. Ideally do this a few weeks before the dates arrive, so there's time to collect availability and build. A **perpetual** roster rolls forward on its own, so each cycle you're simply confirming the next stretch of dates; a **fixed-term** roster is confirmed up to its end date. (See Season type for the difference.)

Nothing changes until you save. Removing, shifting, or adding dates only takes effect once you click **Continue to Roles →** (in the wizard) or **Save** (when you opened Manage Dates from the ⋯ menu) — leaving without saving discards your changes. When you open this screen standalone via Manage Dates, saved changes apply from the next build onward; dates already built are never altered.

Adding and changing roles

Once a roster exists, you can add, rename, re-size, reorder or retire its roles at any time:

1. Open **Builds**.
2. Click the **···** button on the roster's row.
3. Click **Manage roles**. The page lists every role with its headcount, its start time and an active switch.



ROLE	HEADCOUNT		TIME	ACTIVE / INACTIVE	FILL ORDER
	MIN	MAX	STARTS		
Vocals	1	2	9:00 AM	☑ Active	Reorder...
Keyboard	1	1	9:00 AM	☑ Active	Reorder...
Guitar	1	2	9:00 AM	☑ Active	Reorder...
Drums	1	1	9:00 AM	☑ Active	Reorder...

Each role shows its Headcount (the minimum and maximum people to roster), its Time (when it starts, optional) and an Active / Inactive switch.

4. Make your changes (see the table below).
5. Click **Save** at the top right.

Fill order — which role gets first pick

Rostas fills roles **top-to-bottom** in the order they're listed here — locking each one in fully before moving to the next. If a volunteer is capable of more than one role on a roster, whichever role sits higher in this list gets first claim on them for that date.

Use the **Fill Order** control on any role — **Move to top / Move up / Move down / Move to bottom** — to change where it sits. This matters most for a role with a thin, shared bench: putting it higher gives it first pick of your multi-capable volunteers instead of leftovers.

Reordering redistributes, it doesn't create capacity. Moving a role up can close its own shortfall, but only by taking a shared volunteer away from whatever role used to get them first. See Insights for exactly which role would carry that cost before you decide.

Changes apply from your next build onward. Renaming a role, changing its headcount, switching it active or inactive, or adding a new role all take effect at the next build — dates you've already built keep their original roles and wording. Nothing changes underneath the volunteers you've already notified.

Deactivate rather than delete. Deactivating a role keeps the full history of who served in it; it just stops appearing in new builds. Reach for deactivate unless you're correcting a genuine setup mistake.

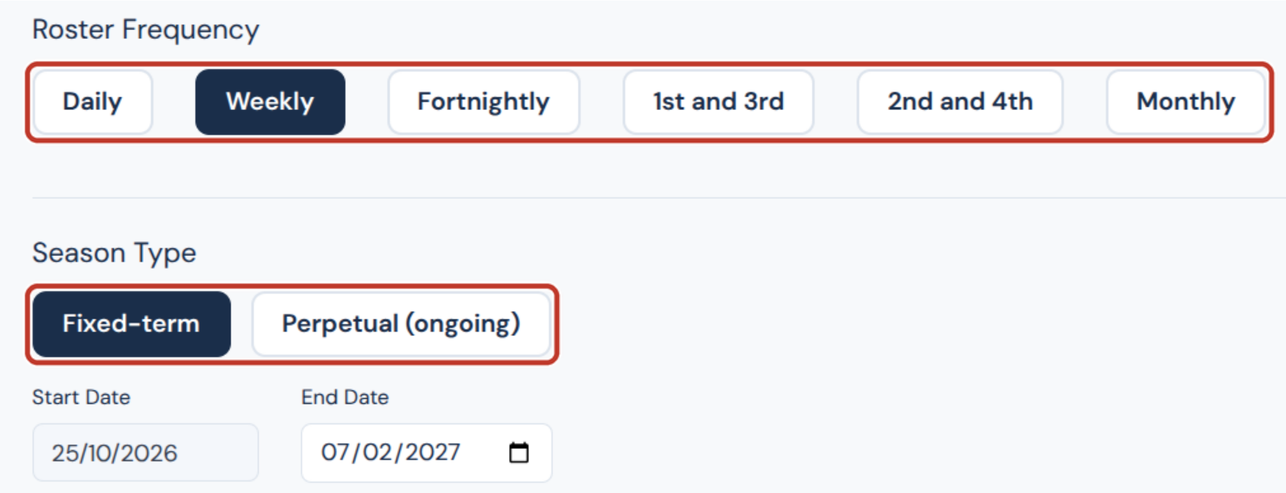
Mind the timing when renaming mid-cycle. Because a rename only affects messages sent after it, volunteers already notified will have the old name in their earlier email or text. If you rename partway through a cycle, expect a brief mismatch until the next build.

How often a roster runs

There are two separate frequency ideas in Rostas: how often the *roster* runs, and how often each *volunteer* serves. This section covers the roster side — its cadence and whether the season is fixed or ongoing. The per-volunteer cap is set on each person's profile (see Frequency on the Profile detail page); the two are explained together at the end.

Roster cadence — how often the roster runs

Not every roster runs weekly. A community meal might run fortnightly, a kids' ministry only on the 1st and 3rd Sunday, a review team monthly. The **Roster Frequency** setting on the **Season Length** page sets this cadence per roster type — it decides which dates appear in the season, and therefore which dates Rostas builds for. You reach it two ways: when you first create a roster (the Season step of Set up a new roster), or any time afterwards from the Builds dashboard — ⋯ — Season Length.



Roster Frequency

Daily | **Weekly** (selected) | Fortnightly | 1st and 3rd | 2nd and 4th | Monthly

Season Type

Fixed-term (selected) | Perpetual (ongoing)

Start Date: 25/10/2026

End Date: 07/02/2027

The Season Length page — Roster Frequency pills across the top, and the Season Type control below. A fixed-term season also shows its Start Date and End Date. Click Save at the top right. Changes apply from your next roster build onward; dates already built keep their original cadence.

> **Cadence is set once per roster type** and applies to everyone in it. If two groups run on different weeks, set them up as separate roster types.

Season type — fixed-term or perpetual

Below the cadence pills, the **Season Type** control decides whether this roster has an end or simply keeps going:

> **Perpetual seasons roll forward on their own** — the end date is maintained by Rostas, so you never have to extend them. Most ongoing church rosters (Sunday service, welcome team) suit Perpetual. If you later need a perpetual roster to stop on a set date, switch it to Fixed-term and give it an end date.

Volunteer frequency cap — how often a person serves

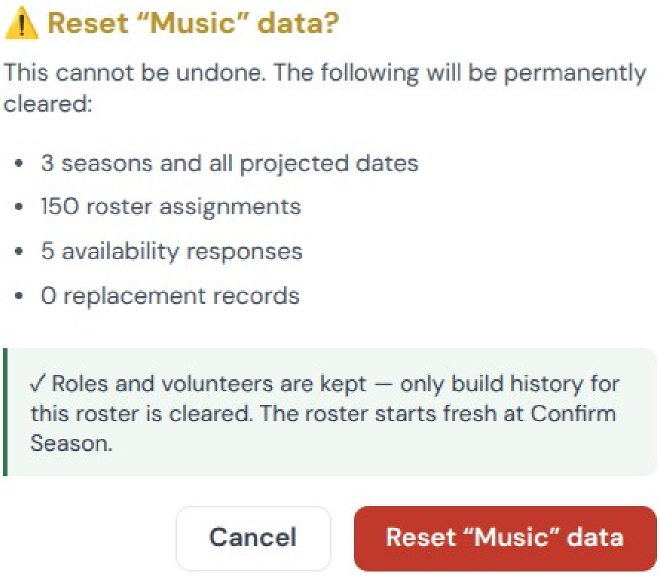
Separate from the roster's cadence, each volunteer has their own cap — how often *they* personally get rostered — so nobody is used every week just because they're always free. You set it on each person's profile (Frequency on the Profile detail page), independently for each roster they serve in. The two settings work together:

> **The cap counts distinct dates**, not individual roles. A volunteer in two roles on the same date counts as one date — so serving twice on one Sunday doesn't use two of their allocation.

Clearing a roster's test data

Reset roster data clears a roster type's operational history — built assignments, availability responses, replacement chains — without touching the roster's setup: its roles, volunteers, and season stay exactly as they are.

1. Open **Builds**.
2. Click the ⋯ button on the roster's row.
3. Click **Reset roster data**.
4. Read the list of what will be cleared.



⚠ Reset “Music” data?

This cannot be undone. The following will be permanently cleared:

- 3 seasons and all projected dates
- 150 roster assignments
- 5 availability responses
- 0 replacement records

✓ Roles and volunteers are kept — only build history for this roster is cleared. The roster starts fresh at Confirm Season.

The confirmation lists exactly what will be cleared.

5. Click **Reset "[roster]" data**. (Click **Cancel** to keep everything.) The roster's state button now reads **First Setup**, ready for a fresh first build. A paused roster stays Paused.

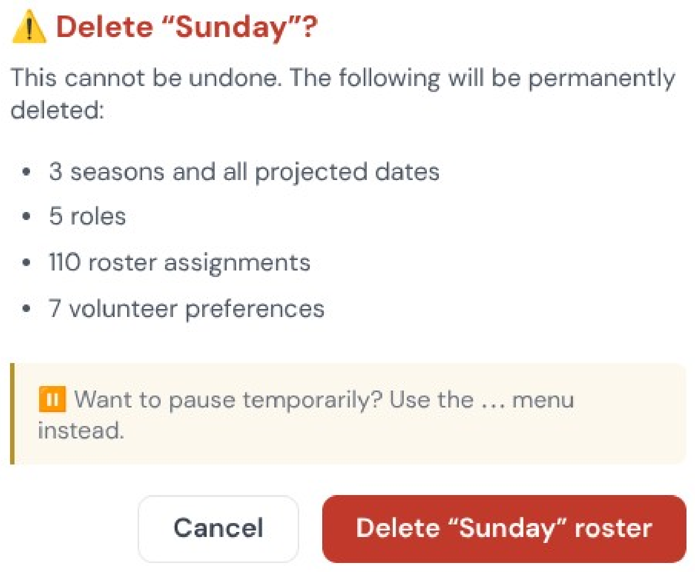
> **Built for getting started.** This is the tool for wiping sample or test data before a roster goes live — clear out anything built while you were setting up, then start rostering for real without deleting and re-creating the whole roster type.

> **Reset vs Delete.** Reset clears history but keeps the roster type itself — its roles and volunteer assignments to it survive. Delete removes the roster type entirely — see Deleting a Roster below. If you're clearing out test data before going live, Reset is almost always what you want.

Deleting a Roster

Delete roster permanently removes the roster type — its shell, roles, seasons, build history, and every assignment tied to it. Unlike Reset, there's no going back.

1. Open **Builds**.
2. Click the **···** button on the roster's row.
3. Click **Delete roster**.
4. Read the list of what will be deleted. If you only need a break, click **Cancel** and choose **Pause roster** instead.



⚠ **Delete “Sunday”?**

This cannot be undone. The following will be permanently deleted:

- 3 seasons and all projected dates
- 5 roles
- 110 roster assignments
- 7 volunteer preferences

⏸ Want to pause temporarily? Use the … menu instead.

The confirmation lists exactly what will be deleted, with real counts, and suggests pausing instead.

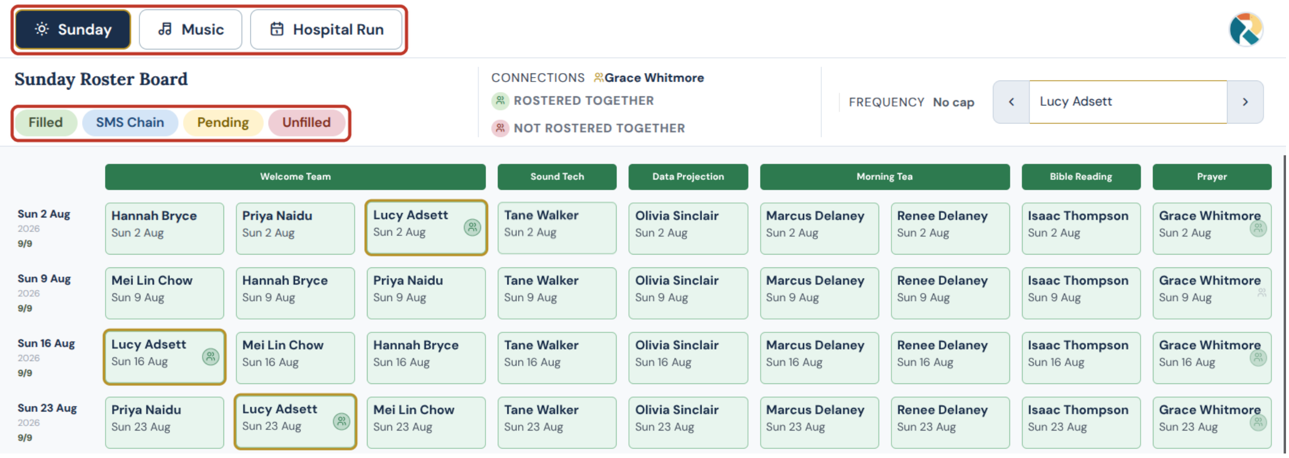
5. Click **Delete "[roster]" roster**.

> **Deleting is permanent.** If you only need to stop a roster for a while — over summer, say — use **Pause** from the ··· menu instead. Pausing keeps all the roster's history and settings; deleting removes them for good.

The Roster Board is where you manage the roster between builds. You'll come here to check on replacement progress, make manual swaps, confirm pending assignments, or search for a specific volunteer. Access it by clicking **Boards** in the sidebar.

Reading the Board

The Board shows every roster date as a row, with roles as columns. Each cell shows the assigned volunteer's name and date. Colour coding tells you the status of each assignment at a glance.


Sunday
Music
Hospital Run
Sunday Roster Board
Filled
SMS Chain
Pending
Unfilled
CONNECTIONS Grace Whitmore
ROSTERED TOGETHER
NOT ROSTERED TOGETHER
FREQUENCY No cap
‹
Lucy Adsett
›

	Welcome Team			Sound Tech	Data Projection	Morning Tea		Bible Reading	Prayer
Sun 2 Aug 2026 9/9	Hannah Bryce Sun 2 Aug	Priya Naidu Sun 2 Aug	Lucy Adsett Sun 2 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 2 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 2 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 2 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 2 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 2 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 2 Aug
Sun 9 Aug 2026 9/9	Mei Lin Chow Sun 9 Aug	Hannah Bryce Sun 9 Aug	Priya Naidu Sun 9 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 9 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 9 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 9 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 9 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 9 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 9 Aug
Sun 16 Aug 2026 9/9	Lucy Adsett Sun 16 Aug	Mei Lin Chow Sun 16 Aug	Hannah Bryce Sun 16 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 16 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 16 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 16 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 16 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 16 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 16 Aug
Sun 23 Aug 2026 9/9	Priya Naidu Sun 23 Aug	Lucy Adsett Sun 23 Aug	Mei Lin Chow Sun 23 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 23 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 23 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 23 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 23 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 23 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 23 Aug

The Roster Board — dates run down the left, role columns across the top with green headers. Use the roster type tabs at the very top to switch between rosters. The legend and frequency search are in the header row above the grid.

> **White isn't the same as Red.** A red cell is an unfilled slot that needs a volunteer. A white row is a date you deliberately excluded — usually in the Confirm Dates step, turning a chip pink there. The Board just carries that decision through: the row stays blank on purpose, so it doesn't get mistaken for a gap. White rows aren't clickable — there's no assignment to act on.

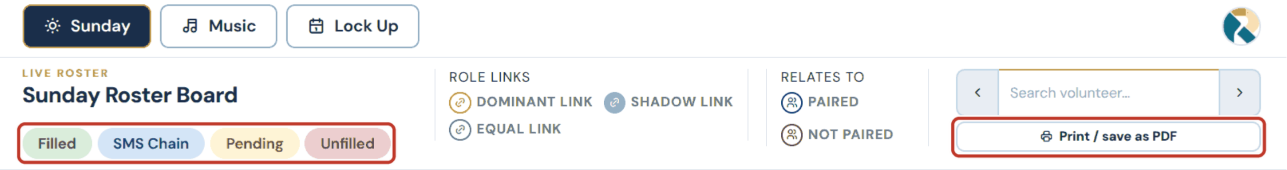
Legend and Frequency

The legend row at the top of the board shows the four colours (white excluded dates have no chip of their own). To the right, the **volunteer search** (with ◀ ▶ navigation arrows) lets you find a specific person and step through volunteers one by one. The **Frequency** panel shows how often the currently searched volunteer is rostered and when they were last assigned.

Printing the roster

To print the roster for a noticeboard or to hand out:

1. Click **Print / save as PDF** under the search box on the Board. The roster you're looking at opens in a new tab: every date as a row and every role as a column, with everyone's names. Weeks with no service say so, and people who declined are left out.


Sunday
Music
Lock Up
LIVE ROSTER
Sunday Roster Board
Filled
SMS Chain
Pending
Unfilled
ROLE LINKS
DOMINANT LINK
SHADOW LINK
EQUAL LINK
RELATES TO
PAIRED
NOT PAIRED
‹
Search volunteer...
›
Print / save as PDF

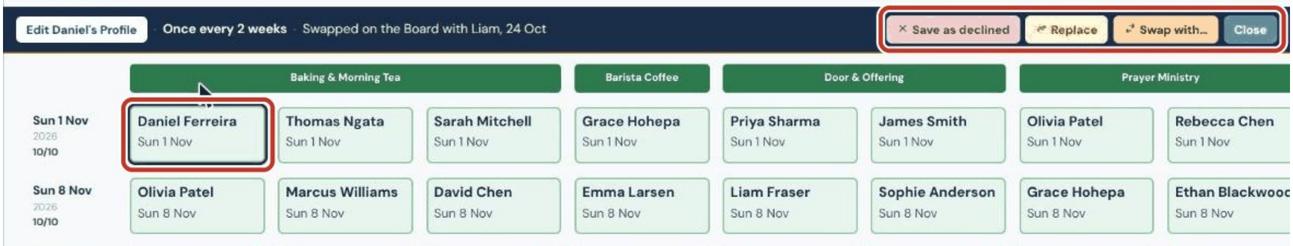
The top of the Roster Board: the legend on the left, and Print / save as PDF under the volunteer search.

2. Click **Print / save as PDF** at the top of the new tab.

3. Choose your printer and print. It prints on A4 landscape, with the column headings repeated on every page. To make a PDF instead, choose **Save as PDF** as the printer.

Changing a card on the Board

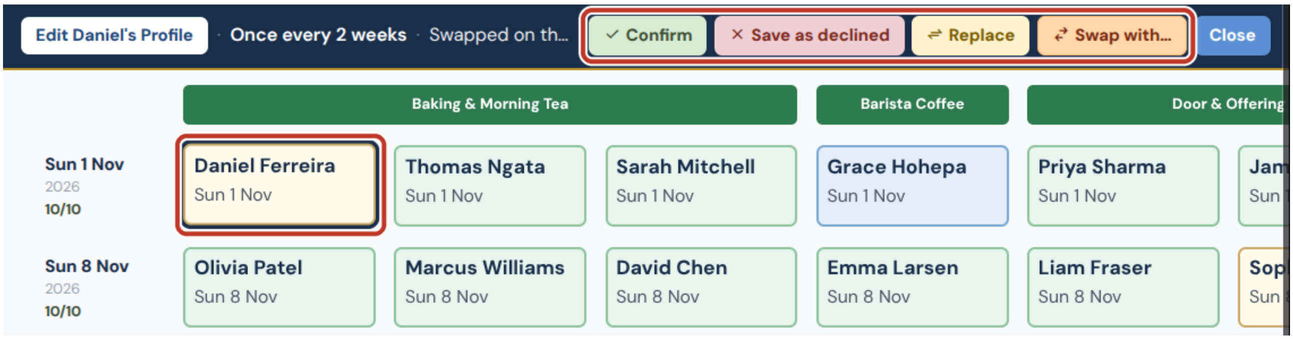
Click any card on the Board to select it. The card gets a navy border and an action bar appears above the green role headings, showing who is on the card, their frequency and any recent change, with buttons on the right. The buttons depend on the card: a Filled card has nothing to confirm, so it shows no fill button at all.



Once every 2 weeks · Swapped on the Board with Liam, 24 Oct

	Baking & Morning Tea			Barista Coffee	Door & Offering		Prayer Ministry	
Sun 1 Nov 2026 10/10	Daniel Ferreira Sun 1 Nov	Thomas Ngata Sun 1 Nov	Sarah Mitchell Sun 1 Nov	Grace Hohepa Sun 1 Nov	Priya Sharma Sun 1 Nov	James Smith Sun 1 Nov	Olivia Patel Sun 1 Nov	Rebecca Chen Sun 1 Nov
Sun 8 Nov 2026 10/10	Olivia Patel Sun 8 Nov	Marcus Williams Sun 8 Nov	David Chen Sun 8 Nov	Emma Larsen Sun 8 Nov	Liam Fraser Sun 8 Nov	Sophie Anderson Sun 8 Nov	Grace Hohepa Sun 8 Nov	Ethan Blackwood Sun 8 Nov

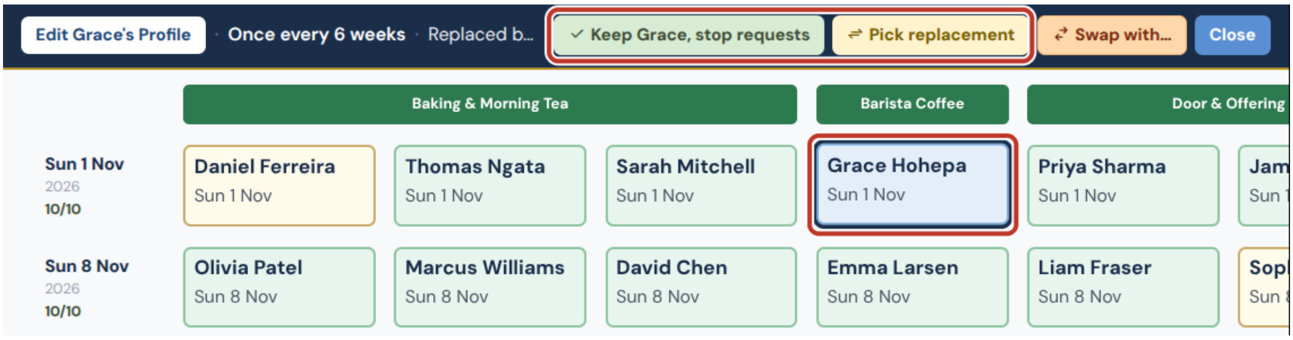
A Filled card selected. The action bar shows Save as declined, Replace and Swap with…; there's no fill button because the card is already Filled.



Once every 2 weeks · Swapped on th...

	Baking & Morning Tea			Barista Coffee	Door & Offering	
Sun 1 Nov 2026 10/10	Daniel Ferreira Sun 1 Nov	Thomas Ngata Sun 1 Nov	Sarah Mitchell Sun 1 Nov	Grace Hohepa Sun 1 Nov	Priya Sharma Sun 1 Nov	Jam Sun
Sun 8 Nov 2026 10/10	Olivia Patel Sun 8 Nov	Marcus Williams Sun 8 Nov	David Chen Sun 8 Nov	Emma Larsen Sun 8 Nov	Liam Fraser Sun 8 Nov	Sop Sun

A Pending card selected. Confirm appears first, then the same buttons as a Filled card.



Once every 6 weeks · Replaced b...

	Baking & Morning Tea			Barista Coffee	Door & Offering	
Sun 1 Nov 2026 10/10	Daniel Ferreira Sun 1 Nov	Thomas Ngata Sun 1 Nov	Sarah Mitchell Sun 1 Nov	Grace Hohepa Sun 1 Nov	Priya Sharma Sun 1 Nov	Jam Sun
Sun 8 Nov 2026 10/10	Olivia Patel Sun 8 Nov	Marcus Williams Sun 8 Nov	David Chen Sun 8 Nov	Emma Larsen Sun 8 Nov	Liam Fraser Sun 8 Nov	Sop Sun

A card in an SMS chain (blue) selected. Keep Grace, stop requests keeps her on; Pick replacement lets you choose who covers instead of waiting for replies.

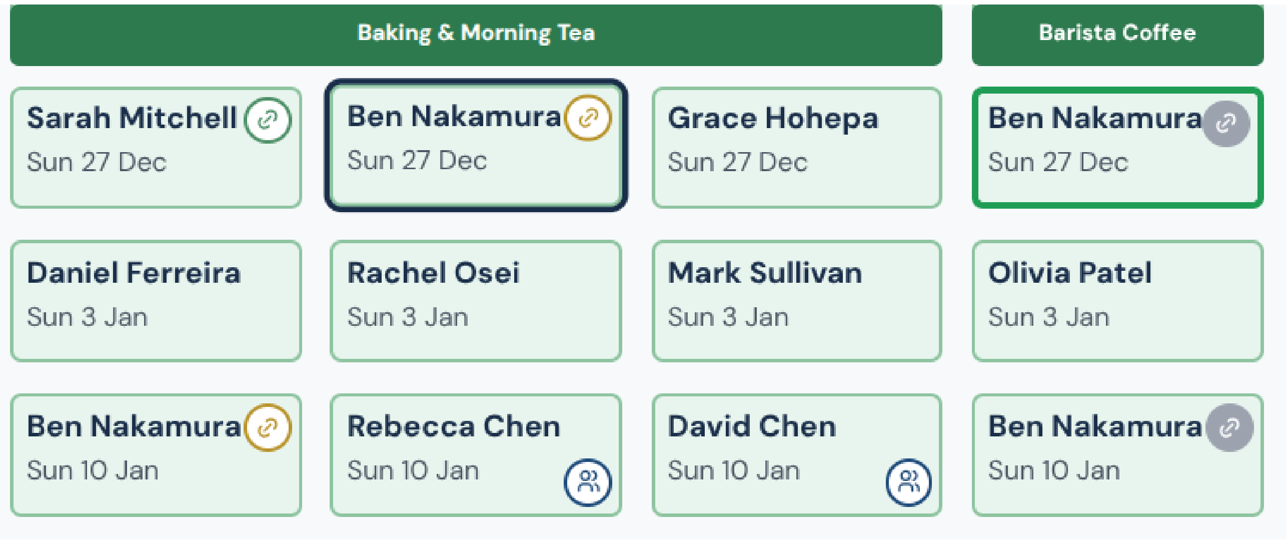
Confirm, Undo decline and Keep [name] also close open requests. If Rostas had already asked other volunteers to cover that slot, those requests are closed. Anyone who says Yes later is told someone else has already stepped in, so two people don't turn up. (On a card with any other status the same button reads **Save as filled**.)

Seeing a card's connected cards

When you click a card, Rostas also shows you what it's connected to on that date. Each connected card's border turns bold in its own colour (green on a Filled card) and pulses three times:

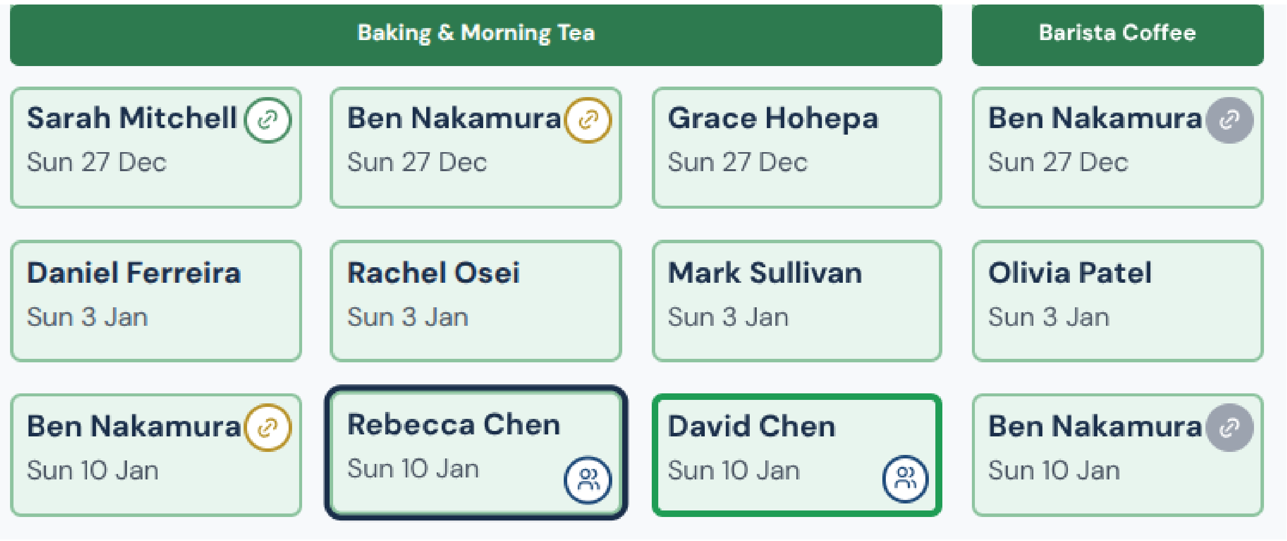
- **The same person in another role.** If the volunteer is also rostered in a linked role that day, that card lights up.
- **Their buddy or household partner.** If they're paired with someone who is serving that day too, the partner's card lights up.

If a connected card is off to the side, the Board scrolls sideways to bring it into view. The highlight clears when you click another card, click empty space on the Board, or click **Close**.



Baking & Morning Tea			Barista Coffee
Sarah Mitchell Sun 27 Dec	Ben Nakamura Sun 27 Dec	Grace Hohepa Sun 27 Dec	Ben Nakamura Sun 27 Dec
Daniel Ferreira Sun 3 Jan	Rachel Osei Sun 3 Jan	Mark Sullivan Sun 3 Jan	Olivia Patel Sun 3 Jan
Ben Nakamura Sun 10 Jan	Rebecca Chen Sun 10 Jan	David Chen Sun 10 Jan	Ben Nakamura Sun 10 Jan

Ben's Baking & Morning Tea card selected. His linked Barista Coffee card that day gets a bold green border.



Baking & Morning Tea			Barista Coffee
Sarah Mitchell Sun 27 Dec	Ben Nakamura Sun 27 Dec	Grace Hohepa Sun 27 Dec	Ben Nakamura Sun 27 Dec
Daniel Ferreira Sun 3 Jan	Rachel Osei Sun 3 Jan	Mark Sullivan Sun 3 Jan	Olivia Patel Sun 3 Jan
Ben Nakamura Sun 10 Jan	Rebecca Chen Sun 10 Jan	David Chen Sun 10 Jan	Ben Nakamura Sun 10 Jan

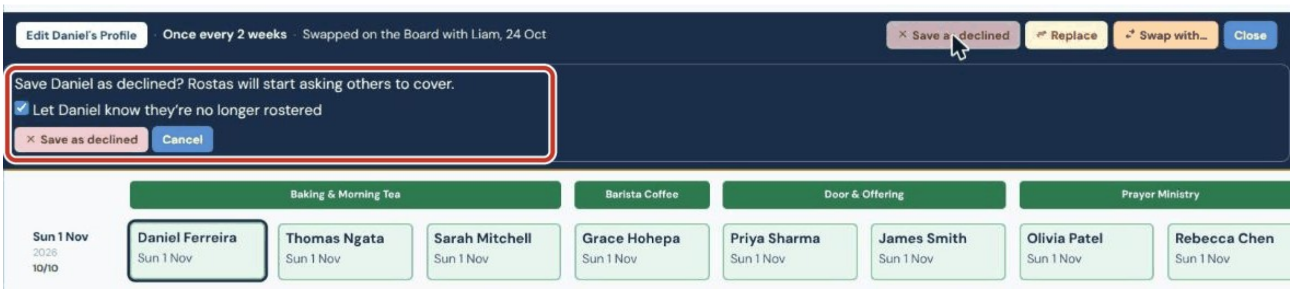
Rebecca Chen selected. David Chen, who is paired with her and serving the same Sunday, gets a bold green border.

Saving someone as declined

When a volunteer tells you they can't make it:

1. Click their card on the Board.
2. Click **Save as declined**. A confirm step opens under the action bar.

3. Leave **Let [Name] know they're no longer rostered** ticked, or untick it if you've already spoken to them.


Edit Daniel's Profile
× Save as declined
Replace
Swap with...
Close
× Save as declined
Cancel
Baking & Morning Tea
Barista Coffee
Door & Offering
Prayer Ministry
Sun 1 Nov
2026
10/10
Daniel Ferreira
Sun 1 Nov
Thomas Ngata
Sun 1 Nov
Sarah Mitchell
Sun 1 Nov
Grace Hohepa
Sun 1 Nov
Priya Sharma
Sun 1 Nov
James Smith
Sun 1 Nov
Olivia Patel
Sun 1 Nov
Rebecca Chen
Sun 1 Nov

Once every 2 weeks · Swapped on the Board with Liam, 24 Oct

Save Daniel as declined? Rostas will start asking others to cover.

☑ Let Daniel know they're no longer rostered

The decline confirm step. "Let [Name] know they're no longer rostered" is ticked to start with.

4. Click **Save as declined** again. (Click **Cancel** to change nothing.)

What happens next:

- If that date's roster has already gone out and the box was ticked, Rostas tells them: an app notification, or a text with a link to their roster if they don't have the app.
- If the roster for that date hasn't gone out yet, nothing is sent and the Board tells you so. They simply won't be on the roster when it's sent.
- Rostas then starts the SMS replacement chain to find someone to cover. If the roster is paused, the card waits for you instead.

When the roster changes while the Board is open

Volunteers answer texts and emails at any time, and other coordinators may be working on the same roster, so the Board keeps itself up to date:

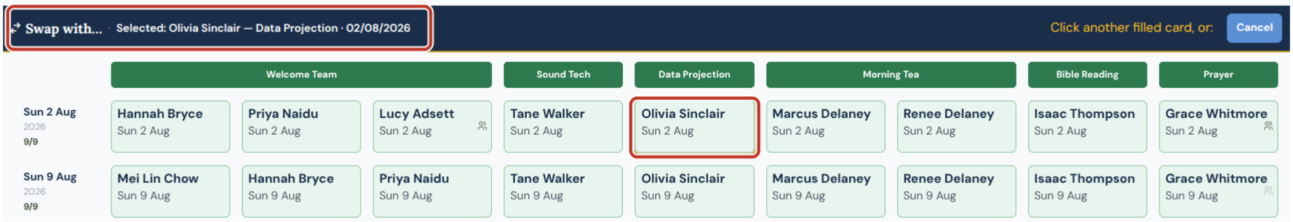
- **It refreshes by itself.** Every 30 seconds, and whenever you come back to the tab, the Board checks for changes (a volunteer's Yes, a decline, another coordinator's change) and redraws in place.
- **If you have a card open**, it doesn't redraw under you. A bar at the top says "*The roster has changed since you opened the Board*" with a **Reload** button.
- **Each card is checked when you click it.** If it changed since the Board loaded, a red note says what it shows now and the buttons are greyed out; reload the Board first. If Rostas is in the middle of asking someone to cover it, a yellow note says who and when their reply is due.
- **Saves never undo a volunteer's answer.** If someone said Yes to that slot after your Board loaded, your change is refused and the Board reloads so you can see who's on it now.

The coloured messages the Board shows after a save stay up for 10 seconds.

Swapping two volunteers

When two rostered volunteers want to trade dates:

1. Click the first volunteer's card on the Board.
2. Click **Swap with...**. The card gets a gold border while Rostas waits for the second card. (Click **Cancel** in the bar to stop.)



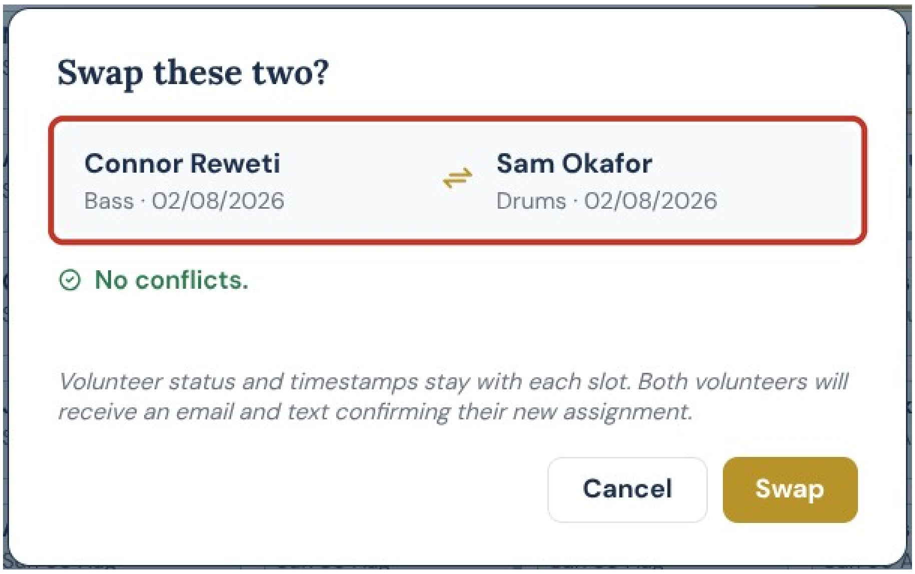
Swap with… Selected: Olivia Sinclair — Data Projection · 02/08/2026

Click another filled card, or:

	Welcome Team			Sound Tech	Data Projection	Morning Tea		Bible Reading	Prayer
Sun 2 Aug 2026 9/9	Hannah Bryce Sun 2 Aug	Priya Naidu Sun 2 Aug	Lucy Adsett Sun 2 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 2 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 2 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 2 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 2 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 2 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 2 Aug
Sun 9 Aug 2026 9/9	Mei Lin Chow Sun 9 Aug	Hannah Bryce Sun 9 Aug	Priya Naidu Sun 9 Aug	Tane Walker Sun 9 Aug	Olivia Sinclair Sun 9 Aug	Marcus Delaney Sun 9 Aug	Renee Delaney Sun 9 Aug	Isaac Thompson Sun 9 Aug	Grace Whitmore Sun 9 Aug

A card armed for swap. The bar at the top shows who you picked.

3. Click the card you want to swap it with. A confirmation shows both people, their roles and dates.



Swap these two?

Connor Reweti
Bass · 02/08/2026
⇄
Sam Okafor
Drums · 02/08/2026

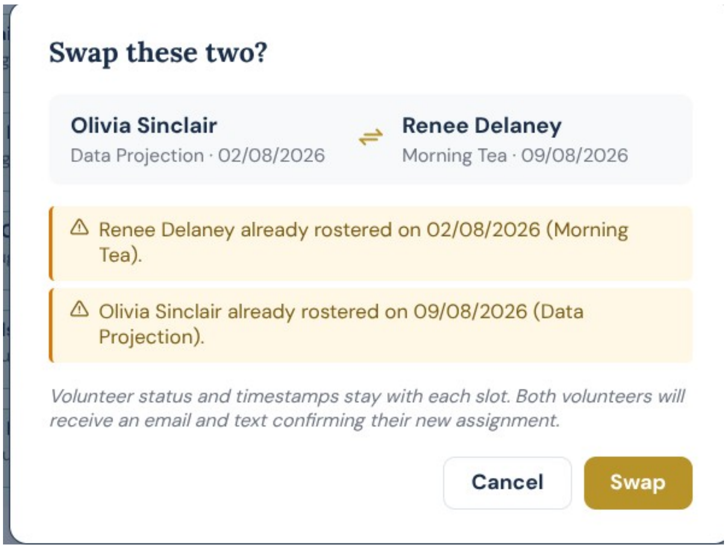
No conflicts.

Volunteer status and timestamps stay with each slot. Both volunteers will receive an email and text confirming their new assignment.

Check both people, roles and dates before you click Swap.

4. Click **Swap**. Both volunteers get an email and a text about their new date.

Conflict warnings are advisory, not blocking. If a swap would clash — say a volunteer is already rostered elsewhere that day — Rostas shows amber warnings on the confirmation, but you can still go ahead. It flags the risk and leaves the decision to you.



Swap these two?

Olivia Sinclair
Data Projection · 02/08/2026
⇄
Renee Delaney
Morning Tea · 09/08/2026

⚠ Renee Delaney already rostered on 02/08/2026 (Morning Tea).

⚠ Olivia Sinclair already rostered on 09/08/2026 (Data Projection).

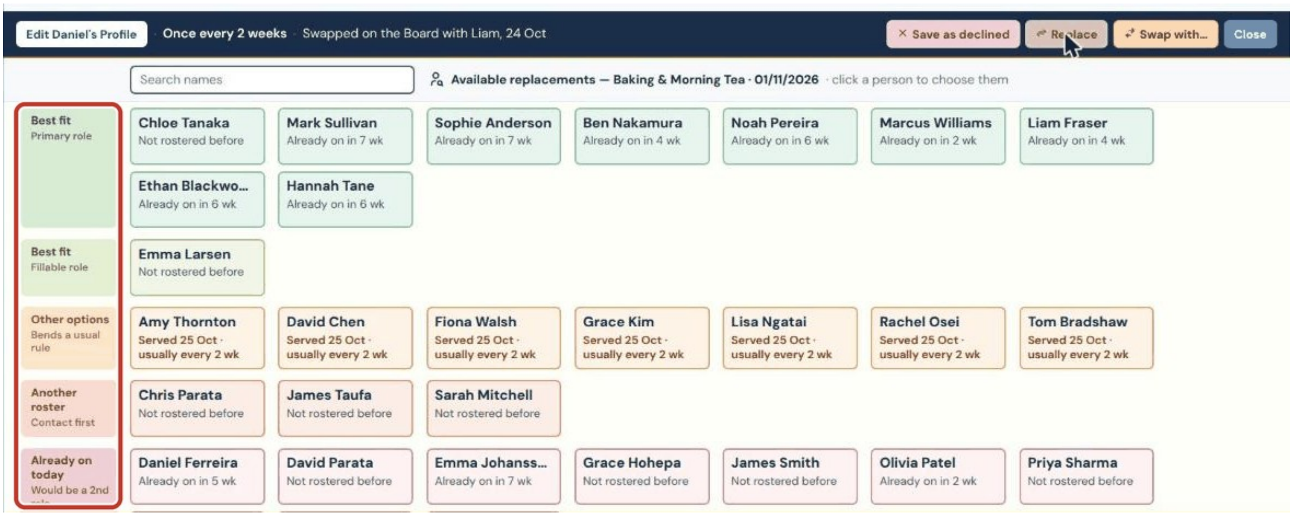
Volunteer status and timestamps stay with each slot. Both volunteers will receive an email and text confirming their new assignment.

A swap with conflicts — the amber warnings inform you, but the swap button stays available.

Choosing a replacement yourself

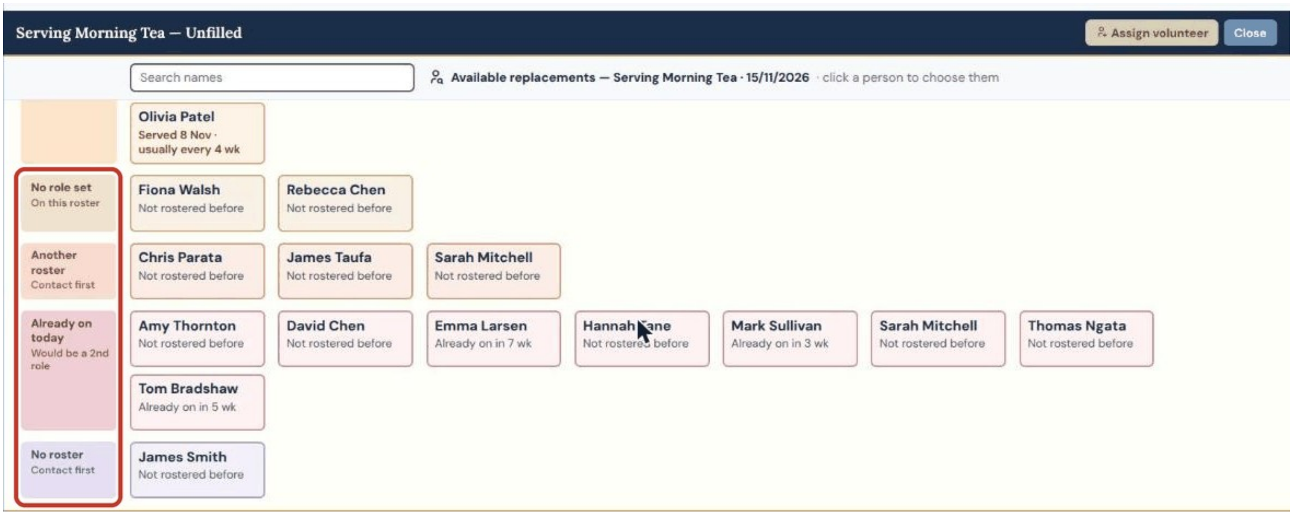
To choose who covers a slot yourself:

1. Click the card on the Board.
2. Click **Replace** (or **Assign volunteer** on an Unfilled card). The replacement panel opens below the action bar. It shows everyone who could cover that role on that date, in coloured bands down the left, best fit first. Each card shows the person's name and how recently they've been rostered.


Edit Daniel's Profile
Once every 2 weeks
Swapped on the Board with Liam, 24 Oct
× Save as declined
Replace
Swap with...
Close
Search names
Available replacements — Baking & Morning Tea · 01/11/2026 · click a person to choose them
Best fit
Primary role
Chloe Tanaka
Not rostered before
Mark Sullivan
Already on in 7 wk
Sophie Anderson
Already on in 7 wk
Ben Nakamura
Already on in 4 wk
Noah Pereira
Already on in 6 wk
Marcus Williams
Already on in 2 wk
Liam Fraser
Already on in 4 wk
Ethan Blackwo...
Already on in 6 wk
Hannah Tane
Already on in 6 wk
Best fit
Fillable role
Emma Larsen
Not rostered before
Other options
Bends a usual rule
Amy Thornton
Served 25 Oct · usually every 2 wk
David Chen
Served 25 Oct · usually every 2 wk
Fiona Walsh
Served 25 Oct · usually every 2 wk
Grace Kim
Served 25 Oct · usually every 2 wk
Lisa Ngatai
Served 25 Oct · usually every 2 wk
Rachel Osei
Served 25 Oct · usually every 2 wk
Tom Bradshaw
Served 25 Oct · usually every 2 wk
Another roster
Contact first
Chris Parata
Not rostered before
James Taufa
Not rostered before
Sarah Mitchell
Not rostered before
Already on today
Would be a 2nd
Daniel Ferreira
Already on in 5 wk
David Parata
Not rostered before
Emma Johanss...
Already on in 7 wk
Grace Hohepa
Not rostered before
James Smith
Not rostered before
Olivia Patel
Already on in 2 wk
Priya Sharma
Not rostered before

The replacement panel. The bands down the left say why each person is offered. Up to seven cards fit across a band, then they wrap onto a new row.

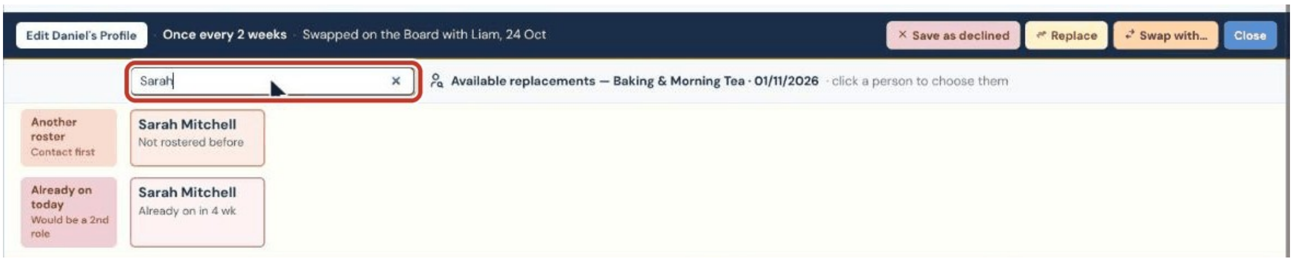
3. Find the person you want. To find someone by name, type in **Search names** (see below).
4. Click the person. What happens next depends on their band (see the table).


Serving Morning Tea — Unfilled
Assign volunteer
Close
Search names
Available replacements — Serving Morning Tea · 15/11/2026 · click a person to choose them
Olivia Patel
Served 8 Nov · usually every 4 wk
No role set
On this roster
Fiona Walsh
Not rostered before
Rebecca Chen
Not rostered before
Another roster
Contact first
Chris Parata
Not rostered before
James Taufa
Not rostered before
Sarah Mitchell
Not rostered before
Already on today
Would be a 2nd role
Amy Thornton
Not rostered before
David Chen
Not rostered before
Emma Larsen
Already on in 7 wk
Hannah Tane
Not rostered before
Mark Sullivan
Already on in 3 wk
Sarah Mitchell
Not rostered before
Thomas Ngata
Not rostered before
Tom Bradshaw
Already on in 5 wk
No roster
Contact first
James Smith
Not rostered before

Further down the panel: No role set (tan), Another roster, Already on today and No roster (purple).

Finding someone by name

The **Search names** box at the top of the panel narrows the cards as you type. Bands with nobody matching are hidden, and if nobody matches at all the panel says "No one by that name." Clear the box with its × to see everyone again.


Edit Daniel's Profile
Once every 2 weeks · Swapped on the Board with Liam, 24 Oct
✕ Save as declined
Replace
Swap with...
Close
Available replacements — Baking & Morning Tea · 01/11/2026 · click a person to choose them
Another roster
Contact first
Already on today
Would be a 2nd role
Sarah Mitchell
Not rostered before
Sarah Mitchell
Already on in 4 wk

Sarah

Typing "Sarah" leaves just the matching cards, still in their bands.

Both people are told automatically. If this roster's notifications have already gone out, Rostas tells the new person straight away (an app notification if they have the app, otherwise a text and an email). The person you took off is told they're no longer rostered (an app notification, or a text with a link to their roster). If you haven't sent notifications yet, nobody is messaged; the roster simply shows the new person when you send it (Step 6).

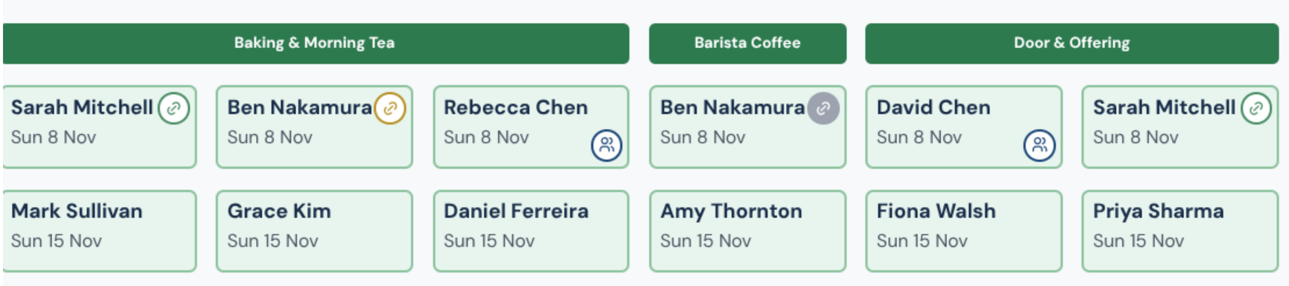
Asking a volunteer from another roster

The **Another roster** and **No roster** bands, both marked *Contact first*, offer people who aren't part of this roster: a Music volunteer showing up for a Sunday gap, for example, or someone in Profiles with no roster ticked.

This is a one-off ask, not an addition to the roster. Choosing someone in these bands sends them a one-off request for this single date — the same app/SMS/email delivery as everywhere else — but doesn't add them to the roster. Use it for genuine gap-filling, and it's worth a heads-up to the volunteer (and their usual coordinator) first, since it crosses roster boundaries.

Giving someone two roles on one date

Occasionally a volunteer may need to cover two roles on the same date — for example, stepping in for a missing team member while also serving in their usual role. Rostas supports this but flags it clearly so you're making a deliberate choice rather than an accidental double-booking.



Baking & Morning Tea	Baking & Morning Tea	Baking & Morning Tea	Barista Coffee	Door & Offering	Door & Offering
Sarah Mitchell Sun 8 Nov	**Ben Nakamura** Sun 8 Nov	**Rebecca Chen** Sun 8 Nov	**Ben Nakamura** Sun 8 Nov	**David Chen** Sun 8 Nov	**Sarah Mitchell** Sun 8 Nov
Mark Sullivan Sun 15 Nov	**Grace Kim** Sun 15 Nov	**Daniel Ferreira** Sun 15 Nov	**Amy Thornton** Sun 15 Nov	**Fiona Walsh** Sun 15 Nov	**Priya Sharma** Sun 15 Nov

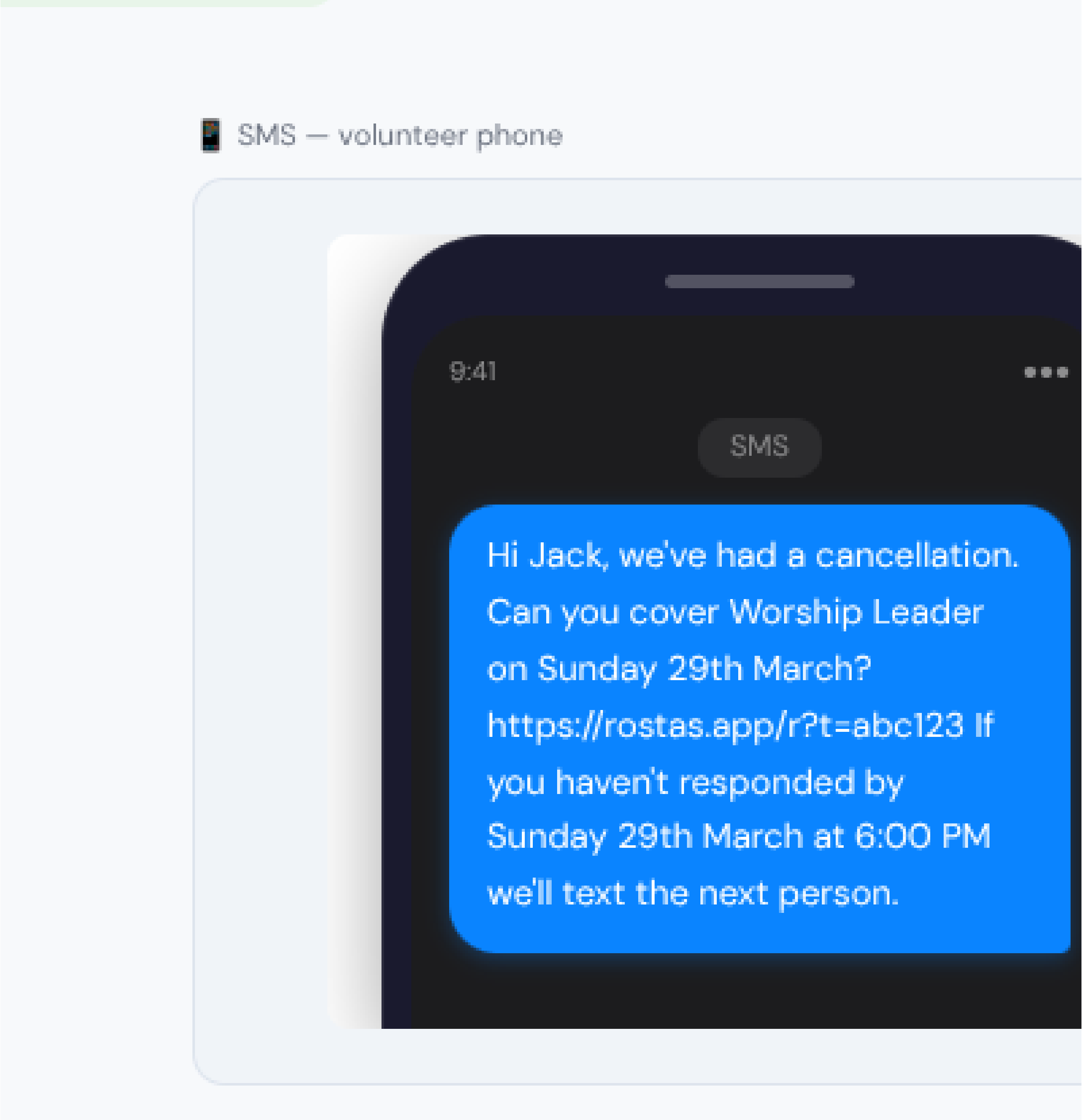
Ben Nakamura and Sarah Mitchell each hold two roles on Sun 8 Nov. The link badge on each card shows how the roles are tied: gold and grey for a dominant and shadow role (Ben), green for an equal pairing (Sarah). The navy people badge marks a buddy or household link (Rebecca and David Chen).

> Use this sparingly. Volunteers serving in multiple roles in one roster can feel stretched. Always confirm with the volunteer before assigning a second role.

The SMS Replacement Chain

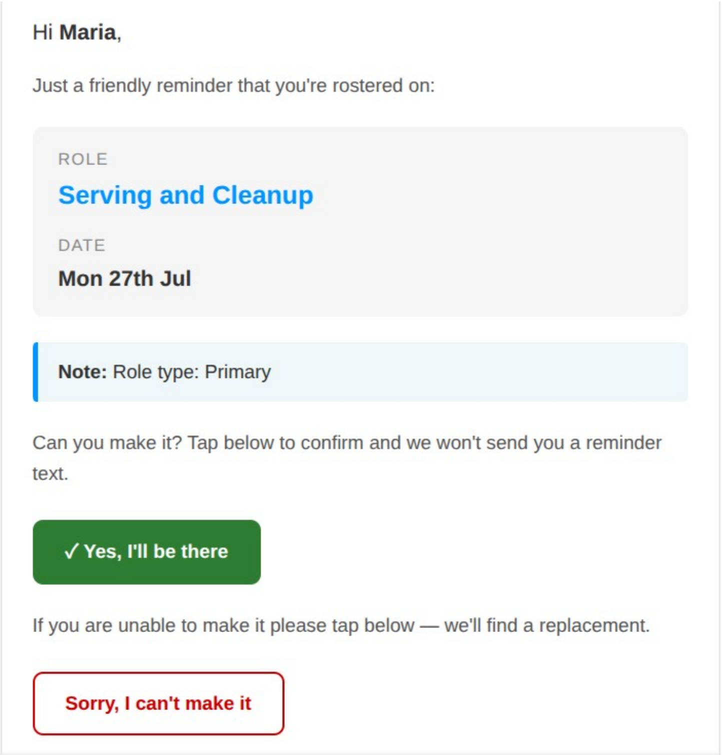
When a volunteer taps "Can't make it" in their roster email, their reminder or the app — or when you click **Save as declined** on the board — Rostas starts the automated SMS replacement chain. It works through available volunteers one at a time until someone accepts.

The request text carries a **direct personalised link** straight to the accept / decline page — see Part A for the full explanation.



Hi Jack, we've had a cancellation. Can you cover Worship Leader on Sunday 29th March? https://rostas.app/r?t=abc123 If you haven't responded by Sunday 29th March at 6:00 PM we'll text the next person.

The replacement request SMS — it carries a direct link to the accept / decline page.



Hi **Maria**,

Just a friendly reminder that you're rostered on:

ROLE

Serving and Cleanup

DATE

Mon 27th Jul

Note: Role type: Primary

Can you make it? Tap below to confirm and we won't send you a reminder text.

If you are unable to make it please tap below — we'll find a replacement.

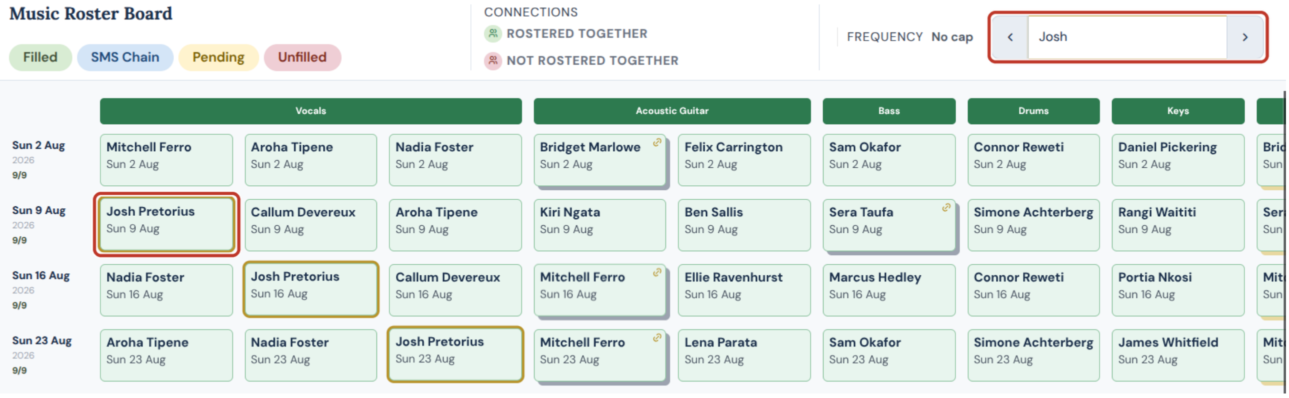
The page a volunteer reaches after tapping "Can't make it" — two clear options. If they changed their mind they can reinstate themselves on the spot.

Quiet hours apply to the SMS chain. Messages are never sent during your quiet hours (set in Settings → Timing & behaviour, default 9pm–8am). If the chain reaches a volunteer inside that window it pauses automatically and resumes once quiet hours end. You can monitor progress on the board — cells in the SMS chain state show in blue.

Seeing all of a volunteer's dates

To see all of one volunteer's upcoming dates at once:

1. Type their name in the **Search volunteer…** box at the top right of the Board. Their assignments are highlighted across the whole Board.



	Vocals			Acoustic Guitar		Bass	Drums	Keys	
Sun 2 Aug 2026 9/9	Mitchell Ferro Sun 2 Aug	Aroha Tipene Sun 2 Aug	Nadia Foster Sun 2 Aug	Bridget Marlowe Sun 2 Aug	Felix Carrington Sun 2 Aug	Sam Okafor Sun 2 Aug	Connor Reweti Sun 2 Aug	Daniel Pickering Sun 2 Aug	Brid Sun
Sun 9 Aug 2026 9/9	Josh Pretorius Sun 9 Aug	Callum Devereux Sun 9 Aug	Aroha Tipene Sun 9 Aug	Kiri Ngata Sun 9 Aug	Ben Sallis Sun 9 Aug	Sera Taufa Sun 9 Aug	Simone Achterberg Sun 9 Aug	Rangi Waititi Sun 9 Aug	Ser Sun
Sun 16 Aug 2026 9/9	Nadia Foster Sun 16 Aug	Josh Pretorius Sun 16 Aug	Callum Devereux Sun 16 Aug	Mitchell Ferro Sun 16 Aug	Ellie Ravenhurst Sun 16 Aug	Marcus Hedley Sun 16 Aug	Connor Reweti Sun 16 Aug	Portia Nkosi Sun 16 Aug	Mit Sun
Sun 23 Aug 2026 9/9	Aroha Tipene Sun 23 Aug	Nadia Foster Sun 23 Aug	Josh Pretorius Sun 23 Aug	Mitchell Ferro Sun 23 Aug	Lena Parata Sun 23 Aug	Sam Okafor Sun 23 Aug	Simone Achterberg Sun 23 Aug	James Whitfield Sun 23 Aug	Mit Sun

Every one of the volunteer's assignments is highlighted, so you can see their whole schedule at a glance.

2. Read the **Frequency** panel beside the box: how often they're rostered and when they last served.
3. Click the ‹ and › arrows to step to the previous or next volunteer, in alphabetical order.

> **Use volunteer search before making a manual replacement.** Search for the volunteer you're thinking of replacing them with first — check they're not already heavily rostered that period before adding another date.

The Settings view is where you configure how Rostas behaves — your organisation's identity, SMS credentials, message wording, timing rules, and more. Open it by clicking **Settings** in the left sidebar. It opens on the **Status** page, so you see straight away whether anything needs attention (see Using System Status). Click any category chip to get to the settings themselves.

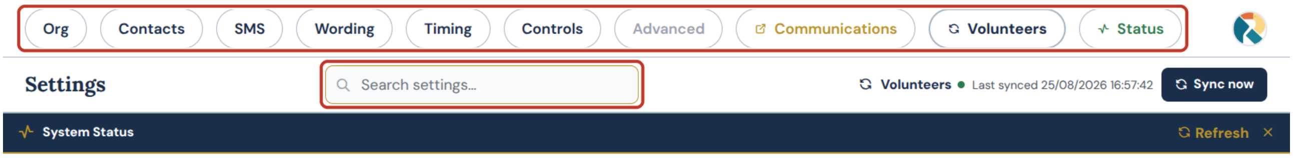
The Settings View

Finding your way around

The Settings view has two parts that work together.

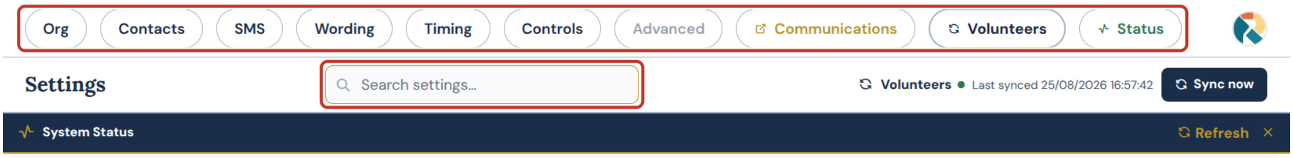
The **chip strip** runs across the top and lets you jump directly to any category — Org, Contacts, SMS, App, Email, Timing, Controls, Advanced and Status. Clicking a chip scrolls the left panel to that section instantly; **Status** takes you back to the Status page. The gold **Comms** chip (with an arrow) opens the Communications Preview in place of Settings — use it to see how your message templates look before sending.

The **search bar** (top right, "Search settings...") filters the left panel live as you type. It searches across setting names and descriptions simultaneously — so typing "SMS" shows not just the SMS category but any setting whose description mentions SMS, across all categories. Non-matching rows disappear; categories with no matches collapse. Clear the search to restore the full list.


Org
Contacts
SMS
Wording
Timing
Controls
Advanced
Communications
Volunteers
Status
Settings
Search settings...
Volunteers
Last synced 25/08/2026 16:57:42
Sync now
System Status
Refresh

The chip strip across the top of Settings — click any category pill to jump straight to that section. The gold Communications chip opens the message preview. Any warnings show in a yellow strip above the list, with an Open System Status link.

The two-column layout

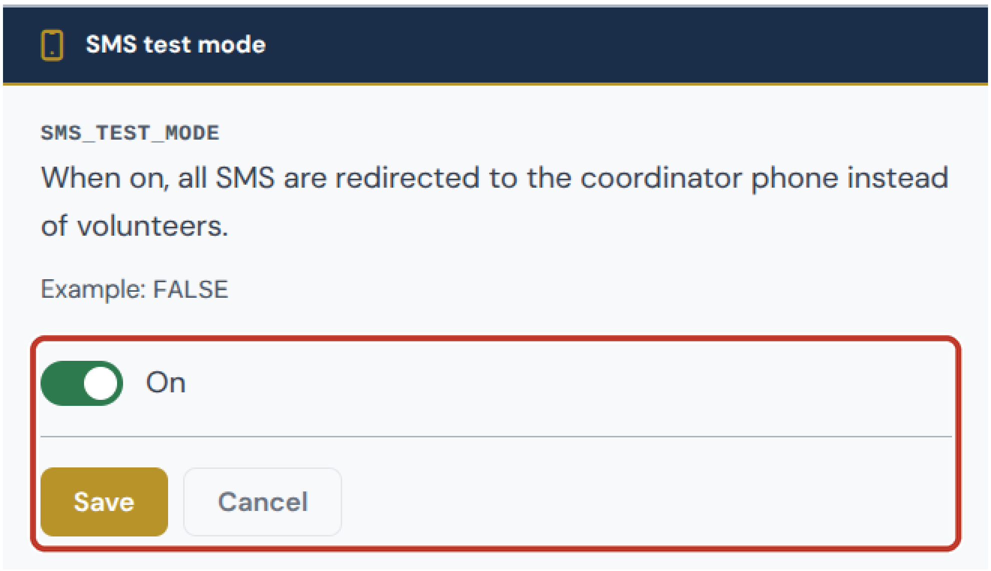

Org
Contacts
SMS
Wording
Timing
Controls
Advanced
Communications
Volunteers
Status
Settings
Search settings...
Volunteers
Last synced 25/08/2026 16:57:42
Sync now
System Status
Refresh

The two-column layout — categories and settings in the scrollable left panel, the selected setting's detail and edit field in the sticky right panel.

- **Left panel** — the scrollable list of all settings, grouped by category. Each row shows the setting name, a one-line description, and its current value on the right. Click any row to open it for editing.
- **Right panel** — appears when you click a row. Shows the full description, an example value, the input field, and Save/Cancel buttons. The panel stays fixed while you scroll the left panel, so you can read and compare other settings without losing your place.

To close the right panel without saving, click Cancel or click a different row.

Editing a setting



SMS_TEST_MODE

When on, all SMS are redirected to the coordinator phone instead of volunteers.

Example: FALSE

On

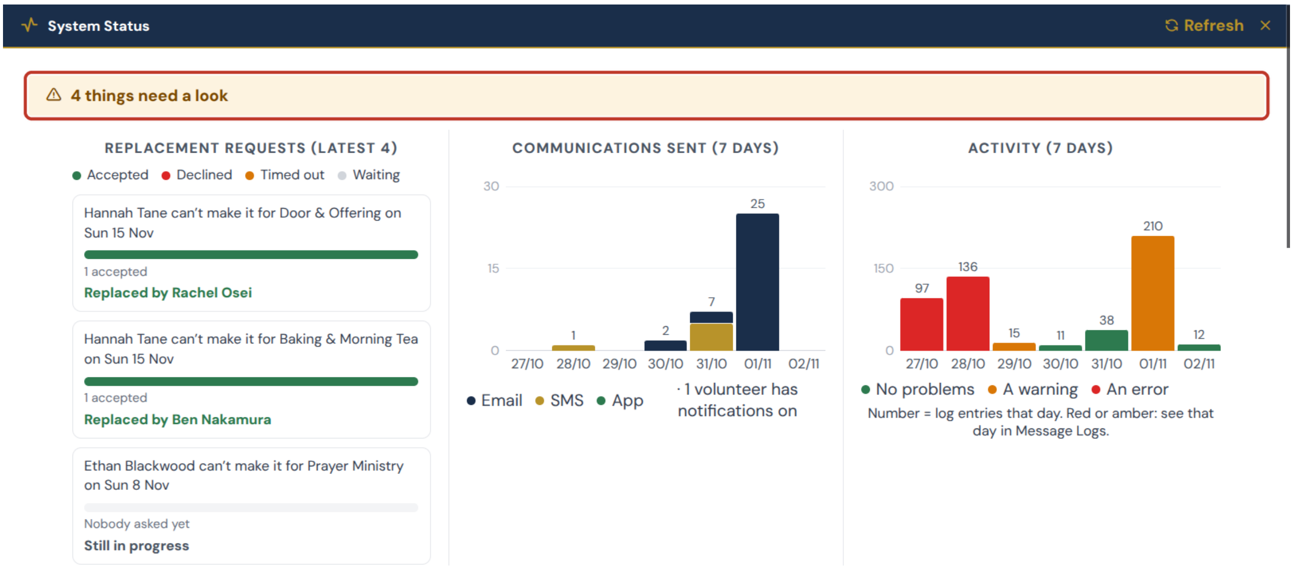
The right panel — key name at top, friendly label, full description, example value, and the input field. Validation runs as you type. The Save button stays disabled until the value is valid.

1. Click the setting's row in the left panel. The right panel opens with the current value filled in.
2. Change the value: pick from the drop-down, flip the switch, or type, depending on the setting.
3. If the field turns red, fix what the message under it says. **Save** stays greyed out until the value is valid.
4. Click **Save**. The left panel shows the new value straight away.

Using System Status

Settings opens on the Status page, so it's the first thing you see every time. Read it from the top down:

1. **The verdict** — one line at the top. Green means nothing needs a look; amber or red says how many things do.
2. **Three charts**: Replacement Requests, Communications Sent and Activity (see below).
3. **Message Logs** — what Rostas sent today and how people answered.
4. **Warnings, Roster Health and Counts** — the three columns at the bottom.


System Status
Refresh
REPLACEMENT REQUESTS (LATEST 4)
● Accepted ● Declined ● Timed out ● Waiting
COMMUNICATIONS SENT (7 DAYS)
30
15
0
1
2
7
25
27/10 28/10 29/10 30/10 31/10 01/11 02/11
● Email ● SMS ● App
ACTIVITY (7 DAYS)
300
150
0
97
136
15
11
38
210
12
27/10 28/10 29/10 30/10 31/10 01/11 02/11
● No problems ● A warning ● An error

⚠ 4 things need a look

Hannah Tane can't make it for Door & Offering on Sun 15 Nov
1 accepted
Replaced by Rachel Osei

Hannah Tane can't make it for Baking & Morning Tea on Sun 15 Nov
1 accepted
Replaced by Ben Nakamura

Ethan Blackwood can't make it for Prayer Ministry on Sun 8 Nov
Nobody asked yet
Still in progress

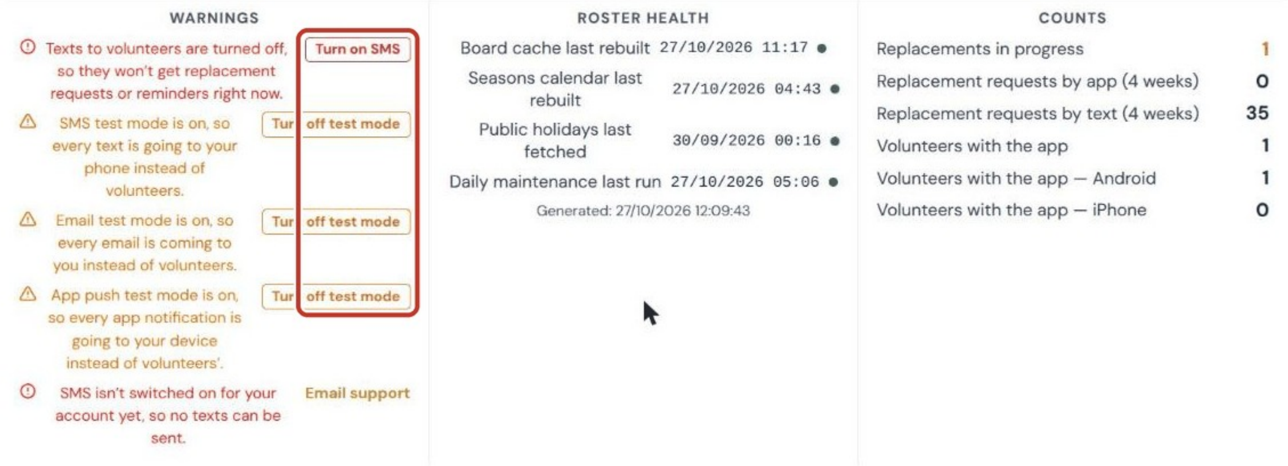
· 1 volunteer has notifications on

Number = log entries that day. Red or amber: see that day in Message Logs.

Settings opens on Status: the verdict, then the three charts. Message Logs and the warnings are further down.

Settings opens on the settings list instead when you arrive at a particular setting (for example from a warning's button or a Comms link), or while the set-up checklist is still showing for a new church.

If the verdict is green, carry on with whatever you came to do. If it shows amber or red, deal with those first, because some warnings mean volunteers aren't receiving messages right now.


WARNINGS
Turn on SMS
Tur off test mode
Tur off test mode
Tur off test mode
Email support
ROSTER HEALTH
COUNTS

Texts to volunteers are turned off, so they won't get replacement requests or reminders right now.

SMS test mode is on, so every text is going to your phone instead of volunteers.

Email test mode is on, so every email is coming to you instead of volunteers.

App push test mode is on, so every app notification is going to your device instead of volunteers'.

SMS isn't switched on for your account yet, so no texts can be sent.

Board cache last rebuilt 27/10/2026 11:17 ●
Seasons calendar last rebuilt 27/10/2026 04:43 ●
Public holidays last fetched 30/09/2026 00:16 ●
Daily maintenance last run 27/10/2026 05:06 ●
Generated: 27/10/2026 12:09:43

Replacements in progress	1
Replacement requests by app (4 weeks)	0
Replacement requests by text (4 weeks)	35
Volunteers with the app	1
Volunteers with the app — Android	1
Volunteers with the app — iPhone	0

The three columns at the bottom of Status — current warnings with their fix buttons, roster health indicators, and counts. (This demo church has its test modes on, so it shows several warnings.)

Following a warning to its fix

Each warning in the System Status card says in plain words what's wrong, and most carry their own button that takes you straight to the setting that fixes it:

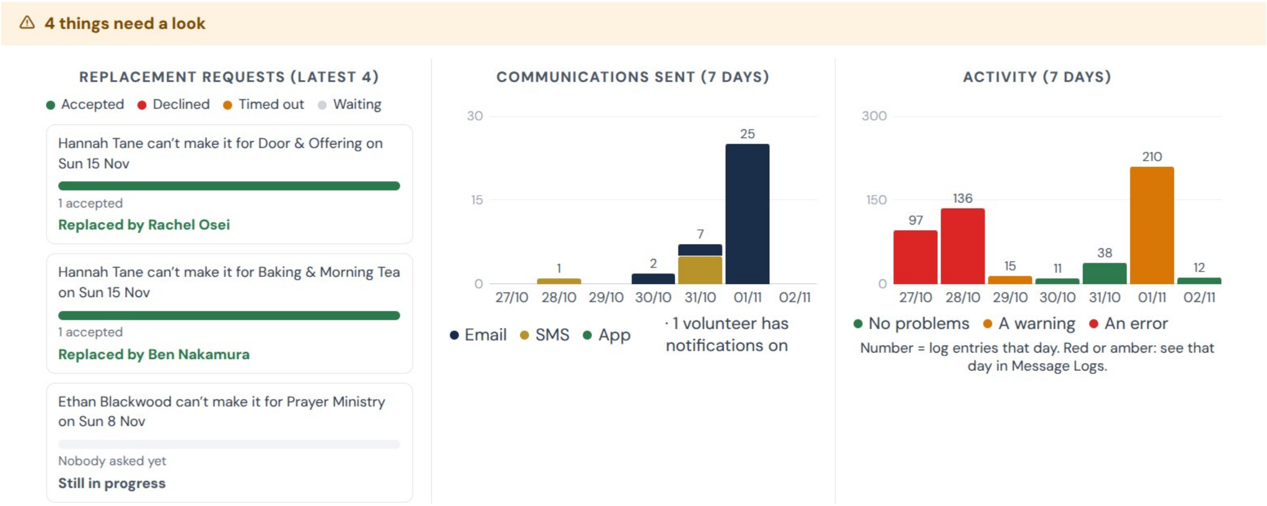
The typical workflow is: read the warning → click its button → save the setting that opens. If a warning has no button, the search bar above the settings list finds the setting by name.

After making a change, check the card again

The Status page doesn't update automatically when you save a setting — it loaded when you opened Settings and reflects that moment in time. After fixing a warning, click the **Status** chip, then **Refresh** in the System Status header, to confirm the warning has cleared.

Understanding your roster's rhythm

Once warnings are clear, the rest of the page gives you a different kind of visibility — not problems to fix, but patterns to understand. Start with the three charts at the top:



Hannah Tane can't make it for Door & Offering on Sun 15 Nov

1 accepted

Replaced by Rachel Osei

Hannah Tane can't make it for Baking & Morning Tea on Sun 15 Nov

1 accepted

Replaced by Ben Nakamura

Ethan Blackwood can't make it for Prayer Ministry on Sun 8 Nov

Nobody asked yet

Still in progress

· 1 volunteer has notifications on

Number = log entries that day. Red or amber: see that day in Message Logs.

The three charts at the top of Status, each with a key of coloured dots.

- **Replacement Requests (latest 4)** — a card for each of the four most recent requests, newest first, however long ago they started. Each card says who couldn't make it ("Hannah Tane can't make it for Door & Offering on Sun 15 Nov"), then a bar of how the people asked to cover it answered: accepted (green), declined (red), didn't reply in time (amber) and still being asked (grey). Underneath, it says how the request ended: **Replaced by [name]**: that volunteer said yes. **Replaced on the Board by [name]**: you picked someone yourself on the Roster Board. **Still in progress**: Rostas is still asking. "Nobody asked yet" means the first ask hasn't gone out yet. **Ended without a replacement**: everyone suitable was asked, the date has passed, or a newer request started for the same slot. Lots of amber across the cards can mean your replacement timers are too short for how quickly your volunteers reply, or that quiet hours leave too small a sending window.
- **Communications Sent (7 days)** — how many messages went to volunteers each day: emails (navy), texts (gold) and app notifications (green). An app notification counts as App only when it was delivered; if it fell back to a text, it counts as SMS. Next to the key it says how many volunteers have the app with notifications on, so an empty green part can simply mean nobody needed a notification that week.

- **Activity (7 days)** — one bar per day. The number is how many log entries Rostas wrote that day. The colour is the worst thing that happened: green for no problems, amber for at least one warning, red for at least one error. For a red or amber day, pick that day in Message Logs to see what went wrong.

Below the charts, two things are worth checking regularly:

- **Message Logs** — a table of what Rostas did today, oldest first: every reminder, replacement ask, swap and roster message, with who it went to, how it was sent and how they answered. Use the date picker to look at an earlier day, and tick **Show system events too** to include behind-the-scenes events such as volunteer syncs and roster builds. Click **Key: what the colours and labels mean** above the table for a full explanation. In short: a pale red row means something failed and a pale yellow row is a warning (both always shown); in the Response column, green means the volunteer said yes, gold means still waiting, amber means no reply in time, and red means declined or not sent. This is your first-stop diagnostic: if a volunteer says they didn't get a message, pick that day and look for them.
- **Communication Failures** — the most direct troubleshooting tool, shown in the Warnings column. When all is well it reads "No comms failures"; otherwise it lists recent send errors and warnings. If a volunteer tells you they never received a replacement SMS, check here for an entry on the date in question. If you see nothing at all for that date, the message may have been suppressed before sending — check SMS enabled, test mode, and quiet hours.

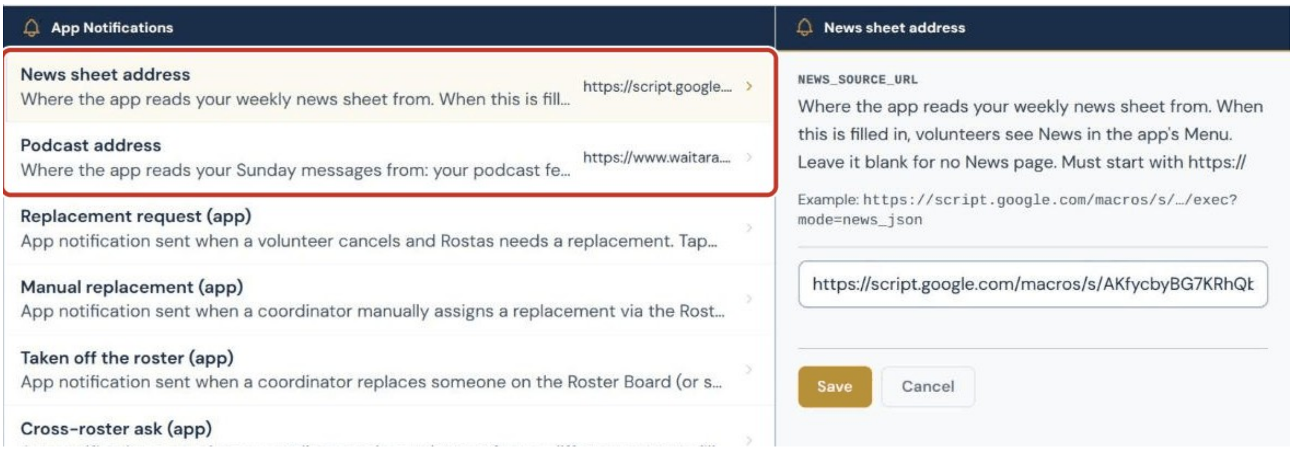
> Settings opening on Status makes this a habit without trying: glance at the verdict, fix any warnings, then do what you came to do. You'll catch problems before volunteers notice them rather than after.

Settings Categories

- **Organisation** — your organisation's name, tagline, timezone, country calling code, contact email, website, volunteer-facing logo, and the logo shown at the top of reminder emails (Email logo URL). The organisation name is the most important field: it appears in every SMS and email sent to volunteers as [OrgName]. Every email Rostas sends also comes from this name. Get this right first.
- **Coordinator Contacts** — your name, email and mobile, plus an optional coordinator for each roster (see A different coordinator for one roster). The “no replacement found” email goes to the **Organisation email** under Organisation, unless the roster has its own coordinator.
- **SMS** — the wording of every text Rostas sends (replacement request, manual replacement, taken off the roster, cross-roster ask, swap, availability nudge, reminder). Each has a live cost counter and a placeholder check. See Message wording below.
- **App** — what volunteers see in the Rostas app. At the top are two addresses: **News sheet address** and **Podcast address** (see News and podcasts in the app). Below them is the wording of the app notifications that stand in for texts when a volunteer has the app.
- **Email wording** — the text blocks in roster, reminder and swap emails (intro, arrival note, sign-offs).
- **Timing & Behaviour** — each roster's first rostered role start time, how many weeks ahead to build rosters, freeze weeks, availability form deadline, reminder timing and day-before reminder texts, SMS quiet hours, replacement timers, and public holiday region. The **Public holidays region** field includes a dropdown of supported countries and a "Fetch holidays now" button — use this to pull the latest public holidays for your country whenever you update this setting.
- **Quick Controls** — the on/off switches: SMS enabled, the three test modes (SMS, Email, App push), and a switch to show or hide each roster type on the Builds dashboard and the Board. It also holds the **Volunteer database** row, where you connect Infoodle, Planning Center or your own Google Sheet (see Choosing your volunteer database). Hiding a roster doesn't stop its reminders; to stop everything for a while, use **Pause roster** (Builds → ⋯).
- **Advanced** — settings that affect system internals (web app URL, licence key, roster type list, Infoodle and AWS SMS keys). These are locked by default. Click Unlock to edit in the right panel and read the warning carefully before changing anything here. Incorrect values can stop roster builds or break SMS links. Contact tech support if unsure.

News and podcasts in the app

The Rostas app can show your church's weekly news sheet and your recorded Sunday messages, as well as rosters. Each one is switched on by filling in an address under **Settings → App**:



News sheet address
Where the app reads your weekly news sheet from. When this is fill… https://script.google.…

Podcast address
Where the app reads your Sunday messages from: your podcast fe… https://www.waitara.…

Replacement request (app)
App notification sent when a volunteer cancels and Rostas needs a replacement. Tap…

Manual replacement (app)
App notification sent when a coordinator manually assigns a replacement via the Rost…

Taken off the roster (app)
App notification sent when a coordinator replaces someone on the Roster Board (or s…

Cross-roster ask (app)

`NEWS_SOURCE_URL`

Where the app reads your weekly news sheet from. When this is filled in, volunteers see News in the app's Menu. Leave it blank for no News page. Must start with https://

Example: `https://script.google.com/macros/s/…/exec?mode=news_json`

https://script.google.com/macros/s/AKfycbyBG7KRhQ

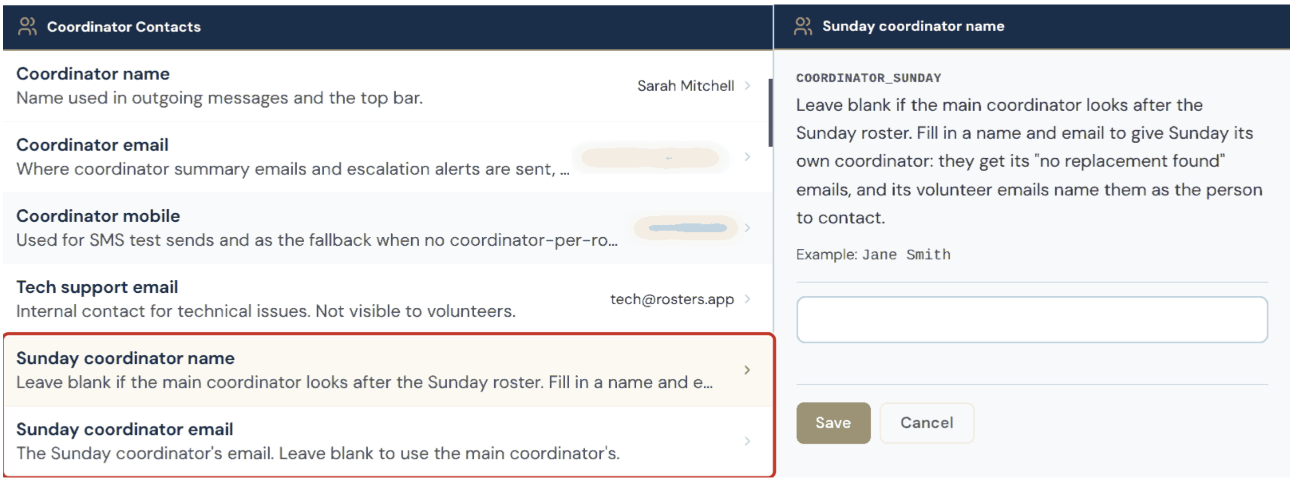
Settings → App. News sheet address and Podcast address sit at the top, above the app notification wording.

Leave an address blank and that page simply doesn't appear in the app. A changed address takes effect straight away for anyone who opens the page; volunteers' phones pick up a newly added Menu row within about three hours.

A different coordinator for one roster

You (the main coordinator) look after every roster unless you say otherwise. If one roster is run by someone else — say your music director runs the Music roster — give that roster its own coordinator:

1. Open **Settings** and click the **Contacts** chip.
2. Find that roster's rows, for example **Music coordinator name**, **Music coordinator email** and **Music coordinator mobile**.
3. Click **Music coordinator name**, type their name and click **Save**.
4. Do the same for **Music coordinator email**, and the mobile if you want it. Anything left blank uses your details.



Coordinator Contacts

Coordinator name — Sarah Mitchell
Name used in outgoing messages and the top bar.

Coordinator email — [redacted]
Where coordinator summary emails and escalation alerts are sent, ...

Coordinator mobile — [redacted]
Used for SMS test sends and as the fallback when no coordinator-per-ro...

Tech support email — tech@rosters.app
Internal contact for technical issues. Not visible to volunteers.

Sunday coordinator name
Leave blank if the main coordinator looks after the Sunday roster. Fill in a name and e...

Sunday coordinator email
The Sunday coordinator's email. Leave blank to use the main coordinator's.

Sunday coordinator name

`COORDINATOR_SUNDAY`

Leave blank if the main coordinator looks after the Sunday roster. Fill in a name and email to give Sunday its own coordinator: they get its "no replacement found" emails, and its volunteer emails name them as the person to contact.

Example: `Jane Smith`

Settings → Coordinator Contacts. Your own details come first; each roster's tiles follow. Leave a roster's tiles blank and you look after it.

From then on, for that roster only:

- the **“no replacement found”** email goes to them;
- volunteer emails for that roster (roster, reminder, availability, role preference and swap emails) say “get in touch with” them and are signed off with their name.

Everything else stays with you: emails that cover more than one roster, your coordinator link, and the test modes. Give each roster its own coordinator, or just the one or two that need it. To hand a roster back to yourself, clear its name and email.

Texts and their wording

Three settings here are worth understanding before you go live.

> **SMS enabled** (Quick Controls) — the master kill switch. When this is false, no SMS leaves Rostas at all — not replacements, not reminders, not test sends. The System Status card shows a red warning when this is off. Only disable it deliberately (e.g. during a migration or if you need to pause sending temporarily).

> **SMS test mode** (Quick Controls) — when true, every SMS that would go to a volunteer is redirected to the coordinator mobile instead. The message is prefixed with [TEST - would go to candidate]. Use this while setting up or testing replacement chains. Turn it off before your first real roster cycle. The System Status card shows an amber warning when test mode is on.

Quiet hours — SMS quiet hours start and end (Settings → Timing & behaviour) are set as times of day, e.g. 9:00 PM and 8:00 AM. Rostas will not send any SMS outside this window, including replacement chain advances. If a replacement request hits quiet hours, it waits until the quiet period ends before texting the next candidate. The default is 9pm–8am.

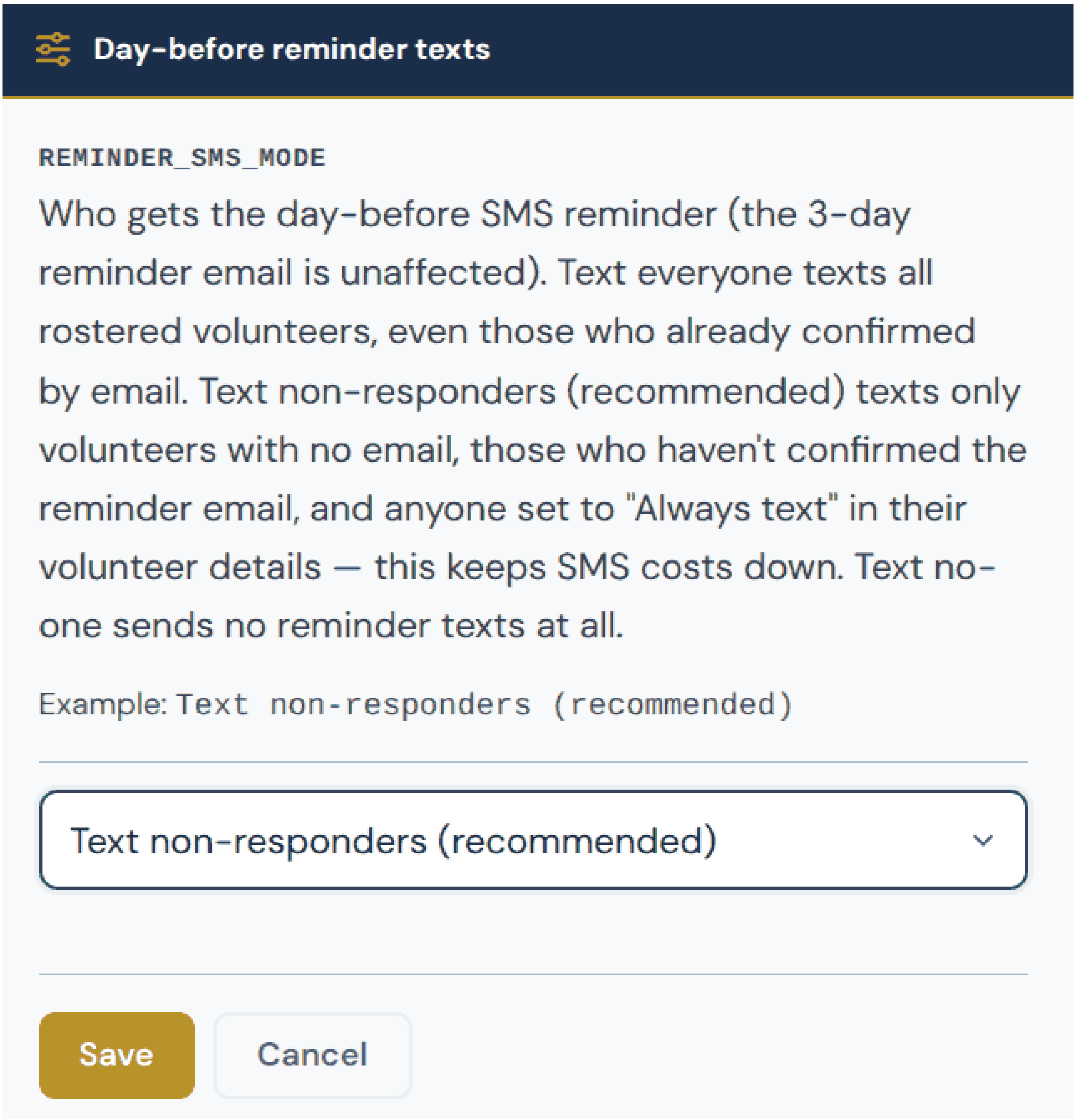
Replacement timers (Settings → Timing & behaviour) — three escalation speeds:

- **Normal** (default 120 min) — used when the service is more than 24 hours away
- **Urgent** (default 30 min) — used when the service is within 24 hours
- **Panic** (default 10 min) — used when the service is within 2 hours

If volunteers are frequently timing out before responding, consider increasing the normal timer. If you're often scrambling at short notice, reducing the urgent or panic timers gets through the candidate list faster.

Reminder SMS mode — controlling reminder texts

The day-before reminder text is the single biggest driver of SMS cost — one text per rostered volunteer, every rostered date. The **Day-before reminder texts** setting (Settings → Timing & behaviour) decides who actually receives it. (The 3-day reminder *email* is unaffected and still goes to everyone with an email address.)



Day-before reminder texts

`REMINDER_SMS_MODE`

Who gets the day-before SMS reminder (the 3-day reminder email is unaffected). Text everyone texts all rostered volunteers, even those who already confirmed by email. Text non-responders (recommended) texts only volunteers with no email, those who haven't confirmed the reminder email, and anyone set to "Always text" in their volunteer details — this keeps SMS costs down. Text no-one sends no reminder texts at all.

Example: `Text non-responders (recommended)`

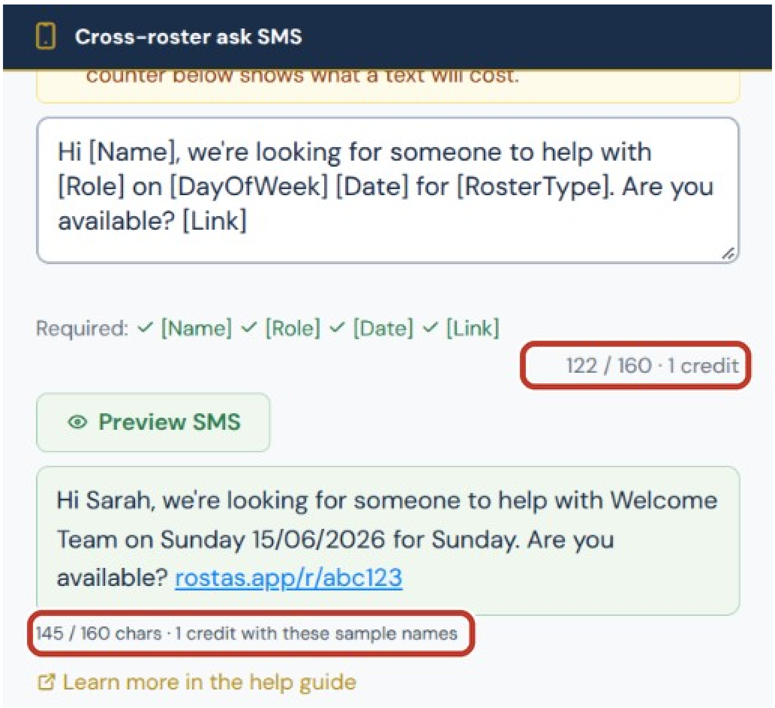
Text non-responders (recommended)

Reminder SMS mode — choose who gets the day-before text.

Text non-responders is the default, and the best value for most churches. It leans on free email and only spends a text where it'll actually help — someone with no email, or who hasn't confirmed. For the few volunteers who reliably miss email, turn on "Always text" on their profile so they still get a text under Text non-responders.

Message wording

Every SMS template has three protections built in to prevent accidental breakage.



counter below shows what a text will cost.

Hi [Name], we're looking for someone to help with [Role] on [DayOfWeek] [Date] for [RosterType]. Are you available? [Link]

Required: ✓ [Name] ✓ [Role] ✓ [Date] ✓ [Link]

122 / 160 · 1 credit

Hi Sarah, we're looking for someone to help with Welcome Team on Sunday 15/06/2026 for Sunday. Are you available? rostas.app/r/abc123

145 / 160 chars · 1 credit with these sample names

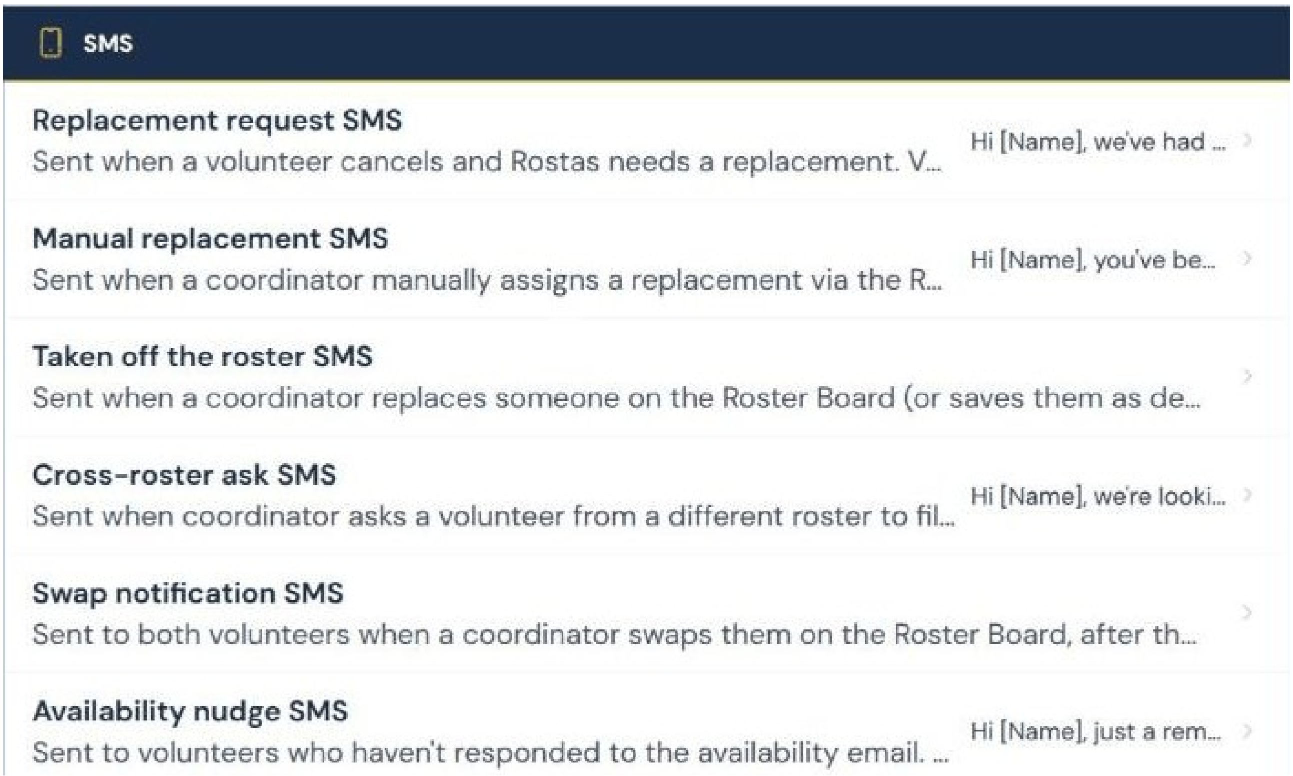
SMS template fields show a live counter of what the text will cost (characters, the limit, and credits), the required placeholder list, and a Preview SMS button. The Save button is disabled if the message would cost more than one credit or is missing a required placeholder.

- **Cost counter** — SMS messages over 160 characters are split into two by carriers and charged as two texts. The counter below the textarea shows what the text will really cost, for example *122 / 160 · 1 credit*. It turns amber when you're within 20 characters of the limit and red as soon as the text would cost more than one credit, and the Save button is disabled while it's red. The SMS templates are deliberately terse for this reason — when you edit one, the counter is protecting your church's SMS costs, not just formatting. Placeholders like [Name] count as typed; Preview SMS (below) shows the length once real names are filled in. Curly quotes (’ “ ”), long dashes (– —) and macrons (ā ē ī ō ū) are fine to type: Rostas swaps them for plain ones (' " - a e i o u) just before sending, and the counter already counts them as plain, so they cost nothing extra. **Avoid emoji** (smiley faces, praying hands and the like): Rostas can't swap them, and one emoji cuts the whole text's limit from 160 characters to 70. The counter shows this straight away (for example *62 / 70 · 1 credit (70 because of 🙏)*), and if the text is then over 70 characters, Save is blocked with a message naming the emoji to remove.
- **Required placeholders** — each template has a set of placeholders that must be present for it to work correctly. For example, the replacement request SMS must include [Link] — without it, the volunteer has nothing to tap. Missing placeholders are shown in red below the textarea. Save is blocked until all required placeholders are present.
- **Preview SMS** — click this button to see the template rendered with realistic sample values substituted in ([Name] → Sarah, [Role] → Welcome Team, [Date] → a sample date, [Link] → a sample link). This shows you exactly what a volunteer will read, with the characters and credits for that filled-in text (links are counted at their real length). Longer names or roles than the samples can push a text near the limit into two credits, so leave some room. It does not send a real SMS.

> All placeholder names use square brackets: [Name], [Role], [Date], [Link],

> [OrgName], [Deadline]. Never use curly braces — {name} will not be substituted.

Message wording lives in three categories: **SMS** (replacement request, manual replacement, taken off the roster, cross-roster ask, swap, availability nudge, reminder), **App** (the matching app notifications), and **Email wording** (roster email intro, arrival note and sign-off; reminder email opening, can't-make-it text and sign-off; swap email). The protections above apply to every text template.



SMS

Replacement request SMS
Sent when a volunteer cancels and Rostas needs a replacement. V...
Hi [Name], we've had ...

Manual replacement SMS
Sent when a coordinator manually assigns a replacement via the R...
Hi [Name], you've be...

Taken off the roster SMS
Sent when a coordinator replaces someone on the Roster Board (or saves them as de...

Cross-roster ask SMS
Sent when coordinator asks a volunteer from a different roster to fil...
Hi [Name], we're looki...

Swap notification SMS
Sent to both volunteers when a coordinator swaps them on the Roster Board, after th...

Availability nudge SMS
Sent to volunteers who haven't responded to the availability email. ...
Hi [Name], just a rem...

The SMS wording templates, including Taken off the roster SMS — each opens to an editor with its own cost counter and required placeholders.

Taken off the roster SMS (and **Taken off the roster (app)** under App) is the message a volunteer gets when you replace them on the Board, save them as declined with the tick box on, or take them off a roster with *Let them know* ticked — but only for dates whose roster had already gone out.

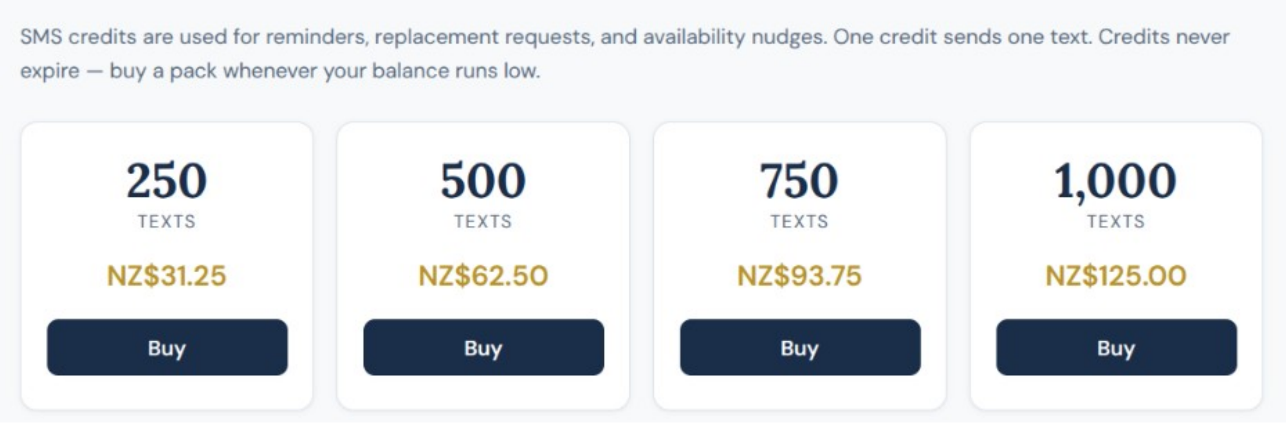
Template Placeholders

SMS and email templates use placeholders in square brackets that Rostas replaces with real values when sending. Never remove a required placeholder — if a required one is missing, the Save button is blocked.

SMS Credits

Sending SMS costs money — unlike email, every text has a real per-message cost from the mobile networks. Rostas covers this with a simple prepaid credit system: **one credit sends one text of up to 160 characters.** A longer text is split into parts and uses one credit per part, which is why the built-in wording is kept short. Every text uses them — reminders, replacement requests (automatic, manual and cross-roster), roster-change texts and availability nudges — and they never expire — you top up whenever your balance runs low.

> **Your first 20 SMS credits are free.** Every new Rostas subscription starts with 20 credits so you can try texts straight away. After that, texts use prepaid credits: buy a pack from the Buy SMS Credits page whenever your balance runs low.



SMS credits are used for reminders, replacement requests, and availability nudges. One credit sends one text. Credits never expire — buy a pack whenever your balance runs low.

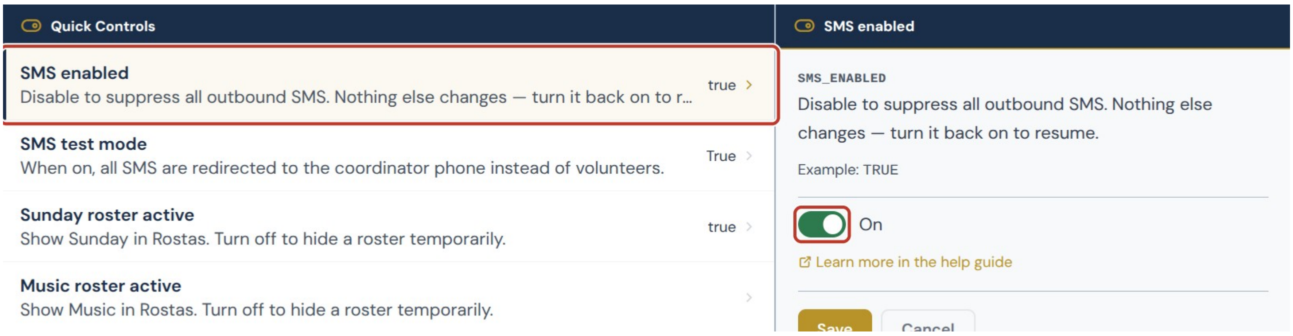
250 TEXTS	500 TEXTS	750 TEXTS	1,000 TEXTS
NZ$31.25	NZ$62.50	NZ$93.75	NZ$125.00
Buy	Buy	Buy	Buy

The Buy SMS Credits page — four prepaid packs. The large number is how many texts the pack buys; the price is below it. Credits never expire.

> **Keeping SMS costs down.** Reminders are the biggest driver of SMS use — one text per rostered volunteer before every rostered date. If you'd like to stretch your credits further, email reminders cost nothing, and you can rely on SMS mainly for the time-sensitive replacement chain. Your Rostas contact can help you tune this. If you change a text's wording, keep it under 160 characters and leave out emoji, or each text can cost two or three credits (see [Message wording]).

Switching rosters and test modes on or off (Quick Controls)

Quick Controls contains the most commonly needed on/off switches. Check these if something isn't behaving as expected.



SMS enabled
Disable to suppress all outbound SMS. Nothing else changes — turn it back on to r... true ›

SMS test mode
When on, all SMS are redirected to the coordinator phone instead of volunteers. True ›

Sunday roster active
Show Sunday in Rostas. Turn off to hide a roster temporarily. true ›

Music roster active
Show Music in Rostas. Turn off to hide a roster temporarily. ›

`SMS_ENABLED`

Disable to suppress all outbound SMS. Nothing else changes — turn it back on to resume.

Example: TRUE

On

Toggle fields in the right panel — a single switch with immediate visual feedback. The current state is always visible in the left panel list before you even click the row.

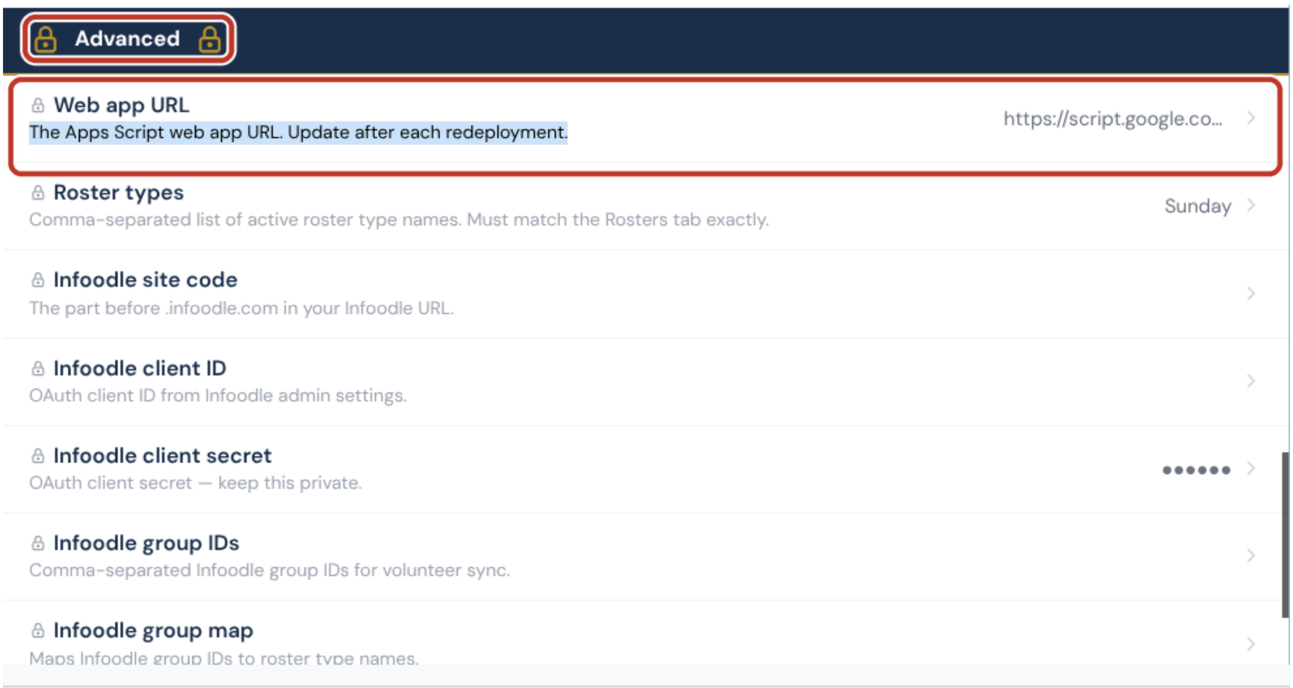
Always check test modes are OFF before sending a real roster.
While a test mode is on, that channel's messages come to you instead of volunteers: SMS test mode redirects texts, Email test mode redirects emails, and App push test mode redirects app notifications.

Advanced Settings

The Advanced section is collapsed by default and greyed out. It contains settings that the system needs to function but that coordinators rarely need to touch. Changing them incorrectly can cause roster builds to fail or SMS links to break.

To edit an advanced setting:

1. Click the **Advanced** chip at the top of Settings.
2. Click the setting's row.
3. Read the amber warning in the right panel.
4. Click **Unlock to edit**.
5. Change the value and click **Save**.



Web app URL
The Apps Script web app URL. Update after each redeployment.
https://script.google.co...

Roster types
Comma-separated list of active roster type names. Must match the Rosters tab exactly.
Sunday

Infoodle site code
The part before .infoodle.com in your Infoodle URL.

Infoodle client ID
OAuth client ID from Infoodle admin settings.

Infoodle client secret
OAuth client secret — keep this private.
••••••

Infoodle group IDs
Comma-separated Infoodle group IDs for volunteer sync.

Infoodle group map
Maps Infoodle group IDs to roster type names.

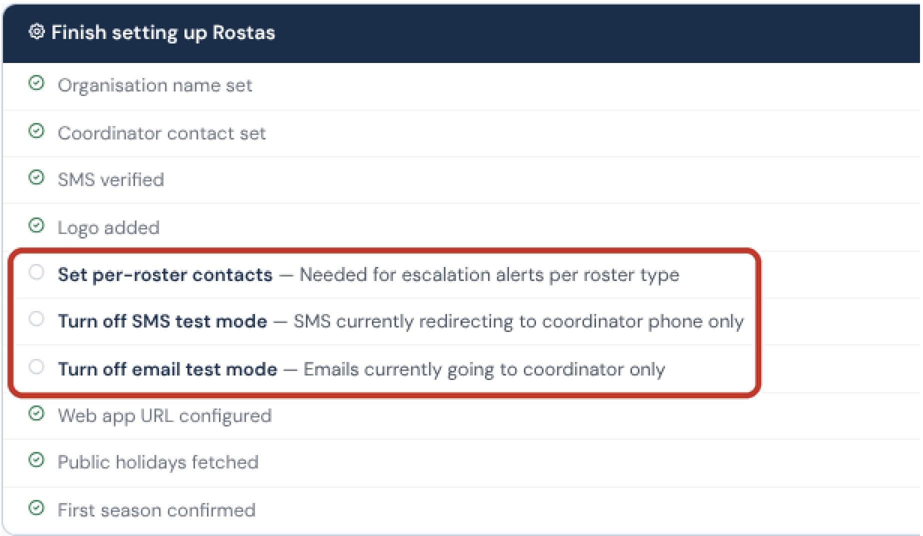
Advanced settings are collapsed by default and each row shows a lock icon. Click "Unlock to edit" in the right panel to make changes — only do this if you're confident about what you're changing.

You'll rarely need the Advanced section. Only change the **Web app URL** if Rostas support asks you to — if it's wrong, the links in texts and emails stop working.

> Advanced settings can break things if changed incorrectly. If you're unsure, leave them as they are or contact your tech support person before making changes.

Setup Checklist

After the initial setup wizard completes, a checklist card appears at the top of the Settings view. It shows which setup tasks are done and which still need attention before going live. The checklist covers ten items — click any incomplete item to jump straight to the relevant setting.



⚙ Finish setting up Rostas

- ✓ Organisation name set
- ✓ Coordinator contact set
- ✓ SMS verified
- ✓ Logo added
- ○ **Set per-roster contacts** — Needed for escalation alerts per roster type
- ○ **Turn off SMS test mode** — SMS currently redirecting to coordinator phone only
- ○ **Turn off email test mode** — Emails currently going to coordinator only
- ✓ Web app URL configured
- ✓ Public holidays fetched
- ✓ First season confirmed

The setup checklist — ticked items are confirmed complete by reading the current Config values, open circles need attention. Click any item to open the relevant setting. The card disappears by itself once every item is ticked.

The checklist goes away by itself once every item is ticked. To hide it sooner, click Dismiss; it won't appear again. If you dismiss it with items still incomplete, you can still fix them through the normal settings list — the checklist is a guide, not a gate.

Troubleshooting

Start from what you've been told or what you can see. Each problem lists the checks in order, most likely first, so you can usually stop after the first one or two.

> **Look at System Status first.** Settings opens on it. If something is switched off, in test mode or out of credits, it says so there, with a button that fixes it. See Following a warning to its fix.

“A volunteer says they never got a text”

1. **Did they get an app notification instead?** If the volunteer has the Rostas app with notifications on, Rostas sends an app notification and only texts if that doesn't arrive. Ask them to look in the app.
2. **Was it a day-before reminder?** With the recommended reminder mode, *Text non-responders*, anyone who already confirmed the reminder email doesn't get the text. That's by design. Turn on **Always text** on their profile if they'd rather have one every time. See Reminder SMS mode.
3. **Was it during quiet hours?** No texts go out overnight (9pm–8am unless you've changed it). A replacement request waits and goes in the morning.
4. **Is their SMS toggle on?** Open their profile. If **SMS** is off, they (or someone) opted them out of texts. Turn it back on only if they ask you to.
5. **Is their mobile number right?** Check it on their profile, digit by digit. It should be a full mobile number, such as `+64 21 123 4567`.
6. **Is SMS test mode on?** While it is, every text goes to your phone instead, starting `[TEST`.
7. **Still a mystery?** Look for that volunteer and date in the communication failures table in System Status. It says why a text didn't send.

“Nobody is getting texts”

1. **Are you out of credits?** System Status says “You're out of SMS credits”. Buy a pack; texts start again straight away. See SMS Credits.
2. **Is SMS turned off, or SMS test mode on?** Both show in System Status and in Quick Controls.
3. **Is it quiet hours?** Texts resume when they end.
4. **Is your subscription paid?** If a payment has failed, texts pause until it's sorted. Emails and app notifications keep working throughout.

“A volunteer replied to the text and nothing happened”

Rostas doesn't read replies to its texts, so a reply goes nowhere. Ask the volunteer to **tap the link** in the text instead: it opens a page where they answer Yes or No. If you already know their answer, record it yourself on the Board (Save as declined, or choose a replacement).

“A volunteer never got their roster email”

1. **Has the roster been sent?** Volunteers hear nothing until you click **Send notifications** in Step 6 of the roster cycle. See Step 6 — Notify.
2. **Is it in their spam or junk folder?** Ask them to look, and to mark it “not spam”.
3. **Is their email address right,** and is their **Email** toggle on? Both are on their profile.

4. **Is Email test mode on?** While it is, emails go to you instead.

“My link says the roster has changed” or “my link doesn't work”

- **“This roster has changed” or “someone else has already stepped in”** is Rostas working properly: they tapped an older message after things moved on. Nothing was changed. See When an old link no longer applies.
- **The link stopped working altogether** (an error or a sign-in page): if you recently issued them a new link, their old ones stop on purpose. Their next email or text carries the new one. See Issuing a new link. If it's happening to several volunteers, contact support.

“I was rostered on a date I said I couldn't do”

1. **Did they mark the date after the build?** Availability given after a build doesn't move anyone already placed. Before you send, **Rebuild roster** picks it up. After you send, click their card and use Save as declined: Rostas then finds a replacement.
2. **Did they mark it Not sure** rather than Can't make it? Then they're Pending (amber) and can say no from their link or the app.
3. Check their availability on their profile to see what Rostas has on record. See Availability on the profile.

“I built a roster and almost every card is red and empty”

When most or all of a new roster is red, the usual reason is that **no roles have been set for the volunteers yet**. Rostas only places a volunteer in a role they've ticked, so a volunteer with no roles on this roster is never used, however available they are. This is common on a brand-new roster, especially straight after importing volunteers.

1. **Find who has no roles.** On the Profiles page, pick the roster's pill and click **No roles set**. See Finding volunteers with no roles set.
2. **Set their roles.** Either set them yourself, profile by profile (the arrows step only through the volunteers still left to do), or ask the volunteers to choose in Step 3 — Role Prefs of the roster cycle.
3. **Build again.** Before you send, **Rebuild roster** on the Board places everyone afresh.

If only a few cards are red, see the next section instead.

“There are still red (unfilled) slots after the build”

1. **Have late availability replies come in?** Click **Refill roster** on the Board. It fills only the empty slots and leaves everyone else where they are.
2. **Do enough people do that role?** Only volunteers who ticked a role are rostered in it. If nearly every card is red, see Almost every card is red. Insights shows which roles are short.
3. **Are frequency caps holding people back?** Someone who has reached their cap isn't used again until it allows. See Frequency cap.
4. Fill the rest by hand: choose someone yourself, or ask someone from another roster.

“A card has said ‘In chain’ for ages”

1. **Is it quiet hours?** The chain waits overnight and carries on in the morning.
2. **Is the roster paused, or SMS turned off?** Check Builds → ··· and System Status.
3. **Has everyone been asked?** When the list runs out, Rostas emails that roster's coordinator (or your Organisation email). Check your inbox.

4. Don't wait: click the card and choose **Pick replacement** (see Choosing a replacement yourself). Once the slot is filled, the chain stops. If the original volunteer can come after all, choose **Keep [name], stop requests**.

“Why wasn't [name] asked to cover?”

Rostas only asks volunteers who have **ticked that role** on their profile, and leaves out anyone who marked themselves **unavailable for that date**. Frequency caps also apply. If you know they'd happily do it, tick the role on their profile, or choose them yourself on the Board.

“Sorry, unable to open the file at this time”

This Google message almost always means your browser is signed in to **more than one Google account**. Google can't tell which account should open Rostas, and you may see `u/1/` in the address bar. Rostas itself is fine.

- **Every day:** open Rostas from its icon in your Church profile (see Put Rostas on your desktop). That profile has only the church account in it, so the problem can't happen.
- **Right now, as a one-off:** open the link in a private window (Chrome: **Ctrl+Shift+N** on Windows, **⌘+Shift+N** on a Mac) and paste the address there.
- Deleting `u/1/` from the address doesn't help: Chrome puts it straight back. Signing in to the church account first doesn't help either.

When to contact tech support

Contact your tech support person if:

- SMS messages are failing with error messages in the System Status communication failures table
- Volunteer links have stopped working for several people (they open an error or a sign-in page)
- System Status says SMS isn't switched on for your account
- Something is producing repeated errors that don't resolve on their own
- Anything requiring access to the Google Apps Script editor

> **When contacting tech support**, include a description of what you were doing, what you expected to happen, and what actually happened. A screenshot of any error message or the System Status panel is very helpful.

Glossary

The words Rostas uses on screen and in this guide, in plain English. Each one links to where it's explained in full.

Connectors

Most organisations get their volunteers into Rostas by importing a CSV — it works for everyone and needs nothing more than a spreadsheet. But if your church or organisation already keeps its people in another system, or in a Google Sheet it keeps up to date, a **connector** can sync them into Rostas automatically, so you don't maintain two lists by hand.

> **Connectors sync identity only.** A connector brings across each person's *name, mobile, and email* — nothing more. Everything about *how* they serve — which rosters they're in, the roles they do, their frequency, who they serve with — is set up and lives entirely inside Rostas. Your other system stays the source of truth for contact details; Rostas stays the source of truth for rostering.

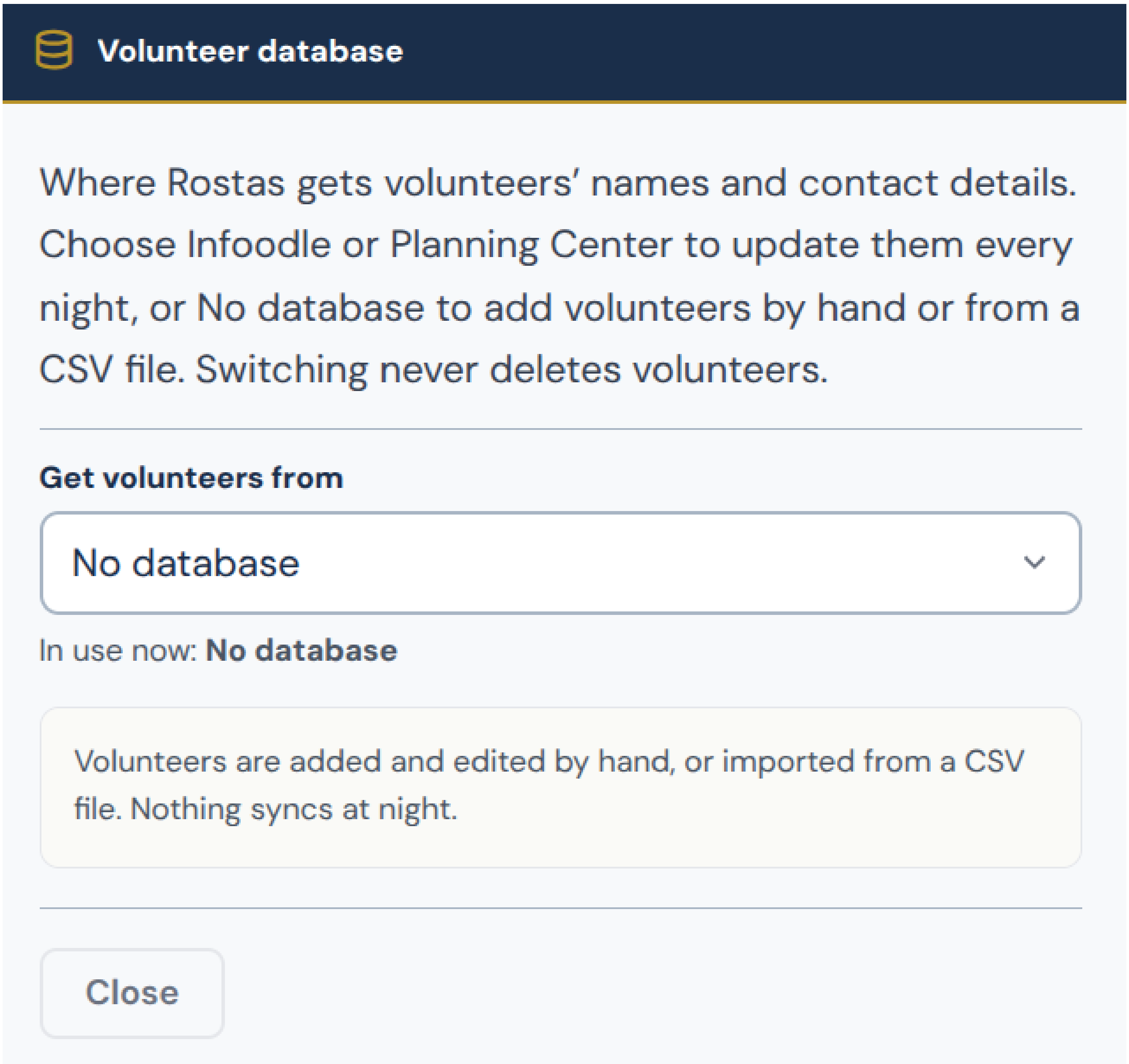
Choosing your volunteer database

Everything to do with connectors is in one place: **Settings → Controls → Volunteer database**. It is the last row in the Quick controls list. Click it and the panel opens on the right.

At the top of the panel, **Get volunteers from** has four choices:

- **No database** — you add volunteers by hand or from a CSV file. Nothing syncs at night. This is where every new Rostas starts.
- **Infoodle** — see Infoodle below.
- **Planning Center** — see Planning Center below.
- **Google Sheet** — your own list of volunteers in a Google Sheet. See Google Sheet below.

Only one database is used at a time. The line under the choice shows what is in use now and when it last synced, for example *In use now: Infoodle · last synced …*.



Volunteer database

Where Rostas gets volunteers' names and contact details. Choose Infoodle or Planning Center to update them every night, or No database to add volunteers by hand or from a CSV file. Switching never deletes volunteers.

Get volunteers from

No database

In use now: **No database**

Volunteers are added and edited by hand, or imported from a CSV file. Nothing syncs at night.

Settings → Controls → Volunteer database with No database chosen. The line under the choice shows what is in use now.

Switching database

Pick a different database, set it up (the steps are under each one below), then press the button that appears under the panel — **Use Infoodle for volunteers**, **Use Planning Center for volunteers**, **Use Google Sheet for volunteers**, or **Stop syncing volunteers**. Rostas asks you to confirm in a yellow box inside the panel before it changes anything, and tells you if the database you are switching to isn't connected yet.

> **Switching never deletes volunteers.** Everyone already in Rostas stays exactly as they are, with their roles, frequency and history. From the switch onwards, names and contact details are updated from the new database every night and whenever you press **Sync now**.

The sync status at the top of Settings

Across the top of Settings, a small **Volunteers** strip shows whether the connection is healthy and when it last synced, with a **Sync now** button to run a sync straight away. If no database is chosen it reads **Not connected** with a **Set up** button; if Planning Center needs attention it shows **Connect** or **Reconnect**; if Google Sheet is chosen but no sheet is saved yet it reads **No Google Sheet saved** with a **Set up** button. Each of those simply opens the Volunteer database panel.

Infoodle

Once Infoodle is connected, new and updated contacts flow in on their own — a volunteer added in Infoodle appears in your Profiles list without a re-import, and a changed phone number or email updates itself.

Where to find your Infoodle details

Rostas needs three things to connect: the **address** of your Infoodle site, a **Client ID** and a **Client secret**. You find all three in Infoodle itself — you don't need to contact Rostas or Infoodle support. In many churches the Rostas coordinator and the person who administers Infoodle are the same person; if that's not you, ask that person to follow these steps (or to sit with you while you do).

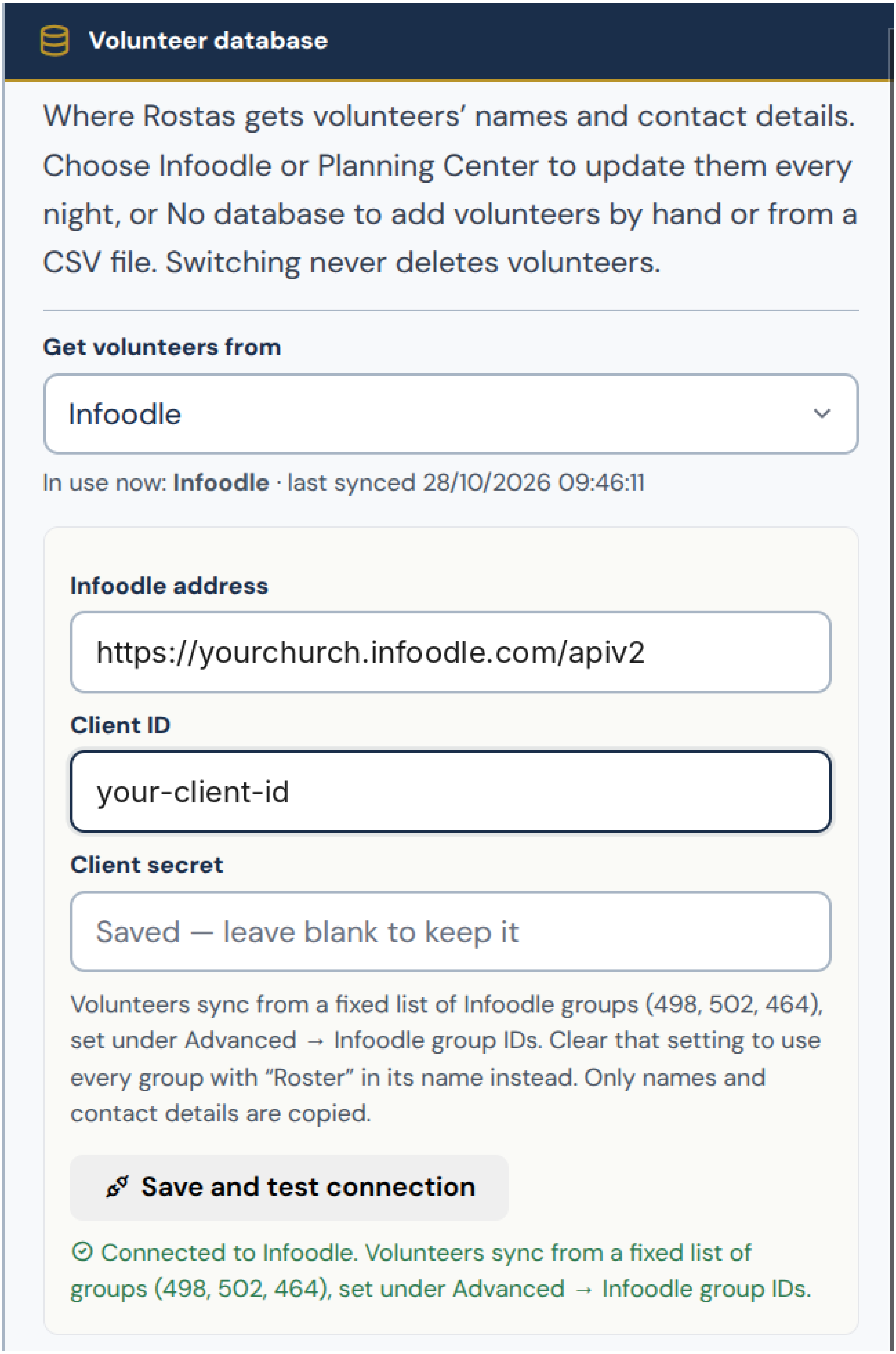
- **Infoodle address** — the web address you use to log in to Infoodle, followed by `/apiv2`. For example, if you log in at `https://yourchurch.infoodle.com`, the address to enter is `https://yourchurch.infoodle.com/apiv2`.
- **Client ID** — the **username you normally log in to Infoodle with**.
- **Client secret** — a code Infoodle creates for your login. To make it: Log in to Infoodle with the login you want Rostas to use. On your **Dashboard**, choose **My Account**. (To do this for someone else's login, open that person's own profile, click the settings cog and choose **Settings**.) Scroll to **API Credentials** at the bottom of the page and generate your secret. Infoodle shows a warning first — read it, then continue. **Copy the secret somewhere safe straight away.** It gives access to your church's Infoodle data, so keep it private and don't email it around. When you're back on the My Account page, the **Client secret** box now holds the number. Select **Authorise** to finish.

> - There is **one secret per Infoodle login**, and Rostas can see only what that login is allowed to see in Infoodle. Use a login that can see the groups your volunteers are in.
> - Consider creating a separate Infoodle login just for Rostas, rather than using one person's own login. That way the connection doesn't break if that person leaves, changes role or changes their password.
> - If the connection ever stops working — for example after the secret is changed in Infoodle — enter the current details in Rostas and press **Save and test connection** again.

Connecting Infoodle

1. Open **Settings → Controls → Volunteer database** and choose **Infoodle**.
2. Fill in **Infoodle address** (it must start with `https://`), **Client ID** and **Client secret**, using the details from Where to find your Infoodle details above.
3. Press **Save and test connection**. Rostas saves the details and signs in to Infoodle to check them. A green message confirms it worked; a red one says what went wrong.
4. Press **Use Infoodle for volunteers** and confirm.

If the test fails, **nothing is saved** — the previous details are put back — so a typo can never break a sync that was already working. Once the secret is saved, the box shows *Saved — leave blank to keep it*; you only retype it to change it.



Volunteer database

Where Rostas gets volunteers’ names and contact details. Choose Infoodle or Planning Center to update them every night, or No database to add volunteers by hand or from a CSV file. Switching never deletes volunteers.

Get volunteers from

Infoodle

In use now: **Infoodle** · last synced 28/10/2026 09:46:11

Infoodle address

https://yourchurch.infoodle.com/apiv2

Client ID

your-client-id

Client secret

Saved — leave blank to keep it

Volunteers sync from a fixed list of Infoodle groups (498, 502, 464), set under Advanced → Infoodle group IDs. Clear that setting to use every group with “Roster” in its name instead. Only names and contact details are copied.

Connected to Infoodle. Volunteers sync from a fixed list of groups (498, 502, 464), set under Advanced → Infoodle group IDs.

The Infoodle panel after Save and test connection. The green message confirms Rostas could sign in. The secret box reads “Saved — leave blank to keep it” once a secret has been stored.

Which people are synced

Rostas syncs the people in your Infoodle **groups with “Roster” in the name** — for example “Sunday Roster” or “Music Roster”. To add someone to Rostas, add them to one of those groups in Infoodle. If you press *Save and test connection* and no group has “Roster” in its name yet, Rostas tells you to rename the groups your volunteers belong to, and then press Sync now.

If your church was set up with a fixed list of group numbers (under **Advanced → Infoodle group IDs**), Rostas keeps using exactly that list, and the panel says so. Clear that setting if you would rather use the “Roster” name rule.

When someone is removed in Infoodle, Rostas doesn't delete them out from under you. Instead it flags them with a **"Deleted in Infoodle"** marker in the Profiles list, so you can confirm they should go and remove them here deliberately — protecting you from losing a volunteer's history by accident.

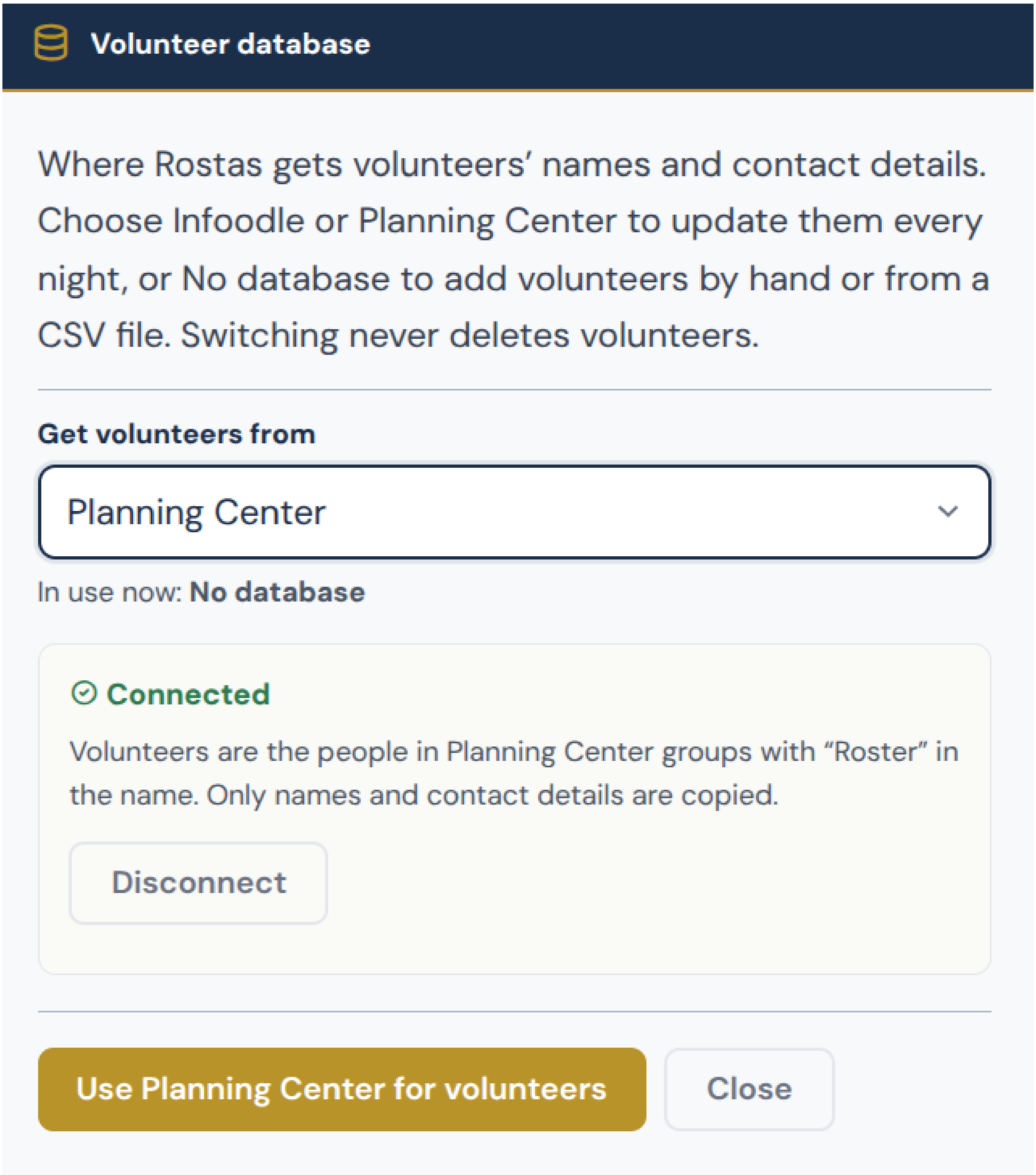
Planning Center

Planning Center connects by signing in to your Planning Center account — there are no codes or keys to copy.

Connecting Planning Center

1. Open **Settings → Controls → Volunteer database** and choose **Planning Center**. The panel shows *Not connected yet*.
2. Press **Connect Planning Center**. The button changes to **Open Planning Center sign-in** — click it. Planning Center opens in a new tab.
3. Sign in to Planning Center and approve the connection, then return to the Rostas tab. The panel says *Waiting for you to sign in…* and changes to **Connected to** your organisation's name as soon as you finish.
4. Press **Use Planning Center for volunteers** and confirm.

Your church needs its Rostas licence key in place before the sign-in will work; if the panel says so, contact support@rostas.app.



Where Rostas gets volunteers' names and contact details. Choose Infoodle or Planning Center to update them every night, or No database to add volunteers by hand or from a CSV file. Switching never deletes volunteers.

Get volunteers from: Planning Center

In use now: **No database**

Connected

Volunteers are the people in Planning Center groups with "Roster" in the name. Only names and contact details are copied.

The Planning Center panel once connected. Pressing Use Planning Center for volunteers switches over (after a confirmation); Disconnect removes the connection.

Which people are synced

As with Infoodle, Rostas syncs the people in your Planning Center **groups with "Roster" in the name** (archived groups are ignored). Someone who leaves all of those groups is marked inactive in Rostas rather than deleted, so their history is kept.

Reconnecting or disconnecting

If Planning Center stops accepting the connection — for example the sign-in has expired or was revoked — the strip at the top of Settings turns red and reads **Planning Center needs reconnecting**. Press **Reconnect** and sign in again; volunteers aren't affected in the meantime, they just stop updating.

To stop using Planning Center, open the panel and press **Disconnect**. Rostas asks you to confirm, and reminds you that volunteers already in Rostas stay exactly as they are.

Google Sheet

If your church keeps its volunteer list in an ordinary spreadsheet, Rostas can follow it. Keep editing the sheet as you do now; every night, and whenever you press **Sync now**, Rostas brings across new people and changed names, mobiles and emails.

How your sheet should look

- **One person per row**, with a heading row at the top. A title row above the headings is fine.
- A column headed **Name**, or two columns headed **First name** and **Surname**. This is the only column you must have.
- A column headed **Email**, and one headed **Mobile** or **Phone**. If you have both, Rostas uses Mobile. Common variations such as *Cell*, *E-mail* or *Last name* are recognised too.
- Any other columns are ignored, so you can keep notes, addresses or anything else in the same sheet.
- Type mobile numbers however you like (`021 555 0001`, `+64 21 555 0001`, `(021) 555-0001`); Rostas tidies them into one format.

> **Using Excel?** Upload the file to Google Drive, open it, and choose **File → Save as Google Sheets**. Then keep your list in that Google Sheet. A file on your computer or in OneDrive can't be synced; import it instead.

Connecting your sheet

1. Open **Settings → Controls → Volunteer database** and choose **Google Sheet**. The panel shows which Google account the sheet must be shared with.
2. In your sheet, press **Share**, add that account and choose **Viewer**. If you made the sheet with that same account, it's already shared and you can skip this step.
3. Copy the sheet's address from your browser's address bar and paste it into **Link to the sheet**. Rostas reads the tab that was open when you copied the link. To use a different tab, type its name in **Tab name**.
4. Press **Save and test**. Rostas reads the sheet and tells you which columns it found, how many people are listed, and what the next sync would change, for example *5 added, 0 updated, 1 listed twice (skipped)*. Nothing changes in Rostas yet. If something is wrong, the message in red says what to fix.
5. Press **Use Google Sheet for volunteers** and confirm, then press **Sync now** at the top of Settings. Your volunteers appear in **Profiles**.

What a sync does

- **New rows** become new volunteers. Only names, mobiles and emails come across; roles, rosters and frequency are set in Rostas as usual.
- **Changed rows** update the same volunteer. Rostas recognises people by their email, then their mobile, then their name, so you can fix a misspelt name or change a number without creating a second person.
- **A blank cell never wipes anything.** If you clear someone's email in the sheet, Rostas keeps the one it has.
- **Someone listed twice** (the same email or mobile on two rows) is added once. Rows with no name are skipped.

- **People already in Rostas** from before (added by hand, imported, or from another database) who are also on the sheet with the same email or mobile are left exactly as they are, so nobody is doubled up.
- **Someone removed from the sheet** is made inactive in Rostas, never deleted, so their history is kept. Add their row back and they become active again on the next sync.

> **A safety catch for big changes.** If the sheet is suddenly empty, or a sync would make more than half of the sheet's volunteers inactive (five or more people), Rostas changes nothing and the nightly sync stops there. This protects you from a sheet that was cleared or sorted by mistake. If the change is real, open the panel, press **Save and test**, and press **Yes, make them inactive and sync**.

To stop using the sheet, choose another database (or **No database**) in the panel. Volunteers already in Rostas stay exactly as they are.

Other connectors

Infoodle, Planning Center and Google Sheet are the connectors available today. Support for other church and volunteer platforms — such as Elvanto — is planned, so more organisations can sync rather than import over time.

> **Not on the list yet?** CSV import works with every system in the meantime — most spreadsheets and databases can export a CSV. If a connector for your platform would help, let your Rostas contact know; it helps prioritise what's built next.

Rostas Coordinator Guide · September 2026